

MCD to geo-map 1,300 heritage buildings

The tender forms and other details can be obtained from the PDA Office Noth AOC near Hotel Imphal. Sd/- Executive Engineer-III.	The tender forms and other details can be obtained from the PDA Office Noth AOC near Hotel Imphal. Sd/- Executive Engineer-III.
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Tahir Hussain was part of armed mob in 2020 riots: Court

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Tahir Hussain was a member of a heavily armed mob that assembled with “animus against Hindus” to commit rioting, loot and arson and murdered Ankit Sharma with a “savage and relentless assault”, a Delhi court has said in its verdict convicting the former AAP councillor and four others for the sensational killing of the Intelligence Bureau officer during the 2020 Northeast Delhi riots.

Additional Sessions Judge Praveen Singh, who acquitted Hussain and other convicts of the charge of criminal conspiracy (IPC Section 120B), said the prosecution proved beyond reasonable doubt that Hussain was a member of the unlawful assembly which had gathered with the object of rioting and committing loot and arson while the damaged and diverted CCTV cameras in the area suggested that “a conspiracy might have been afoot”, the prosecution failed to establish when, where and how such a conspiracy was hatched.

“The prosecution has successfully proved beyond all reasonable doubt that at the time of the incident, accused Tahir Hussain at around 5.00 pm on 25.02.2020, was a member of a large crowd and unlawful assembly which, with animus against Hindus, had assembled at Chand Bagh Pulia with a common object to commit rioting, loot, arson and to cause damage to the property and person of the members of the Hindu community; and that the members of this assembly knew that it was likely that in prosecution of the objects of this assembly, death could result and someone could be killed,” the judgment said.

In the 320-page detailed order dated July 13 made available on Tuesday, the court, which had acquitted six of the 11 accused,



Tahir Hussain

said members of the unlawful assembly surrounded and dragged the officer towards Chand Bagh Pulia. His body was later found in a drain there.

“Tahir Hussain was a member of a large crowd and unlawful assembly which, with animus against Hindus, had assembled at Chand Bagh Pulia with a common object to commit rioting, loot, arson and to cause damage to the property and person of the members of the members of the Hindu community,” the order said

The court said that the mob was heavily armed, used violence, indulged in rioting, arson and loot, and prosecution had successfully established that the members of the unlawful assembly knew that, in pursuing their common object, “death could result and someone could be killed”.

“It is established that the members of this assembly had surrounded and dragged Ankit Sharma towards Chand Bagh Pulia and had thereby abducted him, where after, in a savage and relentless assault upon his person, had murdered him,” said the court, which has listed the matter for arguments on sentence for July 23.

The judge noted that Hussain was part of the mob which was

gathered in violation of the Section 144 CrPC imposed in that area and convicted him under IPC Section 188 (disobedience to order duly promulgated by public servant).

“Being a member of this unlawful assembly, accused Tahir Hussain, in view of Section 149 IPC, is vicariously liable for the aforesaid offences,” the court said while convicting Hussain under Sections 302, 365, 147, 148, 153A and 188 of the IPC read with Section 149.

The judge also noted that the prosecution had proved through the testimonies of eyewitnesses, corroborated by other witnesses, that Hussain was present at Chand Bagh Pulia around 5 pm on February 25, 2020, as part of the unlawful assembly.

The court convicted Hussain under IPC sections 302 (murder), 365 (Kidnapping or abducting with intent secretly and wrongfully to confine person) read with 149, 147 (punishment for rioting), 148 (rioting with deadly weapon), 153A (promoting enmity) and 188 (Disobedience to order duly promulgated by public servant) read with 149 (rioting).

However, Hussain was acquitted of IPC Sections 120B (criminal



Ankit Sharma

conspiracy) and 109 (punishment for abetment) read with 149, with the court saying that the prosecution failed to prove beyond reasonable doubt that he had instigated the offences committed by the unlawful assembly.

On the charge of criminal conspiracy, the court said that while the damaged and diverted CCTV cameras in the area suggested that “a conspiracy might have been afoot”, the prosecution failed to establish when, where and how such a conspiracy was hatched or who its conspirators were.

The court also convicted Nazim, Kasim, Javed and Anas for the same offences. The court noted they were among those who surrounded and dragged IB officer Sharma towards Chand Bagh Pulia before he was fatally assaulted, making them vicariously liable for murder and other offences under Section 149 IPC.

The court acquitted Haseen alias Mullaji alias Salman, Firoz, Gulfam, Soyab, Sameer Khan, Muntajim alias Musa in the case. According to the complaint, Sharma, who was posted with the Intelligence Bureau, had returned home from office on February 25, 2020, before stepping out again.

CM Rekha slams AAP over verdict

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A day after a Delhi court convicted former AAP councillor Tahir Hussain in the murder case of Intelligence Bureau (IB) officer Ankit Sharma, the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) on Tuesday stepped up its attack on the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) and the Congress, claiming the verdict had exposed the true nature of the 2020 Northeast Delhi riots. Chief Minister Rekha Gupta and Law Minister Kapil Mishra on Tuesday slammed the AAP, accusing it of providing political patronage and protection to Tahir Hussain who was convicted in connection with the 2020 Delhi riots a day ago.

AAP leaders Arvind Kejriwal, Sanjay Singh and Manish Sisodia are answerable for the “political conspiracy”, the CM said regarding the former AAP councillor's conviction. With Hussain's conviction, victims of the riots and others affected by it have got justice, she told reporters.

In a statement, the Chief Minister said, “The AAP leadership must explain its political association with and patronage of a person who has been found guilty of instigating the Delhi riots, murder and widespread violence. She said that during the Delhi riots, the national Capital witnessed a horrific phase of violence, stone-pelting and lawlessness, in which many people lost their lives and numerous families were affected.”

She further added that those events continue to leave several unanswered questions in the minds of the people of Delhi. She said, “AAP extended protection and political patronage to

KEJRIWAL, SANJAY SINGH AND MANISH SISODIA ARE ANSWERABLE TO THE PEOPLE OF DELHI. A POLITICAL CONSPIRACY WAS HATCHED AND THE PEOPLE WILL NEVER FORGIVE THEM

CHIEF MINISTER REKHA GUPTA



AAP LEADERS WERE PROVIDING RELIEF CAMPS IN OTHER COMMUNITY AREAS AT THE TIME OF THE RIOT, AND NOW THEY ARE PRESENTING THEMSELVES AS FOLLOWERS OF SANATAN TRADITIONS

LAW MINISTER KAPIL MISHRA



Tahir Hussain who caused pain to thousands.” “Kejriwal, Sanjay Singh and Manish Sisodia are answerable to the people of Delhi. A political conspiracy was hatched and the people will never forgive them,” the Chief Minister added.

Earlier addressing a press conference, Law Minister Kapil Mishra said, “Why are Arvind Kejriwal, Manish Sisodia and Sanjay Singh silent after the conviction? Why have they not come forward and said anything on the matter?” Mishra questioned why the then Delhi Government and its leaders did not speak out during the riots against Sharma's killing or visit the victims.

Referring to the conviction, Mishra said the court's decision had established Hussain's role in the murder and alleged that the matter raised questions about those who had earlier

supported or defended him. He also questioned AAP leaders over their statements at the time of the riots, alleging that they had not shown concern for the victims.

“AAP leaders were providing relief camps in other community areas at the time of the riot, and now they are presenting themselves as followers of *Sanatan* traditions,” he added.

Earlier, AAP chief Arvind Kejriwal on Tuesday hit back at the BJP over its remarks on former AAP councillor Tahir Hussain, saying he was expelled from the party long ago and later joined the AIMIM. “We expelled him from AAP long, long back. Didn't he join one of ‘chanda chor’ party's sister organisations?” Kejriwal said in response to BJP leader Amit Malviya's post on X linking Hussain's conviction in the 2020 Delhi riots case with the AAP.

DU announces ECA quota trial dates

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi University (DU) on Tuesday released the detailed schedule for physical trials under the Extra-Curricular Activities (ECA) quota for undergraduate admissions, with category-wise and registration number-wise reporting slots scheduled between July 16 and July 25.

The schedule has been issued as the university continues the undergraduate admission process through the Common Seat Allocation System (CSAS) portal.

Physical trials for several categories, including dance, debate, music (vocal) and theatre, will begin on July 16, while yoga trials will commence on July 17. Quiz trials will be held on July 20, creative writing on July 21, and digital media, divinity and instrumental music categories from July 21 onwards.

Dance trials at Bharati College have been scheduled from July 16 to 25 across Indian Classical, Indian Folk, Western and Choreography sub-categories, while debate trials at Ramjas College will be held from July 16 to 25 for both Hindi and English categories.

Creative Writing (Hindi) candidates will appear for their trial on July 21 at 2 pm,



while English candidates have been divided into two batches on the same day based on registration numbers. Hansraj College has been designated as the trial centre for the category.

The university has designated separate nodal colleges for different ECA categories. Bharati College will host dance trials, Ramjas College debate, and Miranda House theatre, Mata Sundri College for Women for vocal music, Sri Aurobindo College (Day) instrumental music, Hansraj College creative writing, and Maharaja Agrasen College digital media.

Similarly, Atma Ram Sanatan Dharma College will host trials for fine arts, Rajdhani College divinity, Zakir Hussain Delhi College

(Evening) quiz and PGDAV (Evening) College yoga.

Theatre trials at Miranda House and Indian Classical and Light vocal music trials at Mata Sundri College for Women will continue till July 25 and July 22, respectively, with candidates assigned reporting slots according to their registration numbers.

Fine arts trials, including sketching, painting and sculpture, will be conducted at Atma Ram Sanatan Dharma College from July 20 to 24, while digital media trials covering photography, filmmaking and animation will be held at Maharaja Agrasen College from July 21 to 23. The university said no physical trials will be conducted for the NCC and NSS categories.

In a note accompanying the schedule, the university said outstation candidates may request rescheduling of their trials to any day within the notified date range for the respective ECA category by writing to the admission branch.

However, no requests will be entertained after the trials for a category conclude. It also clarified that requests for changing the trial date will not be accepted for the Creative Writing and Quiz categories, as these are being held on a single day.

Parvesh Singh reviews live trial of patching technology

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Government's Public Works Department Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh on Tuesday witnessed a live trial of spray injection patching technology. The fully mechanised pothole repair method that can fix 100 to 150 potholes per day using a single machine works during the monsoon when conventional methods cannot be deployed.

The new technology can open repaired roads to traffic within minutes, with the minister saying wider adoption will be explored if the trial meets expectations.

The technology works through a single machine that cleans the pothole using high-velocity air, applies a bonding coat of bitumen emulsion, and then injects emulsion-coated aggregate under high pressure. Compaction is achieved through the injection velocity itself, meaning no rolling equipment is needed. Each pothole is repaired in two to five minutes.

The all-weather capability is what makes it particularly relevant for Delhi's monsoon problem. Conventional pothole repair methods require dry conditions and



cannot be used effectively during rain, which is precisely when potholes form fastest on Delhi's roads. Spray injection patching can be deployed in wet and cold conditions, allowing repair work to continue through the season rather than being suspended when the need is greatest.

On durability, the technology delivers a significantly longer repair life than conventional cold-mix patches. The bitumen emulsion bonds the fill material to the pothole walls, giving a repair life of several years. Standard cold-mix patches typically fail within weeks, making them an expensive short-term fix rather than a genuine solution. The elimination of repeat patching cycles at the same locations is one of the key economic arguments for the technology.

The operational footprint is minimal. The machine is

mobile and self-contained, requires no lane closures, and involves a small crew. The road opens to traffic immediately after each repair. The process is also cold-applied, meaning no hot-mix plant operation is needed, resulting in significantly lower fuel consumption and emissions. Since only the required quantity of material is mixed and sprayed on site, there is no material wastage.

The technology is not experimental in an Indian context. Road agencies in Jammu and Kashmir, Haryana, Maharashtra, Madhya Pradesh, Goa, Karnataka, and Telangana have already adopted spray injection patching for rapid, durable road maintenance. Its track record across multiple states in varied geographic and climatic conditions provides a basis for

NEW TECHNOLOGY CAN OPEN REPAIRED ROADS TO TRAFFIC WITHIN MINUTES, WITH MINISTER SAYING WIDER ADOPTION WILL BE EXPLORED IF THE TRIAL MEETS EXPECTATIONS

assessing how it would perform in Delhi.

Singh said today's trial was the first step in evaluating whether the technology fits Delhi's requirements. “If the trial meets our expectations, we will explore its wider adoption to strengthen Delhi's road maintenance system. Our focus is to embrace proven, modern technologies that deliver better roads, greater efficiency and a smoother travel experience for the people of Delhi,” he said.

Delhi is in the middle of its monsoon season, when pothole complaints spike sharply, and the Government's road maintenance systems come under the most pressure. The PWD has already deployed 200 maintenance teams, 754 permanent pumps, and 305 temporary pumps across the city for monsoon management.

Govt plans bronze statue of Vajpayee

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Rekha Gupta Government is planning to install a 15-foot-tall bronze statue of former Prime Minister Atal Bihari Vajpayee at Azadpur Roundabout in north Delhi.

Along with the statue, the Public Works Department (PWD) will undertake several beautification and infrastructure works, including improved lighting, landscaping of the roundabout, and repairs to the nearby foot over bridge (FOB).

“We plan to install the sculpture, manufactured using best practices and accepted engineering standards, at the roundabout, weighing around 1,500 kg,” a PWD official said. Vajpayee, who was the first prime minister of India from the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP), was also the founding president of the party.

“The PWD plans to hire a company which will design and install the sculpture at the roundabout, a tender has been floated in this regard and the work has to be completed in three months,” the official added.

MCD recorded 28% increase in food business licences in new regime

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) has recorded a nearly 28 per cent increase in food business licences in the first month of its new licensing regime, with officials now planning surprise inspections to ensure establishments comply with the revised framework. The civic body issued 895 “deemed licences” between June 9 and July 10, compared to around 700 licences granted during the same period last year, according to official data.

The increase comes after the MCD replaced its conventional health trade licensing system with a “deemed licence” regime for 67 categories of food businesses as part of the Government's ease-of-doing-business reforms.

Under the new system, food establishments no longer need to obtain a separate MCD health trade licence. Instead, an FSSAI registration or licence, along

with the payment of the municipal fee, is treated as an MCD licence.

Officials said the simplified process has made it easier for businesses to obtain licences, but acknowledged that the actual number of food establishments operating under the new system could be higher than the official figures.

“Several businesses have obtained FSSAI registrations but are yet to pay the municipal fee, which is mandatory for the deemed licence to become effective. Many owners are under the impression that obtaining an FSSAI certificate alone is sufficient, but that is not the case. The deemed licence comes into force only after the municipal fee is deposited,” a senior MCD official said

To identify such establishments, the civic body is now planning a series of inspections across the city.

“We have already begun inspections, and these will be intensified in the coming weeks. There will be random

and surprise inspections, particularly at high-risk establishments. The objective is to verify whether businesses have completed the deemed licensing process, paid the municipal fee and are complying with the applicable provisions. Wherever violations are found, action will be taken,” the official said.

While the new regime has reduced paperwork for businesses, it has also raised questions within the civic body and among urban planning experts over the scope of scrutiny before food establishments begin operations.

Under the earlier system, applicants seeking an MCD health trade licence had to submit a range of documents, including building-related records, layout plans and, in certain cases, fire safety clearances. The licensing process was also linked to provisions of the Master Plan for Delhi (MPD)-2021, ensuring that food businesses operated only in areas where such commercial activity was permissible.

The revised framework no



NEW RULES

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longer makes compliance with the Master Plan a condition for obtaining a deemed health trade licence. Instead, it provides that FSSAI guidelines will be adopted for issuing such licences, while placing the responsibility for ensuring public safety and protection of property on the licensee.

Officials clarified that an

FSSAI registration certifies only food safety and hygiene standards. It does not certify compliance with building by-laws, fire safety norms, occupancy limits, and structural stability or land-use regulations.

“An FSSAI licence is essentially a food safety certification. Compliance with other laws continues to be mandatory, but those aspects are no

longer examined as part of the deemed licensing process. They are dealt with separately by the enforcement agencies concerned,” another senior MCD official said.

The policy has also revived concerns over the possibility of more food businesses operating in non-conforming areas, where the existing land use does not match the

land use prescribed under the Master Plan.

Experts said that while the deemed licence enables a business to operate from the food safety perspective, it does not exempt the establishment from action if it violates land-use norms, building regulations or fire safety requirements, and cautioned that removing these checks from the licensing stage could weaken regulatory oversight.

“The Hauz Rani fire showed how a licence issued for one kind of activity was allegedly being used for something entirely different. Earlier, multiple documents were scrutinised before a health trade licence was granted. Now, much of the responsibility shifts to inspections after the business has already started operating,” a former civic body official and an urban planning expert said.

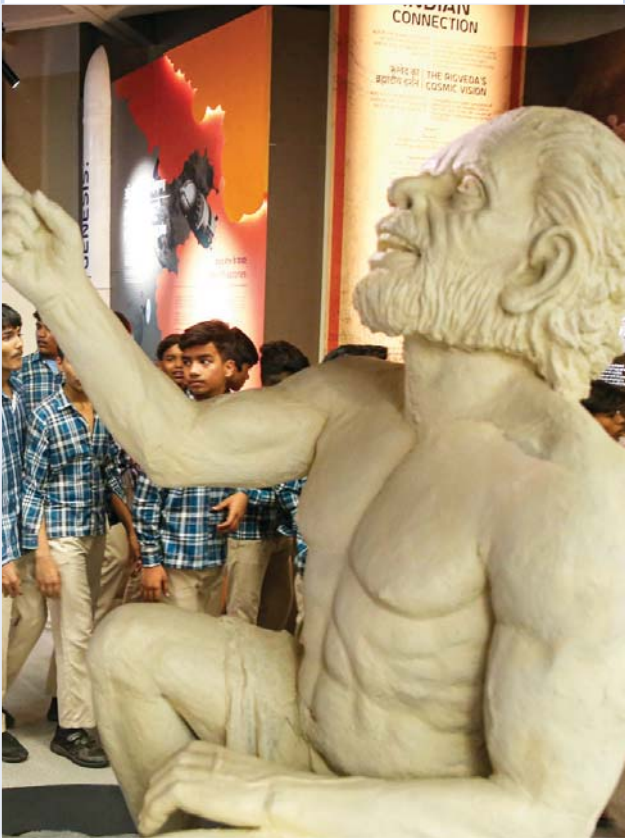
He said the concern was particularly in non-conforming localities, many of which have narrow lanes, congested neighbourhoods and inadequate infrastructure.

“These areas were never planned for intensive commercial activity. If restaurants or other food establishments begin operating without adequate scrutiny, it can create safety risks and make emergency response more difficult. Enforcement, therefore, becomes even more important under the new system,” he said.

Under the Master Plan for Delhi, non-conforming areas are those where the existing use of land differs from the use permitted under planning norms, such as commercial establishments operating in residential neighbourhoods without the requisite approvals.

Municipal officials, however, said the reforms were aimed at simplifying approvals and bringing unlicensed food establishments under the regulatory framework. They maintained that the deemed licence does not exempt businesses from complying with safety norms and said that action will be taken if violations are found.

IN FOCUS



Students visit the Space Exploration Gallery at the Regional Science Center in Bhopal on Tuesday

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DELHI GOVT DEMOLISHES SHRINE BUILT ON GOVT LAND

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

■ New Delhi

Taking action against illegal construction, the Delhi government on Tuesday demolished an shrine built on Government land in the middle of a road. According to the Chief Minister's Office (CMO), the action was part of the government's drive against illegal encroachments and aimed to remove obstacles delaying the road expansion project, which is expected to improve traffic flow on the busy corridor.

"The road-widening project is intended to provide a smooth and obstruction-free route for commuters travelling between Pitampura and Shalimar Bagh," the CMO said. The demolition also forms part of a wider crackdown on unauthorised structures that hinder public infrastructure projects and affect road connectivity across the national capital. The CMO said that the city Government has adopted a zero-tolerance policy towards illegal construction and encroachments on government land.

Notably, the anti encroachment drive has intensified in recent weeks. Since June 1, authorities have demolished 94 illegally constructed buildings and sealed 114 others for violations of building byelaws and fire safety norms.

The Government said the crackdown gathered pace after the June 3 Malviya Nagar fire tragedy. Since then, 63 buildings have been demolished, with the largest single-day action recorded on June 3 when 22 structures were razed.

Ladakh cracks down on conversions

Investigators say Jerry spent nearly ten years creating a dictionary of local dialects before translating the Bible into Bodhi and Zanskari. Police investigations found that he launched the "Zanskari Bible" app on the Google Play Store, first using his own name and later under "WIN Publication Trust" to hide his identity. The app has since been removed from all platforms.

Jerry arrived in Ladakh in 2010, worked briefly in Leh, and moved to Zanskar in 2011 to work as a private guide. Over the years, he built connections in the area as a teacher and tourist guide. Locals say he distributed Christian books translated into Ladakhi and gave solar lanterns and food supplies to low-income families and widows. He said he was linked to the Chennai-based NGO "B Team Trust" and confirmed he registered a trust in Zanskar. His wife and two children live in Padum, where the children attend a private school. Jerry's name appeared on the voter lists for Village Tazsar, and, later, Padum. Still, local objections prevented him from voting in the 2023 LAHDC Kargil and 2024 parliamentary elections in the Zanskar electoral roll.

On 17 June 2026, Ladakh Police conducted another operation against an alleged conversion network in Zanskar, Changthang, and the Aryan Valley. They arrested eight people connected to FIR No. 126/2026. Officers also seized laptops, digital devices, and materials related to religious conversion, including Bibles. These items are now being examined to understand how far the network extends. Ladakh Police say these actions are meant to protect the region's identity, which they believe is threatened by proselytisation.

Authorities are monitoring financial transactions to determine the extent of outside involvement. Police emphasise that anyone who breaks the law will face legal action and say they are committed to keeping peace, harmony, and Ladakh's cultural heritage. Officials say these cases reveal ongoing, well-funded, and technol-

ECI approves ₹6,000 honorarium to BLOs and supervisors for SIR

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

The Election Commission of India has approved a one-time honorarium of Rs 6,000 to each Booth Level Officer and BLO Supervisor engaged in the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls. This amount will be given in addition to their annual remuneration, recognising the volume and nature of work involved in the ongoing door-to-door enumeration exercise, according to a letter dated July 14, 2026, signed by ECI Secretary Pawan Diwan.

The letter, bearing reference number 23/BLO/2026-ERS, has been addressed to the Chief Electoral Officers of 22 states and Union Territories: Andhra Pradesh, Arunachal Pradesh, Chandigarh, Dadra and Nagar Haveli and Daman and Diu, Haryana, Jharkhand, Karnataka, Maharashtra, Manipur, Meghalaya, Mizoram, Nagaland, NCT of Delhi, Odisha, Punjab, Sikkim, Telangana, Tripura, and Uttarakhand. All have been directed to bring the instruction to the notice of all concerned for compliance.

The honorarium is described as a one-time grant, separate from the BLOs' annual remuneration. The Special



Intensive Revision is a large-scale door-to-door exercise in which Booth Level Officers visit every household in their assigned area to verify existing voter details, help residents enrol, and identify electors who have died, permanently moved, or are registered at multiple addresses. The enumeration phase runs from June 30 to July 29, 2026, with BLOs required to return to homes found locked on the first visit at least three more times.

In Delhi alone, more than 13,000 BLOs have been deployed across 13 districts to cover the capital's electorate of 1.45 crore voters. As of July 5, the cumulative distribution of enumeration forms in Delhi had already crossed 62

lakh, representing over 42 percent of the city's total electorate. The pace of work, conducted largely in the monsoon heat through residential lanes and housing colonies, represents a significant operational undertaking for the ground-level election machinery. The honorarium decision reflects the Election Commission's acknowledgment that the SIR exercise demands a level of effort from BLOs that goes beyond their routine electoral roll maintenance duties. BLOs are typically Government employees, teachers, or other officials assigned polling booth responsibilities in addition to their regular work.

The intensive enumeration phase of SIR requires sustained field presence across an extended period, making the additional payment a recognition of that extraordinary workload.

Following the close of the enumeration phase on July 29, the draft electoral roll will be published on August 5. Citizens will be able to file claims and objections until September 4, with final disposal of applications by October 3 and publication of the final electoral roll on October 7. The qualifying date for the revision is October 1, 2026.

Wangchuk's health worsens on day 17 of Jantar Mantar protest

PRIYANSHI SHANDILYA ■ New Delhi

The Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) protest at Jantar Mantar has now lasted 26 days. Activist Sonam Wangchuk is on a hunger strike that has reached its 17th day, and three students have joined him for the same duration. Protesters say the Government has not answered their calls for dialogue, policy changes, or the removal of Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan.

CJP founder Abhijeet Dipke posted on X that Wangchuk's health has worsened during the hunger strike. Dipke said Wangchuk has lost over eight kilograms and is feeling weak and dizzy. Organisers said that with three students now joining the hunger strike, supporters are more concerned and are urging the government to start a dialogue before things get worse.

All day, protesters stayed under makeshift shelters at Jantar Mantar,



Climate activist Sonam Wangchuk being attended by a medical professional during a protest by CJP demanding Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan's resignation over alleged irregularities in the NEET examination at Jantar Mantar in New Delhi

PTI

holding signs calling for education reforms and chanting against reported exam problems.

Volunteers handed out water and helped those on hunger strike, while supporters gathered at the

NCPI likely to be invited to all-party meet; Sudip Bandyopadhyay to be floor leader

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

■ New Delhi

Lok Sabha MPs Sudip Bandyopadhyay and Kakoli Ghosh Dastidar, who have left the Trinamool Congress (TMC) and joined the Nationalist Citizens Party of India (NCPI), are likely to be the floor leader and chief whip respectively of the little-known outfit, which is expected to be called for an all-party meeting to be held ahead of the Monsoon session of Parliament.

The two MPs from West Bengal, who revolted against



Kakoli Ghosh Dastidar

the TMC leadership along with 18 other parliamentarians last month and subsequently announced that they had joined the NCPI, met Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla on Monday and discussed with him seating arrangements for the party's 20 MPs in the Lower House, sources said.

During their meeting with the speaker, the NCPI leaders also discussed the allotment of a party office in the new Parliament building, the sources added.

The MPs who have switched to the NCPI have informed Birla that they have designated Bandyopadhyay

as their floor leader, Satabdi Roy as the deputy leader and Ghosh Dastidar as the chief whip. The meeting comes ahead of the Monsoon session of Parliament starting July 20 and amid the process of according parliamentary recognition to the NCPI as a constituent in the ruling Bharatiya Janata Party-led National Democratic Alliance (NDA).

The NCPI has been asked to submit a party resolution extending support to the NDA and the Narendra Modi Government, the sources said. Bandyopadhyay also met Home Minister Amit

Shah recently, they said.

The NCPI is expected to submit a formal communication to the speaker's office, seeking parliamentary recognition.

The NCPI is also likely to be invited to the all-party meeting to be held on July 19.

The meeting of Bandyopadhyay and Ghosh Dastidar with Birla assumes significance as petitions have been filed by the TMC seeking the disqualification of the 20 MPs who have quit the party and joined the NCPI. TMC leader in the Lok Sabha Abhishek Banerjee has met Birla and submitted

20 separate petitions seeking the disqualification of the rebel MPs under the 10th Schedule of the Constitution. He has argued that the MPs have voluntarily given up the membership of the TMC by joining another party and are, therefore, liable to be disqualified.

Banerjee has also urged the speaker not to accord any recognition, status or facility to any group claiming to be a separate faction of the TMC. The sources said the issue of the disqualification petitions did not come up during Monday's meeting of the MPs with the speaker.

FROM PAGE - 1

standing proxy relationship between LeT and the Pakistan Army.

"LeT has changed its tactics since 26/11 to keep up with India's new security measures. The resumption of training at Mangla Dam shows that the group's goals have not changed. India should remain alert and continually update its countermeasures", intelligence sources added.

Strait of Hormuz faces fresh chaos and fire

Iran responded with attacks targeting Kuwait, Jordan and three tankers that traveled through the strait. In Bahrain, which hosts the US Navy's 5th Fleet, air raid sirens sounded on four occasions Tuesday as authorities told people to seek shelter.

Two of the targeted ships were associated with the United Arab Emirates and were set ablaze for a time. The International Maritime Organization said the attack on the tankers Mombasa and Al Bahiyah killed two mariners and wounded 14 others. The UAE threatened to retaliate.

Dutch shipping firm Stolt Tankers said that one of its ships came under attack. The attack on the Stolt Magnesium off Oman sparked a fire in the engine room, but the company said all the mariners were safe.

Iran's paramilitary Revolutionary Guard said the Mombasa and Al Bahiyah "ignored repeated warnings." Iran has targeted ships that use a route through the strait that passes near Oman outside of its territorial waters.

Hours after the US said it ended its campaign of strikes, the Iranian city of Bushehr on the Persian Gulf was hit in at least four locations, the state-run IRNA news agency reported. The attacks again raised the possibility that Gulf Arab states were retaliating against Iran without discussing it in public.

The European Union Aviation Safety Agency warned airlines against operating in the airspace of Bahrain, Kuwait, Qatar and the United Arab

Emirates, as well as over the Gulf of Oman.

Exchanges of fire in recent days had already cast doubt on the interim peace deal - now almost halfway through the 60-day period in which negotiators were supposed to agree to a final accord, which also was meant to address Iran's disputed nuclear program and other issues.

Washington lifted a blockade it imposed in mid-April as part of the deal. The US military said it will resume it at midnight Wednesday in Dubai.

Under the interim deal, Iran agreed that passage through the strait would remain free of charge for 60 days - but the agreement left open what would happen after. Iran asserts it has the right to manage traffic through the strait and potentially charge fees. The US has disputed that.

The price for a barrel of Brent crude oil, the international standard, briefly topped \$87 early Tuesday, still well below the nearly \$120 reached at the height of the war. The price dipped to \$78 in the aftermath of Trump's announcement that he had changed course.

Regional mediators are still trying to get the US and Iran back to the negotiating table, according to two regional officials.

The officials, speaking on condition of anonymity to discuss the delicate diplomatic process, said Pakistan-led mediation was working around the clock to reactivate the ceasefire. (AP)

West Bengal withdraws OBC appeal

The SC allowed the withdrawals on conditions however that it would be open to hearing independent petitions if interested and aggrieved parties would come forward challenging the Calcutta High Court judgment.

The HC had, in May 2024, quashed the State's decision to include 77 communities in the State's OBC list out of which 75 came from the Muslim community asking how a community which comprised only 30 percent of the State's population could fill 75 out of 77 communities.



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

■ Thane/Mumbai

An investigation to trace a 50-year-old man, who went 'missing' nearly a year ago, has unravelled a ghastly murder, leading to the arrest of his wife and her paramour who allegedly chopped his body into pieces and dumped the remains in a forest in Navi Mumbai, police said on Tuesday.

The murder committed in August last year came to light recently after the victim's brother raised suspicion about his disappearance. The police then questioned the woman and her paramour, who confessed to the killing and throwing the body parts in a forest, the Rabale MIDC police station house officer said.

The victim, Baliram Suryanath Kushwaha, lived with his wife Sunita (40) and their two children in Airoli, Navi Mumbai.

According to investigators, Sunita had an extramarital affair with Rahul Dashrath Prajapati (30), an autorickshaw driver. When Baliram discovered the relationship and opposed it, the duo hatched a conspiracy to eliminate him, the official said.

On the night of August 9, 2025, after sending the children to a relative's house, the accused allegedly strangled Baliram while he was sleeping and slit his throat, he said.

To erase all traces of the crime, they chopped his body into three parts, wrapped the remains in sacks, and transported them in Prajapati's autorickshaw to the Gawli Dev hill forest, dumping the pieces at separate locations, the official said. Sunita later rented out their family home and moved to Ghansoli in Navi Mumbai with her children. The horrific crime

remained buried until April this year, when Baliram's brother visited Sunita and grew highly suspicious of her evasive explanations about his brother's sudden disappearance, prompting him to lodge a missing persons complaint.

To evade being caught, the accused frequently changed their phones and SIM cards. However, the Call Detail Records (CDR) showed constant communication between the two, the police said.

Police analysed call detail records, changes in mobile numbers, and inconsistencies in the statements of both accused. Sustained interrogation allegedly led to their confession, exposing the entire murder conspiracy. During a sustained interrogation, the duo 'confessed' to the crime. They were arrested on Sunday and booked under sections 103 (murder), 238 (destruction of evidence) and 3(5) (common intention) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, the official said.

The police have recovered some remains of the deceased from the dense Gawli Dev forest, and a search is underway for the other body parts, he said.

Following the arrest, the two accused were produced before a local court, which remanded them to seven-day police custody, the official added.



MEA clarifies stand on passport as row over SIR grows

ASHOKE RAJ ■ New Delhi

The Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) on Tuesday clarified that an Indian passport is a travel document issued to regulate the departure of Indian citizens from the country and is not meant to serve as proof of citizenship, amid a growing political debate over its use in electoral roll revisions.

MEA spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal emphasised that passports are granted only after thorough verification as per established procedures under the Passports Act, 1967 and the Passports Rules, 1980. He also

noted that less than eight per cent of Indian citizens currently hold a passport.

The clarification comes in response to questions regarding remarks made by senior MEA officials during Passport Seva Divas on June 24. Officials had described the passport as a travel document for visiting foreign countries and explicitly stated it is not a document to prove citizenship.

The comments were made in the context of the Election Commission's ongoing Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls in several states, where questions arose about whether



MEA spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal

passports could be accepted as proof of citizenship.

The remarks triggered sharp criticism from opposition parties, particularly the Congress, which accused the Government of attempting to create grounds to arbitrarily deny citizenship rights to certain individuals.

Addressing the controversy directly, Jaiswal stated: "An Indian passport is a document that, as per the Passports Act, 1967, is issued by the Government of India to regulate the departure from India of citizens of India."

"It is issued after due verification laid out by an estab-

lished process. The issue of passports to Indian citizens or any other individual is governed by The Passports Act, 1967 and Passports Rules, 1980," he added.

The MEA has maintained that while the passport confirms the holder's identity and nationality for international travel, it does not function as primary evidence of citizenship in domestic legal or administrative processes such as voter list revisions.

The fresh clarification aims to put an end to the political controversy and underscore the limited scope and purpose of the passport document.

India supports UN membership for Palestine: MEA



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

India has backed Palestine's bid for United Nations membership and reaffirmed its support for a two-state solution to the festering conflict between the Palestinian people and Israel.

New Delhi's position on Palestine was apprised by Sripriya Ranganathan, a secretary at the external affairs ministry, during a ministerial meeting of the Palestine Donor Group, held in Brussels on Monday. India has been backing a vision of a "two-state" solution with Israel and Palestine living side by side in peace and security within recognised borders,

consistent with international law. At the Palestine Donor Group meeting, Ranganathan emphasised that India has been a long standing partner of the Palestinian, and reaffirmed India's continued support to a two-state solution as well as to Palestine's membership of the UN, according to the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA).

She underlined India's ongoing developmental assistance, including capacity building programmes and humanitarian assistance to the people of Palestine, noting that India's projects are demand-driven and largely centred on healthcare, education, capacity building, and vocational training, it said.

ED arrests Ebix Chairman Vikas Garg in ₹6,000 crore Mahadev betting probe

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi

The Enforcement Directorate (ED) arrested Vikas Garg (53), chairman of the Ebix Group, on Tuesday in connection with a money-laundering case tied to the Mahadev online betting syndicate. Officials said Garg was taken into custody under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA) after ED teams searched his Delhi home. He was brought before a special court in the capital, which gave the agency 24 hours to take him to Raipur, Chhattisgarh, where the main investigation is underway.

This is the 14th arrest in the case. Last week, the ED temporarily seized assets worth ₹940.77 crore belonging to Garg, his family, and related entities. This action is part of the investigation into illegal online betting by Mahadev Online Book and Skyexchange.

The agency says that



money from the betting syndicate was moved through companies owned and controlled by Garg, using a complex hawala network for cash transfers. The funds were allegedly laundered through platforms and websites like Tiger Exchange and Gold365, as well as through shell companies and multiple transactions.

The Mahadev betting app case involves suspected illegal earnings of ₹6,000 crore and has been connected to several top politicians and officials from Chhattisgarh. The ED describes the Mahadev app as

a major international betting syndicate that enabled illegal betting via online platforms and websites such as Tiger Exchange, Gold365, and Laser247.

The operation used a franchise network of 'panels' and 'branches' run by associates across India. According to the ED, the main promoters, Sourabh Chandrakar and Ravi Uppal, managed the betting syndicate from Dubai. So far, five charge sheets have been filed in a special PMLA court in Raipur, naming 74 accused entities.

The agency has also asked the court to declare

Chandrakar, Uppal, and others, including Anil Agrawal (also known as Atul) and Shubham Soni, as fugitive economic offenders under the Fugitive Economic Offenders Act, 2018. Garg's arrest, as a well-known business leader, is a major step in the investigation. It shows how the syndicate is accused of using complex methods to make betting money look legitimate. Investigators are expected to question Garg in Raipur about the movement of funds and his suspected role in the laundering.

The case continues to reveal links between illegal online betting operations run from outside India and local networks that move and hide the money. With Chandrakar recently detained in Oman and extradition in progress, the ED is focused on breaking up the syndicate's finances and recovering the illegal earnings. More arrests and asset seizures are expected as the investigation goes on.

TMC split: Mamata and rebel camps clash over rally venue

SAUGAR SENGUPTA ■ Kolkata

Amid the ongoing dogfight within the Trinamool Congress — between the faction led by former Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee and present Opposition Leader Ritabrata Banerjee — for the party's bank deposits, symbol and office a new dispute has erupted over the venue of Trinamool Congress Martyrs' Day rally that has been organised for the past 15 years in front of the CESC House at the Esplanade Crossing one of the busiest junctions in the country.

Interestingly, the Mamata Banerjee faction is not interested in holding the July 21 Trinamool Congress Martyrs' Day rally at the Brigade Parade Ground as has been offered by the Kolkata Police, sources in her faction said.

Following a writ petition, a single-judge bench of Justice Sougato Bhattacharya of the Calcutta High Court had earlier admitted a petition from the Mamata Banerjee faction challenging the two-month prohibitory order around CESC House near the busy Esplanade Crossing. The petition would be heard on July 15.



Former Bengal Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee

While the breakaway faction led by MLA Ritabrata Banerjee, which too had been asking permission for the CESC House venue, has reportedly been given to hold its version of the Martyrs' Day rally in front of the Mahatma Gandhi statue in near Jawahar Lal Nehru Road little less than 800 metres from CESC House, the Mamata faction is still insisting on CESC House or as an alternative the Dorrina Crossing.

A senior police officer, referring to the dispute, said that it would be impossible to grant the Mamata faction a place at Dorrina Crossing as

the venue would be "precariously close to the one given to the other group," leaving a good chance of clashes.

"The Police are giving us Brigade Parade Ground which besides being too large for getting it filled within a span of two weeks is also muddy during the monsoons... they are doing it intentionally to disturb us... but we will go ahead with programme even if that means holding a rally from a pick up van," said TMC MP Dola Sen hoping "the High Court will appreciate our problem and issue appropriate directions."

US national nabbed at Nepal border with Chinese passport

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ Lucknow/Maharajganj

A 36-year-old American who said his name was Jordan Brown from California was arrested on July 11 while trying to cross into Nepal on an unauthorised footpath near the Sonauli border in Maharajganj district, Uttar Pradesh. Security forces found a Chinese passport and other items on him, prompting a multi-agency investigation. Brown said he served in the US Navy and Special Forces, but officials have not confirmed this.

Sashastra Seema Bal (SSB) officers stopped Brown during a routine patrol in the Mainihwa area, near border pillar 516 under Sonauli police station. This part of the India-Nepal border is busy and connects Maharajganj in Uttar Pradesh with Bhairahawa in Nepal. Police said Brown was stopped for verification as he approached the border. He reportedly tried to run into Nepal, pushing past SSB officers and local people, but villagers helped catch him. He did not have a valid passport, visa, or any identity documents at the time.

Maharajganj Superintendent of Police Shakti Mohan Awasthi said,



"He was not carrying documents that could confirm his identity. He identified himself as Jordan Brown, a resident of California, United States. We have informed the US Embassy about him." Police registered a case at Sonauli police station under Sections 21 and 23 of the Immigration and Foreigners Act. Brown was brought

before a local court and sent to judicial custody.

During questioning, Brown said he served in the US Navy and the Special Forces for about 6 years and left 2 years ago. He also said he studied at the University of California, that both his parents have died, and that he has travelled to nearly 70 countries. Brown said he met an Indian yoga

instructor from Uttarakhand in Italy about three years ago and married her in October 2024. He told police he planned to go to Nepal to meet a Nepalese person named Naz, whom he met in Goa. He also said someone he knows in Bengaluru has his passport.

Brown gave conflicting accounts about when he arrived in India and his movements near the border. He said he went to Thailand on a tourist visa last year and lost his documents there. He claimed he travelled by sea to Sri Lanka and entered India illegally around November 2, 2025. He also said he came to Goa from the United States about two months ago, after visiting Bali, Indonesia, in May. He said he stayed in Goa for six weeks, then went to Bengaluru. From there, he took a bus to Lucknow on July 8, went to Gorakhpur, and then took a taxi to Sonauli. He told police he spent time in Goa, then went to Noida, and later reached Maharajganj to cross the river.

UP Police officials noticed inconsistencies and unclear details in his contacts and plans, which raised concerns during questioning. These discrepancies in dates (espe-

cially the 2025 vs 2026 arrival claims) and routes are why multiple central agencies are conducting detailed verification of his identity, travel history, and movements of approximately 8 months (from early November 2025 to July 11, 2026). He had no valid Indian visa or passport during this entire period, according to authorities.

Items found with him, including a Chinese passport, are being checked by forensic and intelligence teams. However, the officials say they have not found any evidence of espionage or anti-national activities so far, but the investigation is ongoing. Central intelligence and security agencies have questioned Brown. Authorities are checking his identity, claimed military background, travel history, movements in India, and possible local contacts.

Police are also checking if anyone in India helped him reach the border. UP Police have informed the US Embassy, as is standard for foreign nationals. The investigation is ongoing. Officials say there is no immediate security threat, but they are being extra cautious because of the border location and Brown's unverified claims of military service.

Ladki Bahin Scheme: Congress accuses Maharashtra Govt of cheating women

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

The Congress on Tuesday accused the BJP-led Mahayuti Government in Maharashtra of cheating women by removing nearly 38 per cent of beneficiaries of the Mukhyamantri Majhi Ladki Bahin Yojana after the 2024 assembly elections. Speaking at a press conference in Delhi, Maharashtra Congress spokesperson Atul Londhe Patil alleged that the State Government excluded around 62 lakh women citing non-completion of e-KYC and another 1.8 lakh women on the ground that they were above 65.

Why the Government had collected their Aadhaar details at the time of application if they were later found to be ineligible on age grounds, he sought to know.

Making e-KYC mandatory unfairly affected poor women, many of whom did not own smartphones, while the captcha-based verification process was too complicated for illiterate beneficiaries, the Congress leader said.

He also claimed the Government was going to remove more beneficiaries and nearly 38 per cent of women enrolled under the scheme had been excluded.

The Congress leader alleged that the scheme was introduced in haste ahead of the 2024 Maharashtra assembly elections for electoral gains, and the promised increase in the monthly assistance from ₹1,500 to ₹2,100 was not implemented after the polls.

Citing a report of the Comptroller and Auditor General (CAG), Londhe alleged that the Government spent



Maharashtra Congress spokesperson Atul Londhe Patil

₹33,237 crore against the approved allocation of ₹29,732 crore and failed to explain the additional expenditure of about ₹3,500 crore.

He demanded that the State Government complete the e-KYC process for all eligible women through the administration, restore ben-

efits to those excluded on that ground, and release their pending instalments.

The Congress also sought an independent inquiry into the implementation of the scheme, alleging irregularities, inclusion of ineligible beneficiaries, inclusion of men and Government

employees, and misuse of public funds. Meanwhile, in Mumbai, Shiv Sena spokesperson Sanjay Nirupam rejected allegations of irregularities in the scheme.

He said the beneficiaries who were found ineligible after the e-KYC verification process had received the monthly assistance of ₹1,500 for the past ten months, and their eligibility was reviewed strictly as per the scheme's rules.

Nirupam said around 29,000 men had wrongly received benefits under the scheme, but Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis has assured the State Assembly that the amount paid to them would be recovered.

The Shiv Sena leader demanded that the Government extend the deadline for completion of the e-KYC process.

NC leader Mustafa Kamal dies at 83

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Srinagar

Veteran National Conference leader and former Jammu and Kashmir minister Sheikh Mustafa Kamal died at a private hospital in Srinagar on Tuesday following a prolonged illness, his family said. He was 83.

Kamal, the younger brother of National Conference (NC) president Farooq Abdullah and uncle of Chief Minister Omar Abdullah, was the additional general secretary of the party.

He was laid to rest at a graveyard in the Sonwar area of the city. Apart from the Abdullahs, ministers, NC's MPs and MLAs, and a host of other leaders joined the funeral prayers for the departed soul.

Before joining politics,



Jammu and Kashmir Chief Minister Omar Abdullah, National Conference President Farooq Abdullah and others offer funeral prayers for senior National Conference leader and former Jammu and Kashmir minister Sheikh Mustafa Kamal, in Srinagar on Tuesday

Kamal earned his MBBS degree from the Sawai Mansingh Medical College in Jaipur, Rajasthan, in 1962.

He later built a distinguished legislative career and became a member of the Jammu and Kashmir

Legislative Council from 1983 to 1987. Kamal represented the Gulmarg constituency in Baramulla district as an MLA from 1987 until 2002. Throughout his political career, he held various high-profile Cabinet portfolios.

States Focus



95% OF JHARKHAND VOTERS COVERED UNDER SIR: OFFICIAL

Booth-level officers (BLOs) have reached nearly 95 per cent of Jharkhand's 2.64 crore electors under the ongoing Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls, an official said on Tuesday. The enumeration exercise began on June 30 and will continue till July 29, during which BLOs are conducting door-to-door visits to distribute, collect and verify enumeration forms.

"BLOs have successfully reached out to 94.96 per cent of the total electorate, covering 2,51,28,733 voters, and made enumeration forms available to eligible Indian citizens through house-to-house visits," an official in the Chief Electoral Officer's office said.

He said more than 41.27 per cent of the enumeration forms have been digitised so far. (PTI)



KERALA CELEBRATES ASTRONAUT ANIL MENON'S JOURNEY TO ISS

People of the State celebrated and felt proud as Kerala-origin NASA astronaut Anil Menon flew to ISS on Tuesday. He is the great-grandson of former Indian National Congress chief Sir C Sankaran Nair. Kerala Governor Rajendra Vishwanath Arlekar congratulated Menon, whose roots lie in the Ottapalam area of Palakkad district.

In a Facebook post, Arlekar said that he was fortunate to have visited Menon's ancestral home last year to pay tributes to Sir Nair.

"Hearty congratulations and best wishes to Anil Menon, the pride of Kerala, in his historic space odyssey. I have had the fortune of visiting his ancestral home, Chettur House at Ottappalam, a year back, to pay tributes to Anil Menon's great-grandfather, late Sir C Sankaran Nair," he said.

Menon took off for the International Space Station (ISS) on board the Soyuz MS-29 spacecraft as part of Expedition 74. Chief Minister VD Satheesan on Saturday had congratulated Menon on his achievement and termed his journey to the ISS as a "truly historic milestone" for the State. (PTI)

Union Govt appoints 5 new digital forensic examiners

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi

India's digital forensic system has received a major boost, with the Centre appointing five new Examiners of Electronic Evidence under Section 79A of the Information Technology Act, 2000. Announced on Tuesday, this step will help the country handle the increasing volume of electronic evidence from cybercrimes, cross-border offences, and other digital violations.

Officials said these agencies can now give expert opinions on electronic evidence in court. This should make digital evidence more reliable and accepted in legal cases. One of the new designees is the Special Instruments Wing (SIW) of the Border Security Force (BSF), which will focus on Drone Forensics, an area that is becoming more important.

Security agencies are dealing with the misuse of drones for smuggling, illegal surveillance, and other crimes. The SIW's advanced-technology capabilities help it recover and analyse drone data, strengthening India's response to new aerial threats. The other four agencies will focus on digital forensics, with DFSL Mumbai, NFSU Goa, and CFSL Kolkata handling Computer (Media) Forensics and Mobile Device Forensics.

These three laboratories will handle Computer (Media) Forensics and Mobile Device Forensics. Their mandate includes these three labs, which will work on Computer (Media) Forensics and Mobile Device Forensics. They will examine data from computers, hard drives, removable media, smartphones, and other devices. The Cyber Forensic Division in Jaipur will focus on Computer (Media) Forensics for the national



network, but not on floppy disks or mobile devices.

This expansion, according to experts, supports the Central Government's goal of creating a larger, more accessible network of digital forensic labs. Investigators increasingly rely on electronic records from devices such as phones, computers, external drives, CCTV, cloud services, and drones. Quickly and accurately analysing this evidence is crucial for build-

ing strong prosecution cases. The benefits of this approach are clear. Many modern crimes, such as cyber fraud, financial scams, terrorism, and organised crime, depend on digital evidence. Fast, reliable forensic reports can decide the outcome of a case. By reducing delays and training a skilled workforce, the scheme speeds up everything from evidence collection to presentation in court, making it easier to

handle these cases.

This push gains added urgency with the implementation of the new criminal laws. They emphasise scientific investigation and aim to deliver justice, from the registration of an FIR to the final decision by the Supreme Court, within three years.

Union Home Minister Amit Shah often stresses the importance of scientific evidence in ensuring justice is both quick and fair, as well as in raising conviction rates. This focus has become even more important with the introduction of new criminal laws. The new laws emphasise scientific investigation and aim to resolve cases, from the initial FIR to the Supreme Court's final decision, within three years.

They focus on establishing new campuses of the National Forensic Sciences University, setting up additional Central Forensic Science Laboratories, upgrad-

ing existing infrastructure, addressing the acute shortage of trained forensic professionals, and reducing case pendency in forensic science laboratories nationwide.

By naming these five new Examiners of Electronic Evidence, the Centre is making digital forensic work more widespread and stronger. This also means that experts, especially in new fields like drone forensics, are available to law enforcement across India. The move should speed up digital evidence checks, cut investigation and trial delays, and help build a stronger, more modern justice system.

As cyber threats and tech-related crimes keep changing, these steps in forensic infrastructure are important for national security and timely justice. Naming these labs and agencies is another step in modernising India's forensic system to meet the needs of the digital era.

MP Govt gets final UCC report; panel excludes STs

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bhopal

Chief Minister Mohan Yadav on Tuesday urged the Congress to clearly spell out its stand on the proposed Uniform Civil Code (UCC), saying the high-level committee constituted by the Madhya Pradesh Government has submitted its final report and the time has come for political parties to State their position on the issue.



Madhya Pradesh Chief Minister Mohan Yadav

Speaking to media persons at the State Assembly after paying tributes to former Chief Minister Kailash Joshi on his birth anniversary, Yadav alleged that the Congress views issues such as the Uniform Civil Code and the Bhojshala dispute only through the prism of Hindu-Muslim politics and vote-bank considerations. He said people from different religious communities had expressed their views before the committee, but the Congress had so far not officially clarified its stand.

The Chief Minister said the committee submitted its final report to the State Government on July 13 within the stipulated timeframe and thanked its chairperson and members for completing the exercise. Committee members Gopal Sharma, Budhpal Singh, Shobha Paithankar and Member Secretary Ajay Katesania were present when the report was handed over.

According to Yadav, the report has been prepared in three volumes. The first con-

tains the committee's recommendations based on an analysis of international, national and State laws, as well as existing legal traditions and practices. It comprises 10 chapters outlining the committee's key recommendations.

The second volume contains the draft legislation prepared after examining the laws and regulations currently applicable in Madhya Pradesh. The proposed Bill consists of four parts, 404 sections and seven schedules.

The third volume details the public consultation process undertaken by the committee. Suggestions were invited through district-level consultations, State-level interactions and an online portal. More than 9.58 lakh suggestions were received, and the report includes an analysis of responses based on questions, gender and community categories.

The committee has also recommended that Scheduled Tribes be kept outside the ambit of the proposed Uniform Civil Code. The State Government will now examine the report before deciding on the next course of action.

Yadav said representatives of the Muslim, Hindu and Christian communities had participated in the consultation process and expressed their views, but alleged that the Congress, despite being a major political party, had not formally conveyed its position on the proposed legislation.

Satluj movie controversy must end now: Punjab BJP chief

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chandigarh

Punjab BJP chief Kewal Singh Dhillon on Tuesday said the 'Satluj' movie controversy must end now, asserting that reopening these wounds serves no one, the State has bled enough, and healing takes time.



Kewal Singh Dhillon

"The Satluj controversy must end now. Reopening these wounds serves no one — Punjab has bled enough and healing takes time," Dhillon said in a post on X. In his post, he further said, "The killings of PUNJABIS, irrespective of religion, must never be forgotten. Let us honour the memory of our people, not exploit it for noise".

"I specially appeal to the media to report with responsibility and restraint on this matter — Punjab's peace comes first," he said.

Dhillon's statements come after many political parties,

including Shiromani Akali Dal (SAD) and Sikh bodies in Punjab, have slammed the takedown of Diljit Dosanjh's film "Satluj" from an OTT platform, saying the movie compels India to confront one of the State's "darkest chapters" and history must be confronted with honesty, not buried through censorship. SAD president Sukhbir Singh Badal had on Wednesday said his party will screen the film "Satluj" in every village and corner of Punjab.

Datia bypoll: Congress leader Nayak meets BJP candidate Ashutosh Tiwari

GIRISH SHARMA
■ Bhopal

The Datia Assembly by-election has been jolted by a potentially game-changing development, with disgruntled Congress leader Avdhesh Nayak — who was conspicuously absent from his own party candidate's nomination filing — holding a meeting with BJP candidate Ashutosh Tiwari, fuelling intense speculation that the former Congress ticket claimant may be on the verge of switching allegiance ahead of the July 30 vote.



BJP candidate Ashutosh Tiwari

The meeting between Nayak and Tiwari, which has been confirmed through multiple political sources, has sent tremors through both party camps in the constituency. Photographs and accounts of the encounter between the two leaders have been circulating widely on social media, with political observers interpreting the rendezvous as a signal that Nayak's disenchantment with the Congress has crossed the point of reconciliation.

Nayak's resentment has been simmering since the party's ticket distribution. He had staked a strong claim to

the Congress nomination for the Datia by-election, arguing that his sacrifice in 2023 — when the party had initially declared him as its candidate before replacing him with Rajendra Bharti following factional pressure — entitled him to the ticket this time. However, the Congress leadership once again overlooked his candidature, a decision that appears to have pushed him to the breaking point.

Following the ticket announcement, State Congress president Jitu Patwari had described the selection as a "social decision." However, this characterisation reportedly deepened Nayak's sense of grievance. Adding insult to injury, his name was omitted from the

party's list of star campaigners for the Datia by-election — a pointed exclusion that has been widely interpreted as a deliberate marginalisation of a leader who had expected to be the party's face in the constituency.

Nayak's absence from the Congress candidate's nomination proceedings was the most visible manifestation of the rift. In a constituency where every public gesture carries electoral weight, his decision to stay away from what should have been a show of party unity has been read as an unambiguous declaration of dissent.

The development has injected a volatile new variable into the Datia contest. Nayak commands significant

influence among OBC voters, particularly within the Nayak-Kachhi community, and any formal or informal alignment with the BJP could substantially redraw the constituency's caste arithmetic — which was already finely balanced, with Congress having won the seat by a margin of just 7,742 votes in 2023.

The BJP, for its part, appears to be actively cultivating the disaffected Congress leader. The meeting with candidate Tiwari is being viewed not as a casual social encounter but as a calculated political outreach aimed at either securing Nayak's formal defection or, at the very minimum, ensuring his passive non-cooperation with the Congress campaign — either outcome serving the BJP's electoral interests.

Congress leaders in the district have attempted to downplay the significance of the meeting, maintaining that Nayak remains a party member and that internal differences will be resolved through dialogue. However, senior functionaries privately concede that the damage may already be irreparable, with Nayak's public signals leaving little room for ambiguity about his intentions.

Rebel TMC MPs meet Speaker over NCPI seating in Lok Sabha

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Lok Sabha MPs Sudip Bandyopadhyay and Kakoli Ghosh Dastidar, who have left the Trinamool Congress (TMC) and joined the Nationalist Citizens Party of India (NCPI), have met Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla and discussed seating arrangements for the party's 20 MPs in the Lower House of Parliament, sources said on Tuesday.

During their meeting with the speaker on Monday, the NCPI leaders also discussed the allotment of a party office in the new Parliament building, the sources said.

The MPs who have switched to the NCPI have informed Birla that they have designated Bandyopadhyay as their floor leader, Satabdi Roy as the deputy leader and Ghosh Dastidar as the chief whip.

The meeting comes ahead of the Monsoon session of Parliament and amid the process of according parliamentary recognition to the NCPI as a constituent in the ruling



Kakoli Ghosh Dastidar

Bharatiya Janata Party-led National Democratic Alliance (NDA).

Bandyopadhyay also met Home Minister Amit Shah recently, a source said.

The sources said the NCPI is expected to submit a formal communication to the speaker's office for according parliamentary recognition to it. The leaders are also likely to join an all-party meeting on July 19.

The meeting with the speaker assumes significance as petitions have been filed by the TMC, seeking the disqualification of the 20 MPs who have left the party and joined the NCPI.

TMC leader in the Lok

Sabha, Abhishek Banerjee, has met Birla and submitted 20 separate petitions, seeking the disqualification of the rebel MPs under the 10th Schedule of the Constitution.

He has argued that the MPs have voluntarily given up their membership of the TMC by joining another party and are, therefore, liable to be disqualified.

He has also urged the speaker not to accord any recognition, status or facility to any group claiming to be a separate faction of the TMC.

The sources said the issue of the disqualification petitions did not come up during Monday's meeting of the MPs with the speaker.

YMA flags discrepancies in Mizoram draft electoral rolls

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Aizawl

The influential Young Mizo Association (YMA) on Tuesday alleged discrepancies in the State's draft electoral rolls prepared under the ongoing Special Intensive Revision (SIR) and sought a thorough review to ensure that only genuine citizens are included in the voters' list.

The demand came days after Mizoram Chief Electoral Officer (CEO) Garima Gupta, who had ruled out any abnormal surge in the number of voters in the draft rolls, was transferred to Delhi.

Addressing a press conference, leaders of the Central Young Mizo Association (CYMA) said they had examined the draft electoral rolls published on July 4 and found what they described as "improbable" discrepancies in the digitisation of Enumeration Forms (EFs).



Bihar takes centre stage as an emerging textile hub at Bharat Tex 2026

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi/Patna

Union Minister of Textiles Giriraj Singh on Tuesday inaugurated the Bharat Tex 2026, India's largest global textile event, at Bharat Mandapam. Minister of State for Textiles Pabitra Margherita, Secretary (Textiles) Neelam Shami Rao, Industries Secretary Kundan Kumar and other senior officials were present on the occasion marking the beginning of four days of innovation, collaboration and global textile excellence. On the very first day of the event,

investors signed MoUs worth over ₹1,400 crore with the Government of Bihar.

Participating as the Partner State, Bihar showcased its growing strength in the textile and apparel sector with the inauguration of the Bihar Pavilion.

Speaking on the occasion, Giriraj Singh said that Bihar is rapidly emerging as one of India's promising textile hubs. He noted that the Bihar Government has developed modern industrial infrastructure, including plug-and-play facilities, which have significantly enhanced investor

confidence in the State.

Speaking on the occasion, Industries Minister Shreyasi Singh said that Bihar is rapidly emerging as one of India's most promising destinations for textile and apparel manufacturing. She stated that the State Government's progressive industrial policies, investor-friendly ecosystem and strong focus on traditional crafts are creating new opportunities for entrepreneurs, artisans and global investors. She added that Bharat Tex 2026 provides an ideal platform to showcase Bihar's manufacturing



capabilities and rich textile heritage to the world.

Industries Secretary Kundan Kumar said that the

Bihar Pavilion reflects the State's commitment to pro-

moting its traditional crafts alongside modern industrial growth. He noted that the participation of Bihar's enterprises at Bharat Tex 2026 will strengthen market access, enhance business linkages and create new opportunities for the State's textile ecosystem.

During the Knowledge Session at Bharat Tex 2026, the Government of Bihar signed Memoranda of Understanding (MoUs) with 16 leading textile and apparel companies, reinforcing the State's growing reputation as an emerging textile

investment destination.

The Bihar Pavilion features leading exhibitors from across the State, including SAVI Global, Gramin Khadi Gramodyog Vikas Sangh, Gopalan Silk, Eco Tasar Silk Pvt Ltd, High Spirit Commercial Ventures Pvt Ltd (HSCVPL), New Zeel Fashion Wear Pvt Ltd, Earthomadic Foundation, Competence Experts Pvt Ltd., NIFT Patna, Modelama Group, alongside live demonstrations of Madhubani and Tikuli painting by master artists Kumari Nalini Shah & Arundhati Mahato.



India will respond with full might to hostile eyes: Rajnath

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Indian soldiers reclaimed every peak, hill and bunker from enemy control during the Kargil war, their victory representing the country's enduring resolve to "respond with full might" to any hostile gaze upon its land, identity and honour, Defence Minister Rajnath Singh said on Tuesday.

He stated this while flagging off a motorcycle expedition from the National War Memorial in Delhi to the Kargil War Memorial in Dras, Ladakh, as part of nationwide celebrations marking 27 years since Operation Vijay in 1999.

The 13-day commemorative expedition — 'Shaurya Vijay Yatra' — will see the participation of 28 riders, including serving and retired defence forces personnel, and their family members.

It will cover 1,900 km while traversing through the demanding terrain of the northern Himalayas to honour the courage, resolve and supreme sacrifice made by Indian bravehearts who ensured



Union Defence Minister Rajnath Singh with Chief of the Army Staff (COAS) General Dhiraj Seth and others during the launch of the Shaurya Vijay Yatra motorcycle expedition, from National War Memorial to Kargil War Memorial in Dras, Ladakh, honouring the Indian armed forces and former servicemen in New Delhi

victory in the 1999 Kargil war. The motto of the expedition is 'One Ride, One Nation, One Salute'. During the expedition, riders

will carry "an urn containing the National War Memorial's sacred soil", which will be offered at Kargil in memory of the fallen

heroes, the defence ministry said. "When the soil from here (National War Memorial) unites with the one in Kargil (at Dras

memorial), it would symbolise the confluence of the reverence of the nation's current generation and the valour of the nation's heroes," Rajnath Singh said.

He paid glowing tributes to the gallant soldiers of the country, who, he said, "wrote a golden chapter of courage, patience, discipline, and unmatched patriotism that militaries across the world still study and regard with respect".

"At an altitude of nearly 20,000 ft and temperatures plummeting to minus 40 degrees Celsius, our soldiers achieved their objectives with courage and resilience. They reclaimed every peak, hill and bunker from enemy control and upheld the honour of the tricolour," he asserted.

"The victory (in the Kargil war) represents India's enduring resolve to respond with full might to any hostile gaze upon our land, identity and honour," Singh said. The minister expressed deep gratitude to all Indian bravehearts, including Param Vir Chakra awardees Capt Vikram Batra, Lt

Manoj Kumar Pandey, Sub Maj (Honorary Captain) Yogendra Singh Yadav (ret'd) and Sub Maj (Honorary Captain) Sanjay Kumar (ret'd), for their invaluable contribution in ensuring victory in the war.

He said these valiant soldiers serve as an inspiration to the youth and will continue to motivate future generations.

En route, the riders will pay homage to bravehearts at prominent military memorials, including the Chandimandir War Memorial, Rezang La War Memorial and Leh War Memorial.

They will also interact with and felicitate 'Veer Naris', recognising their courage and resilience. The expedition will culminate at the Kargil War Memorial on the Kargil Vijay Diwas on July 26.

Highlighting a key aspect of the expedition, Rajnath Singh said, it brings together serving officers, veterans and civilians from different parts of the country.

"Diverse backgrounds, languages, and traditions, yet one tri-

colour, one nation, and a shared reverence for our heroes — this is the very identity of our country," he said.

With National Cadet Corps (NCC) cadets in attendance at the flag-off ceremony, Singh exuded confidence that the expedition will awaken a renewed sense of patriotism among the people, especially the youth.

He said it will convey a message to future generations that the defence of the nation's freedom and honour takes place not only at the borders, but also in our memories and values.

Chief of Defence Staff Gen NS Raja Subramani, Chief of the Army Staff, Gen Dhiraj Seth, and other senior officials were also present on the occasion.

'Shaurya Vijay Yatra' reflects the Indian Army's commitment to carrying forward the values exemplified during Operation Vijay. By retracing this journey of courage, the expedition seeks to inspire future generations to uphold duty, honour and selfless service, the ministry said.

Andhra Pradesh introduces monthly economic report to monitor growth

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Amaravati

Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister N Chandrababu Naidu on Tuesday said the State Government has introduced a 'Monthly Economic Report' to continuously monitor growth and improve governance through data-driven decision-making.

Addressing ministers, secretaries and the heads of departments at the Secretariat today, the chief minister said that the Government departments should focus more on improving citizen satisfaction through better service delivery.

"Naidu said the State Government is introducing a Monthly Economic Report for the first time in the country to continuously monitor Andhra Pradesh's economic growth and improve governance through data-driven decision-making," a release quoted the CM as saying.

The CM said the Government is committed to making governance more efficient, transparent and outcome-oriented by leveraging technology and real-time data. According to Naidu, monthly assessments of Gross State Domestic Product (GSDP), revenue receipts and departmental performance would help identify gaps and enable timely corrective measures. The performance and skills of Government employees and officials would also be evaluated regularly to improve administrative effi-



Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister N Chandrababu Naidu

ciency, he said. Expressing concern over the growing number of public grievances against "certain departments," the chief minister directed officials to resolve complaints swiftly through the Public Grievance Redressal System (PGRS).

He instructed all departments to strive for zero pendency in grievance disposal and analyse whether changes in rules or amendments to laws were required to permanently resolve recurring issues. Naidu alleged that the Revenue Department had inherited a large number of complaints due to the erstwhile YSRCP Government's policies. To address long-pending land issues, he observed that the Government is distributing Pattadar Passbooks (land documents) every month in different districts.

Highlighting the importance of technology, he said the Government has developed Artificial Intelligence-based tools to simplify gover-

nance and enhance revenue collection. These efforts have contributed to a 24 per cent increase in revenue collections across various departments, Naidu said, adding that nearly 20 per cent growth over 2017 levels was logged during the previous year and congratulating officials for their collective efforts. The chief minister cautioned that officials occupying key positions must not play a negative role and urged senior officers to undertake regular field visits to understand people's problems first-hand.

Reaffirming the Government's commitment to protecting consumers, Naidu said, "Electricity tariffs have not been increased" despite entering the third year of the Government's tenure. "The Government remains committed to its promise of not raising power tariffs for five years and has also implemented true-down adjustments, resulting in reduced charges for consumers," the press release said.

BJP slams TN Govt over temple land scams

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Tirunelveli (Tamil Nadu)

Tamil Nadu BJP president Nainar Nagendran on Tuesday alleged that the TVK Government was turning a blind eye to massive temple land "scams" and was failing to address the severe power crisis crippling rural areas in the State.

Addressing the press, Nagendran highlighted several "controversial" land registrations and acute staff shortages in the electricity department, questioning the Government's governance model.

Raising serious allegations regarding the illegal transfer of temple properties, specifically citing a recent incident in Palani, the BJP leader alleged that on July 6, one acre and 40 cents of prime temple land, valued at over Rs 50 crore, were illegally registered. He reminded the Government of multiple Supreme Court rulings, including the landmark 1968 case involving the Thenkarai



Tamil Nadu BJP president Nainar Nagendran

Thirumoolanathasamy Temple in Madurai, which firmly established that temple lands belong solely to the deity. While advocating for the protection of long-term residents, he stated, "Those living on temple lands for 60-70 years should not be evicted, but they cannot be given pattas either and must pay a nominal rent to the temple to secure their tenancy rights."

CM launches WhatsApp Chatbot for TN hospitals

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chennai

In a major thrust towards making healthcare services more accessible, Chief Minister C Joseph Vijay on Tuesday launched Nalam TN — an integrated digital platform — to facilitate quick and remote OP registration and appointments at the Government medical facilities across the State.

One can activate the booking by texting "Hi" to the AI Whatsapp chatbot on 9619222999 and skip physical outpatient registration



queues in the hospitals. The digital platform: www.nalam.tn.gov.in is currently live on a pilot basis in 22 districts, including Chennai and Chengalpattu,

the Government said. Also, the platform allows people, including corporates, to directly sponsor medical equipment or donate transparently to specific Government hospitals to improve the facilities, the Government said.

The chief minister launched the portal at an event held under the aegis of the State health and family welfare department at the Presidency College Auditorium in Chennai.

Also, Vijay inaugurated healthcare infrastructure worth ₹139.47 crore, focus-

ing on the expansion of medical facilities, including patient wards and diagnostic equipment and handed over appointment orders to 2,144 newly recruited healthcare professionals, including 751 assistant medical officers and 1,393 health inspectors.

In a heartwarming gesture, the chief minister walked down from the stage to hand over an appointment order to a differently-abled doctor. He obliged to a few doctors requesting him for an autograph and a selfie too.

Ramnagar-Dehradun train to start from July 18

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

BJP MP Anil Baluni on Tuesday said a train service from Ramnagar to Dehradun is set to commence from July 18 in Uttarakhand, and expressed gratitude towards Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Railway Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw for this.

He said this train service will greatly facilitate travel for local residents commuting to Dehradun for work. It will also provide direct and convenient rail connectivity for the tourists visiting Corbett National Park, the Garhwal MP added. Baluni said that in



MP Anil Baluni

the initial phase, this train will operate two days a week.

Depending on passenger numbers and demand, efforts will be made in the future to increase its operation to four or five days a week, he added. "Dear friends, I am overjoyed

to share this delightful news with all of you. As a result of sustained efforts over a long period, a direct train service between Ramnagar and Dehradun is set to commence on July 18," Baluni, who is also BJP chief spokesperson, said in a post on social media.

"I extend my heartfelt gratitude to the esteemed Prime Minister Narendra Modi ji for his continuous efforts to make the lives of fellow citizens more convenient, and to the honourable Railway Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw ji, who has always accorded priority to Uttarakhand's rail projects and services," he added. Baluni said the residents of

Ramnagar, also known as Corbett City, have long been demanding a direct rail service to Dehradun.

"I extend my best wishes to the residents of the Ramnagar region, as they are about to receive this double dose of good news. Prior to this, the Dhanaghari Bridge has also been dedicated for the convenience of the general public," he said.

This new rail service will prove "immensely beneficial", not only for the local people but also for tourists and pilgrims from across the country and abroad who visit Uttarakhand, the BJP leader added.

Assam's debt rose 4.5 times in 10 years: State Minister

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Guwahati

The overall debt of Assam has increased more than 4.5 times to ₹1.62 lakh crore in the last 10 years, after the BJP came to power, the State Assembly was informed on Tuesday.

Replying to a set of queries raised by a number of opposition MLAs, Finance Minister Jayanta Malla Baruah in written answers said that Assam had an outstanding debt of ₹35,690 crore as on March 31, 2016.

"As per the latest information from the Accountant General, the total debt of Assam stood at 1,61,761 crore as on March 31, 2025," he added.

Out of the total liabilities, ₹18,582 crore are interest-free 50-year loans, the minister told



Assam Finance Minister Jayanta Malla Baruah

the House. "Therefore, Assam's total loans with interest is ₹1,43,179 crore," he said. Baruah added that the State has paid ₹9,467.75 crore as interest to various lenders in the 2024-25 fiscal alone.

Maharashtra eases Ahilyadevi Holkar farm loan waiver norms

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

The Maharashtra Cabinet on Tuesday approved significant changes to the latest loan waiver scheme, removing key eligibility conditions, including the previous ₹50,000 upper limit applicable to the beneficiaries of the 2019 waiver.

It also scrapped the condition of regular loan repayment during 2026-27, making nearly 23 lakh farmers eligible for incentive benefits under the Punyashlok Ahilyadevi Holkar Shetkari Karjimukti Yojana 2026 (PAHSKY). A Cabinet meeting, chaired by Chief Minister



Maharashtra Assembly Speaker Rahul Narwekar along with State Chief Minister Devendra Fadnis in Mumbai

Devendra Fadnis, cleared the establishment of an international-standard agricultur-

al market in Palghar district and an asset monetisation policy for urban local bodies,

according to an official release. Approving significant changes to the PAHSKY, the cabinet decided to remove the earlier ₹50,000 ceiling applicable to around 13 lakh farmers under the 2019 farm loan waiver scheme, enabling them to receive the incentive for regular loan repayment without the earlier cap.

In another major decision, the cabinet cleared the transfer of 558.43 hectares of land belonging to the Dapchari Dairy Project in Dahanu taluka of Palghar district to the Maharashtra State Agricultural Marketing Board for setting up an international-standard agricultural market along with

modern agricultural marketing infrastructure. The project is expected to benefit farmers from Palghar, Thane and adjoining areas. The Cabinet also approved an asset monetisation policy for properties owned by urban local bodies, including municipal corporations, councils and nagar panchayats, to help civic bodies generate additional revenue through planned commercial utilisation of their assets.

It further approved the implementation of the Centre-sponsored Urban Challenge Fund, which will enable cities to access market-based financing for quality urban infrastructure projects.

Maharashtra proposes to double pink e-rickshaw subsidy for women

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Mumbai

The Maharashtra Government has proposed to double the subsidy under its Pink E-Rickshaw Scheme for women from 20 per cent to 40 per cent, officials said on Tuesday.

Women who have already purchased e-rickshaws under the programme will benefit from this increase, an official release said.

Under the revised norms, beneficiaries will now contribute 60 per cent of the vehicle cost, including a minimum of 10 per cent as their own contribution, while the remaining 50 per cent can be financed either through an interest-free partial deferred payment facility offered by the supplier or through bank loans.

The Government has also decided to expand the scheme beyond the existing eight districts and authorised the Women



and Child Development Minister to reallocate district-wise beneficiary targets.

Subsidies will be disbursed through the office of the Commissioner, Women and Child Development, Pune.



Editor's

TAKE

EPI: An imperfect index, an uncomfortable truth

India ranks 176th in the 2026 Environment Performance Index. Is the index unfair, or is the country failing to confront its environmental crisis?

India has once again landed near the bottom of the global Environment Performance Index (EPI), ranking 176th out of 177 countries in the 2026 edition, ahead only of Laos. With a score of 22.46, against table-topper Estonia's 74.79, the headline is stark. But is it fair to call India one of the world's most pollution-hit nations, or is this simply an artefact of a flawed ranking system, as New Delhi has argued before?

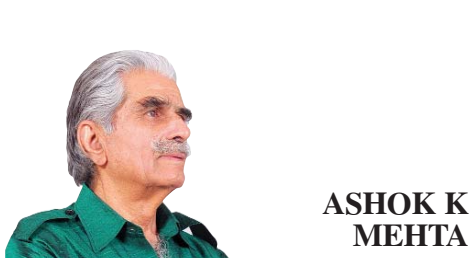
The honest answer is that both things can be true at once. The EPI's methodology has genuine limitations – it shifts across editions, making year-on-year comparisons tricky, and it measures current-state performance rather than historical responsibility, a point India raised sharply when it was ranked last in 2022. Those are legitimate scientific and diplomatic objections, not mere excuses.

Yet dismissing the index as “unscientific surmise”, as the Government did in 2022, does not survive contact with the underlying data. India's own indicators – not just its rank – tell a grim story: rising deaths and disease linked to fine particulate matter, worsening carbon monoxide and sulphur dioxide exposure over a decade, and a collapse in the effectiveness of marine protected areas. These are not abstractions produced by a Yale-Columbia formula; they are lived realities in Delhi's winter smog and along an overfished coastline pushed towards catching species lower on the food chain.

The deeper story is one of tension, not villainy. India's per capita emissions remain low by global standards, and hundreds of millions of citizens are only now gaining reliable access to electricity, which is still overwhelmingly coal-fired. That is the crux of the “development versus pollution” dilemma that the report itself acknowledges. Encouragingly, the 10-year trend shows India's score improving, and the pace at which emissions are rising has slowed. Progress exists; it is simply outpaced by scale. So, what would doing “enough” actually look like? Four things stand out. First, air quality enforcement needs teeth - real-time monitoring, industrial accountability and a faster transition from coal to renewables, an area where India has made pledges but where implementation lags behind ambition. Second, marine and coastal governance needs an overhaul; protected areas that exist on paper but not in practice explain the index's harshest assessments. Third, this year's new grassland-conversion indicator is a reminder that ecosystem protection cannot stop at forests – India's grasslands, vital carbon sinks, remain a policy afterthought. Fourth, India needs its own credible and transparent environmental data infrastructure, both to hold itself accountable and to contest international rankings from a position of evidence rather than denial. Rejecting an imperfect index outright, as happened in 2022, forfeits the opportunity to use it constructively. A more useful approach - engaging with the EPI's authors, who have publicly said they welcome collaboration, while building stronger domestic metrics – would serve India better than defensiveness. No ranking is perfect. It is indicative. Whether India treats it as a warning worth heeding, or one worth arguing away, will determine the future of the country's air quality.

The next flashpoint in global geopolitics

With the Strait of Hormuz under strain, the Malacca Strait has emerged as the world's most strategically significant maritime chokepoint, reshaping Indo-Pacific security, trade and great-power competition



ASHOK K MEHTA

The ship tracker in Kota Kinabalu, where I am – on the eastern edge of Malaysia – shows that 281 ships passed through the Malacca Strait on July 14, compared with 134 ships which used to cross the Strait of Hormuz daily before the blockade. Four countries – Malaysia, Indonesia, Thailand and Singapore – monitor and regulate traffic across the Malacca Strait. Before its twin blockades by the US and Iran, the Strait of Hormuz was free for international passage. Iran has found it can use the choke point as leverage and even impose tariffs. As I write, the issue over passage rights remains unresolved despite tit for tat bombings and a fragile ceasefire. Not since the Suez Canal crisis of 1956, which led to a geopolitical tsunami, has another choke point rediscovered its importance.

The 900 km long and 65 km wide Strait of Malacca is flanked by Malaysia, Singapore and Indonesia, with which PM Modi signed a landmark BrahMos deal this week; it carries 24 per cent of global sea borne trade, 45 per cent of sea borne oil and 23 per cent of cargo shipments, and contains the world's most critical port infrastructure: Singapore's Port Klang, which is the world's second busiest container hub, one of the busiest container trans shipment points and the world's largest ship refuelling hub. That the Malacca Strait remains free of disruption is critical for China, the US, India and Japan especially, and ASEAN; notably for the four custodian states, for whom control or leverage over it is necessary. They have been working on keeping the South China Sea and the Indian Ocean that the Malacca Strait connects open and tranquil.

Tensions in the South China Sea and the Taiwan Strait are magnifying after the ongoing Gulf War, as Chinese coastguards have introduced new sea patrols off Taiwan's eastern coast. China's claims over the entire South China Sea are in violation of an UNCLOS ruling in 2016, which was re endorsed by the West last week but rejected by China. For Beijing, Taiwan is an inalienable and vital component of its One China policy. China has maritime disputes with seven ASEAN countries but enjoys cordial relations with all; North Korea is its only good weather friend. China has long delayed accepting a South China Sea code of conduct first sought by ASEAN in 2003, and, like hedging with India over delineation of the LAC, China has dodged ASEAN over the code until it was nailed to a 2026 deadline by the ASEAN chair, the Philippines. Chinese President Hu Jintao during an economic conference in 2003 first



PM MODI'S RECENT VISIT TO INDONESIA HAS TURNED THE TIDE. MANY IDEAS HAVE RECENTLY BEEN FLOATED ABOUT BLUNTING CHINESE ADVANTAGE ALONG THE LAC BY AUGMENTING CHINA'S MALACCA DILEMMA, SHOULD INDIA HAVE THE POLITICAL WILL AND MILITARY FINESSE FOR IT

The writer, a retired Major General, served as Commander, IPKF (South), Sri Lanka, and was a founder member of the Defence Planning Staff, now the Integrated Defence Staff

Malacca Strait and other vital sea routes of the world. The narrowest portion of the Malacca Strait is the 2.8 km Phillips Channel near Singapore, which is a vulnerable point. Contingency plans for keeping it free of disruption are available and are being augmented by the new entity “ASEAN Maritime Centre for Protection of Strait of Malacca and South China Sea from Encroachment by Major Powers”, set up in May 2026. This will be similar to the Information Fusion Centre for the Indian Ocean Region at Gurugram, India.

On June 18, 2026, Thailand's Prime Minister Anutin Charnvirakul highlighted the criticality of strategic maritime choke points like the Malacca Strait. ASEAN countries were all affected by the closure of the Hormuz Strait except Petronas rich Malaysia. Thailand announced on 18

June the revival of the pending USD 36bn land corridor project connecting two deep sea ports - Ranong in the Andaman Sea, Indian Ocean, with Chumphon in the Gulf of Thailand, South China Sea in the Pacific Ocean.

China, one of the investors, would be a key beneficiary of this alternate route. The corridor will reduce logistics costs by nearly 30 per cent and cut transit time by 14 days especially for large cargo containers. But Singapore will lose its pivotal position as the infrastructural hub along the key waterway.

India sits 40 nautical miles on the 6 degree channel covering the western approach to the Malacca Strait. The controversial USD 5bn Great Nicobar Project, involving construction of a deep water port at Galathea Bay, will become the pivotal hub of global shipping and a new international container trans shipment port near the entrance to the Malacca Strait. On July 4, former naval chief and LG of Andaman Adm DK Joshi and Nicobar Adm DK Joshi examined its strategic value with advisers. INS Baaz, India's southernmost air and naval base, is close by but the runway is still not fit for large jet aircraft.

I recall my visit with Defence Planning Staff in 1989 when Indonesia protested India's proposal to enlarge the air base and the issue became a *Time magazine* cover story. PM Modi's recent visit to Indonesia has turned the tide. Many ideas have recently been floated about blunting Chinese advantage along the LAC by augmenting China's Malacca dilemma, should India have the political will and military finesse for it.

PIC TALK



Women extract jute fibres from retted stalks in Morigaon, Assam.

PHOTO: PTI

DIGITAL EXPERIENCE

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Are schools preparing children for the future?



SAKSHI SETHI

2ND OPINION

When families who can afford the finest schools begin looking beyond them, education systems should pay attention. For generations, success followed a familiar route: admission to a reputed school, good examination results and entry into a prestigious university. That pathway still exists, but its adequacy is increasingly being questioned.

As artificial intelligence reshapes knowledge and work, many affluent families are investing in experiences that classrooms often treat as optional – entrepreneurship, financial literacy, AI awareness, internships, public speaking and problem-solving. Their choices should not be copied blindly, but they raise an important question: if conventional schooling is enough, why are those with access to the best schools still searching? Artificial intelligence has changed the value of information. Knowledge that once required hours of research is now instantly accessible. AI

tools can generate presentations, analyse data, write code and answer complex questions. Possessing information is no longer enough. The real advantage lies in knowing how to question, verify and apply it responsibly. This makes human capabilities such as critical thinking, creativity, communication, emotional intelligence, ethical judgement and adaptability more valuable than ever.

Yet these abilities remain underdeveloped in many classrooms. Schools continue to reward compliance over curiosity, speed over depth and standardised responses over original thought. Examinations serve an important purpose, but performance should not become the sole measure of success. A child may score highly without learning to think independently, collaborate effectively or make sound decisions. Many affluent families are responding by exposing children to experiences beyond academics. Outdoor expeditions, internships, entrepreneurial projects, community service and debates help develop resilience, leadership and problem-solving skills. Equally important is the willingness to let children struggle. Failure, when supported by reflection and guidance, is a powerful teacher. A failed project can improve planning, a difficult presentation can build confidence and disagreement can strengthen negotiation skills. Artificial intelligence reinforces this need. As routine tasks become automated, education must move beyond memorising information. Students should learn to evaluate AI-generated content, identify bias, verify sources, protect privacy and make ethical decisions. Technological literacy should include understanding both

the capabilities and the limitations of intelligent machines.

Traditional schools remain indispensable. They provide structure, discipline, mentorship and foundational knowledge. The real question is whether they are evolving quickly enough. This challenge is especially relevant in India, where educational success is often measured by board results, entrance examinations and institutional prestige. These achievements matter, but long-term success depends equally on judgement, adaptability and lifelong learning.

The greatest risk is that future-ready education becomes another privilege available only to those who can afford it. Fortunately, many meaningful reforms require more imagination than money. Schools can introduce teamwork, community projects, student-led discussions, public speaking, financial awareness, age-appropriate AI literacy and opportunities to solve real-world problems. The National Education Policy (NEP) 2020 already advocates competency-based and experiential learning. The challenge lies in implementation. The choices of affluent families should not be viewed as a model to imitate blindly, but as a signal that education must evolve. The future will belong not simply to those who score the highest marks, but to those who can think independently, learn continuously, adapt confidently and remain deeply human in an age shaped by intelligent machines. That is not elite education – it is the education every child deserves.

The writer is an educator and a councillor

MOTHERHOOD ALONE CANNOT DEFINE EVERY WOMAN'S TRUE IDENTITY

Apropos the recent remarks made by Uttar Pradesh Governor Anandiben Patel during a university convocation in Kanpur, I find her views on women deeply disappointing and out of step with contemporary India. While motherhood is undoubtedly one of the most respected and meaningful roles in society, suggesting that women should first become “expert mothers” before anything else diminishes their aspirations and achievements. Today's women are excelling in every sphere, from science, administration and business to the armed forces and sports. Their identity cannot be confined to domestic responsibilities alone. Every individual, irrespective of gender, should share household duties and parenting responsibilities. Placing the primary burden of childcare and homemaking on women only reinforces outdated stereotypes

that have long hindered gender equality. Ironically, official surveys continue to show that women already spend significantly more time than men on unpaid domestic work, which often limits their participation in the workforce. Instead of encouraging such unequal expectations, influential public figures should inspire society to promote shared responsibilities, equal opportunities and mutual respect. A university convocation is a platform to motivate young graduates to pursue their dreams with confidence. Public leaders must encourage women to realise their full potential rather than define their future through traditional gender roles. India can truly progress only when women are empowered to choose their own paths without prejudice or stereotypes.

YASH PAL RALHAN | JALANDHAR

Please send your letter to the info@dailypioneer.com. In not more than 250 words. We appreciate your feedback.

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

The infrastructure we cannot afford to ignore

Apropos the opinion piece, “The infrastructure we cannot afford to ignore” by Shri Siddhart Roy, published on 14 July 2026, the article rightly highlights that trust and accountability are as important as physical infrastructure in building a developed nation. However, it is concerning that this vital social asset appears to be weakening with each passing day. Instead of fostering trust, society is witnessing growing suspicion among communities.

A taxi driver often hesitates to accept a passenger, fearing fare disputes or cancellations, while the passenger worries about safety and overcharging. The relationship between doctors and patients has deteriorated, with medical decisions increasingly viewed with suspicion, sometimes even resulting in violence against healthcare professionals. Likewise, teachers, once held in high esteem, now frequently face criticism from students and parents. Road rage over trivial issues and disputes over queues, seats and other minor inconveniences have also become increasingly common.

These incidents may appear isolated, but they reflect a deeper social reality. When trust erodes, cooperation declines, conflicts increase and institutions become less effective, regardless of how advanced a nation's physical infrastructure may be.

SOURAV ASH | KOLKATA

Indian women script Lord's glory

Apropos the news report, “Best Is Yet to Come: First Female Test Centurion at Lord's, Yastika Bhatia”, published on July 14, here is my response.

The Indian men's team took 54 long years to register a Test victory at the historic Lord's, but the women's team achieved this feat in their very first Test at the venue. The Indian women's cricket team defeated England by 270 runs in the one-off Test at Lord's, handing the hosts a crushing defeat. Indian fast bowler Kranti Gaud created history by becoming the first woman to have her name inscribed on the prestigious Lord's Honours Board after claiming 5 for 37 in the first innings. In the process, she also became the youngest Indian woman fast bowler to take a five-wicket haul in a Test, surpassing the previous record held by the legendary Jhulan Goswami.

In the second innings, wicketkeeper-batter Yastika Bhatia became the first woman to score a Test century at Lord's, earning herself a permanent place on the iconic Honours Board. Both players come from humble backgrounds, and their remarkable achievements will inspire countless young girls who dream of representing India.

Smriti Mandhana also contributed with the bat in both innings. This historic victory helped erase the disappointment of India's T20 World Cup semi-final exit.

BAL GOVIND | NOIDA

Citizens should not suffer during protests

The recent farmers' protest in Chandigarh has once again raised an uncomfortable but necessary question: how far is too far when it comes to public demonstrations? According to reports, thousands of commuters, schoolchildren and office-goers were stranded for hours as major roads across Chandigarh and Mohali were blocked. When a protest disrupts ambulances, students and ordinary workers, it ceases to be merely a democratic expression and becomes a burden on the public.

No one disputes the farmers' right to protest. In a democracy, peaceful demonstrations are essential. However, that right must be exercised responsibly. Protests should be organised in designated areas with proper arrangements to ensure that emergency services, schools and daily commuters are not adversely affected.

Many farmers undoubtedly face genuine economic challenges, and their grievances deserve serious attention. At the same time, there should be zero tolerance for tactics that inconvenience citizens or endanger public safety. A movement retains its moral strength only when it wins public support rather than public resentment.

Farmers deserve to be heard, but patients, students and the common man also deserve the freedom to move safely and without disruption.

SUMEET SETHI | CHANDIGARH

India’s Taiwan moment: Deepening ties without redrawing policy

As India’s global profile rises and our strategic partnerships expand, we too have increasingly become targets of coordinated attempts to shape public narratives and influence policy debates. Democracies cannot afford to underestimate information warfare simply because it unfolds without conventional weapons



PRIYANKA CHATURVEDI

India's foreign policy has often found strength in its ability to reject false binaries. We have maintained relationships with adversaries, partnered with competitors and pursued strategic autonomy in an increasingly polarised world. It is this ability to engage without becoming entangled that has defined Indian diplomacy for decades. This is what strategic autonomy in motion looks like. Yet this confidence appears to diminish in the case of Taiwan, despite bilateral trade crossing US\$10 billion and cooperation steadily expanding within India's existing policy framework.

In the case of Taiwan, Indian governments over the years have always asked themselves: does deeper engagement contradict India's One China policy? It is a misplaced question. India's official position has been clear and consistent. Equally clear, however, is that our One China policy has never precluded meaningful economic, educational, technological or cultural engagement with Taiwan. If anything, with bilateral trade having more than doubled over the past decade and Taiwan emerging as a major source of investment in electronics and semiconductors, the rapidly changing geopolitical and economic landscape demands fuller use of the diplomatic space that already exists.

The challenge before India is not whether to change policy, but whether to fully leverage it. My visit to Taiwan convinced me that the time has come to do precisely that. Like many observers, I arrived with a mental picture shaped largely by international headlines. Taiwan has often been portrayed through the prism of geopolitical rivalry, military tensions across the Taiwan Strait and global anxieties over semiconductor supply chains. What I discovered instead was a thriving democracy with remarkable institutional resilience, an innovation-led economy and a society that has quietly built global leadership in sectors that will define the future.

The resilience of Taiwan is visible not merely in its economic achievements but in the confidence of its people. Universities work seamlessly with industry. Small and medium enterprises continue to drive global manufacturing networks. For a country like India, which often boasts of a demographic dividend and wants to become a global manufacturing and technology hub, these are lessons worth absorbing.

Taiwan today produces over 60 per cent of the world's semiconductors and more than 90 per cent of advanced chips, making it indispensable to global supply chains. Its expertise in semiconductors, electronics manufacturing, precision engineering, healthcare technologies, renewable energy and advanced manufacturing complements India's own developmental aspirations. As companies diversify through the "China Plus One" strategy and India expands electronics manufacturing under Production Linked Incentive (PLI) schemes, both sides have a commercially viable and strategically beneficial opportunity to deepen cooperation.

The case extends beyond economics. China's increasingly assertive behaviour, from repeated transgressions along the Line of Actual Control to growing naval deployments, survey vessels and maritime militia activity across the South China Sea and the wider Indo-Pacific, has reinforced the importance of resilient regional partnerships. Deepening engagement with Taiwan complements India's broader Indo-Pacific vision of a free, open and rules-based maritime order without altering our stated policy.

Taiwan lives under the constant shadow of organised disinformation campaigns. At times, one does feel that its ideas of freedom of speech are based not on its lived reality but more on the idealism of Western concepts. Like many



democracies confronting algorithm-driven disinformation through Chinese digital platforms and coordinated online influence campaigns, Taiwan faces an existential challenge. India's own decision to ban 59 Chinese-linked mobile applications demonstrated how democracies can respond decisively to national security concerns. Taiwan's contentious relationship with China has made the island one of the world's foremost laboratories for information warfare. False narratives, manipulated content, coordinated online campaigns and psychological operations seek to influence elections, erode trust in democratic institutions, polarise public opinion and weaken confidence in governance.

What makes these campaigns particularly dangerous is that they rarely appear overtly political. They often masquerade as grassroots concerns, anonymous citizen movements or seemingly authentic public opinion. By the time misinformation is identified and corrected, it has frequently achieved its objective of creating confusion and mistrust. Taiwan has invested considerably in combating these threats through digital literacy, rapid government communication and active civil society participation. Yet, even with these safeguards, the challenge remains enormous. The experience carries an important lesson for India.

As India's global profile rises and our strategic partnerships expand, we too have increasingly become targets of coordinated attempts to shape public narratives and influence policy debates. Democracies cannot afford to underestimate information warfare simply because it unfolds without conventional weapons. Keeping this in mind, in my meetings with the leadership of the Taiwanese government, as part of the IPAC group and its India co-chair, I advocated greater momentum for the proposed India-Taiwan Labour Mobility Agreement, which has been collateral damage in the disinformation emanating from China. The agreement was conceived as a practical response to complementary economic needs. Taiwan's median age now exceeds 44 years, and labour shortages persist across manufacturing, healthcare and construction. India, by contrast, has one of the world's youngest workforces, creating a natural complementarity. A well-regulated labour mobility framework could create a win-win partnership. Indian workers would gain access to structured employment opportunities, skill development and higher incomes. Taiwan would benefit from addressing labour shortages through transparent, rules-based migration.

Yet, despite its promise, the agreement has remained in cold storage. Distorted claims circulated, suggesting that the agreement would result in uncontrolled migration, derogatory commentary on the Indian diaspora, displacement of local workers or exploitation on a massive scale. Facts were replaced with speculation. Public debate was overshadowed by fear, and these narratives achieved one objective: they slowed a partnership that could have generat-

ed tangible benefits for both societies.

Whenever two democracies move towards greater strategic cooperation, particularly in sectors carrying long-term economic significance, there will inevitably be those who perceive such proximity as contrary to their interests. Information manipulation has become one of the least visible yet most effective tools for delaying or derailing international cooperation.

Besides these partnerships, our engagement with Taiwan must extend far beyond labour mobility. Semiconductors understandably dominate public discussion. Taiwan's leadership in semiconductor manufacturing is unmatched. With India investing nearly US\$15 billion through semiconductor incentives and fabrication projects, collaboration can strengthen technological resilience while reducing dependence on concentrated supply chains. But there are equally compelling opportunities elsewhere. Vocational education offers enormous scope for collaboration, particularly in advanced manufacturing skills. Joint research programmes between universities could deepen scientific cooperation. Partnerships in healthcare technology, biotechnology and medical devices would contribute to India's growing life sciences sector. Renewable energy, electric mobility and digital governance represent additional areas where Taiwan's experience could complement India's scale.

Perhaps most importantly, people-to-people exchanges deserve greater attention than they currently receive. Diplomatic relationships endure not because governments sign agreements but because societies develop familiarity with one another. Student exchanges, academic collaboration, tourism, technology partnerships and professional mobility create durable constituencies of trust that often outlast political cycles. India has successfully cultivated such relationships with many countries across Asia. Taiwan should be no exception.

None of this requires India to abandon its strategic autonomy or alter its official diplomatic position. Indeed, the strength of Indian foreign policy has always rested on its refusal to allow external powers to define the limits of our engagement. We have consistently maintained independent relationships based on our own national interests rather than the preferences of competing geopolitical blocs. Our approach to Taiwan should reflect the same confidence.

Ultimately, the question is not whether India should revisit its One China policy, but whether it has the confidence to fully utilise the diplomatic space it already provides. Strategic autonomy has always meant making sovereign choices in pursuit of national interests. Deepening ties with Taiwan is not a departure from India's foreign policy but a natural extension of it in an increasingly contested Indo-Pacific.

The writer is a former Member of Parliament (Rajya Sabha) and currently heads Women Led Futures at ORF

High-tech weapons, made in India



ANIL BHAT

Made in India weapon systems looked impressive at Armenia's Republic Day military parade on 28 May 2026. Armenia emerging as one of reportedly eighty countries a buying Indian-manufactured weapons also highlights the growing global trust in "Make in India" military technology. The proudly weapon systems that Armenia purchased from India included the Pinaka Multi-Barrel Rocket Launchers for rapid, long-distance saturation strikes; two types of highly mobile 155 mm artillery guns; Akash medium-range surface-to-air missile systems designed to intercept aircraft, drones, and cruise missiles and Swathi Weapon Locating Radars with pin-point accuracy. Armenia has recently emerged as India's largest and primary export market for military weaponry.

Operation Sindoor launched in May 2025 confirmed that India had made immense progress in providing indigenous, state-of-the-art weapon systems to its Armed Forces. India's Defence Research and Development Organisation (DRDO) and some other Indian industrial companies demonstrated the capacity and capability to build the modern weapon systems covering strategic, air defence, air surveillance and integrated command and control sections for wide and effective air defence of the country. The key indigenous systems developed by DRDO which played a decisive role during Op Sindoor were:

- Surface-to-Air Missiles, which included the Akash Missile System, with over 96 per cent Indian content, along with medium-range missiles used for advanced area defense.
- Akashteer (meaning sky arrow) System, an automated air-defence control and reporting system which performed exceptionally well, integrating various sensors and communication frameworks into a single mobile network.
- Supersonic Cruise Missiles, produced by BRAHMOS and delivered pinpoint accuracy during strikes.
- Counter-Drone Technology included -man-portable counter-drone systems and the D4 Anti-Drone System, which were successfully utilised to jam and neutralise hostile unmanned aerial vehicles.

Former DRDO experts and top officials praised the performance of homegrown technologies, emphasising that the success in this conflict debunked prior criticisms of the organisation. Post Op Sindoor, unclassified productions by DRDO are:

India's Sudarshan Chakra

An indigenous Iron Dome, a network-centric shield capable of neutralizing ballistic missiles up to 5,000 km in range. This is a major leap forward for Mission Sudarshan Chakra (Lord Vishnu's constantly spinning celestial discus, which is a powerful symbol of divine protection), which is India's ambitious initiative to build a multi-tiered, all-encompassing air and missile defence umbrella. The goal is to develop an indigenous capability with features akin to Israel's Iron Dome and the US THAAD system, allowing India to counter everything from short-range rockets and drones to long-range ballistic threats.

Project Kusha

Under this project, DRDO has also been working on broader defense shields like the Long-Range Surface-to-Air Missile system to intercept threats at varying distances.

MIRV - AGNI V

MIRV (Multiple Independently Targetable Re-entry Vehicle) is an advanced ballistic missile technology that enables a single missile to carry and deliver multiple nuclear warheads against different targets. Integrated into the DRDO-developed Agni-V, it significantly enhances India's strategic deterrence. The successful flight trials were conducted under Mission Divyastra. The MIRV-capable Agni-V, with an estimated range of 5,000-8,000 km, releases independent warheads after re-entering the atmosphere, enabling simultaneous strikes on multiple targets while complicating enemy missile defence systems.



SHESHNAAG 150

The Sheshnaag-150 (also known as Nagraja-meaning king of serpents) is an indigenous, AI-powered long-range swarm kamikaze drone developed by Bengaluru-based Newspace Research and Technologies (NRT) to function as a low-cost, high-impact strike system. It features a range of over 1,000 km, carries a 25-40 kg warhead, has over five hours of endurance and operates in swarms to overwhelm the enemy's defences. It is designed to operate in GPS-denied environments utilising advanced visual navigation systems. It can be launched from mobile platforms, such as a modified Toyota Hilux pickup truck. This drone aims to fill a niche for cost-effective, long-range, and high-precision strikes.

TARA

On May 7, 2026, DRDO and the Indian Air Force (IAF) successfully carried out the maiden flight-trial of India's first indigenous glide weapon system, TARA (Tactical Advanced Range Augmentation) designed to convert unguided warheads into precision guided munitions (PGMs). Jointly developed by RCI (Research Centre Imarat) and other DRDO labs, the system now in production with industry partners demonstrated the ability to extend the range of a bomb to between 150 and 180 km when released from an altitude of 5-km, with a circular error probability (CEP) of three metres. The system deploys wings and tail units after release, using inertial navigation, GPS-assisted guidance and electro-optical seekers to achieve an accuracy of under five metres.

CADET Kamikaze drones

India is rapidly advancing its asymmetric and mobile warfare capabilities through the Carrier Air Defence Tracked (CADET) system, an advanced, mobile and armoured air defence platform developed by the Indian Army. It marks a shift from static territorial defence to mobile air defence for advancing mechanised forces. The kamikaze drones include the Peacekeeper Drone, with a range of 180 km, a speed of 450 km/h and a targeting accuracy (Circular Error Probable) of less than five metres. The CSIR-NAL Heavy Drone carries a 25 kg explosive payload, has an endurance of nine hours and a maximum range of 1,000 km. The drones are resistant to jamming and spoofing, using the indigenous NAVIC satellite navigation system developed by the Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO).

India's exports of high-tech military weapon systems grew rapidly between 2022 and 2026, with total defence exports rising from ₹686 crore in FY 2013-14 to a record ₹38,424 crore in FY 2025-26, supplying over 80 countries.

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FCRA 2.0: A new framework for secure and transparent foreign funding



ASHISH TRIPATHI

FCRA 2.0: A new framework for secure and transparent foreign funding

On 30th of June, Union Home Minister and Minister of Cooperation Shri Amit Shah, along with newly appointed IB Chief IPS Mahesh Dixit and Home Secretary Shri Govind Mohan, launched the FCRA 2.0 Portal and the e-OCI card in New Delhi. The launch of these portals shows that the Government of India is taking a more direct approach to using technology for official work.

The Foreign Contribution Regulation Act (FCRA) is an Indian law that monitors and regulates the funds or donations from foreign donors to NGOs, individuals, and other social organisations. This law was introduced in 1976 during the period of emergency in India, and at that time, the purpose of making such a law was to prevent external interference in domestic political affairs.

In subsequent years, the law was updated several times, and the registration of NGOs became mandatory.

The introduction of new laws and directives under the FCRA marks a significant and timely

step towards enhancing the regulation of foreign contributions in India. The home minister in his address recalled that our government would work on the principle of 'minimum government and maximum governance.' He further said that when the intention is clear, the policy is transparent, and there is a mindset to embrace technology, then all forms of governance become very easy for honest people, a strict surveillance system is put in place for wrongdoers, and the country can be made increasingly secure.

The FCRA 2.0 Bill, 2026, was introduced in the Lok Sabha on March 25 to amend the FCRA Act 2010, and this amendment was brought to strengthen the security and sovereignty of our nation. The bill tightened the rules to prevent any form of anti-Indian activity across the country.

In the age of information technology, narratives have become increasingly important and consequential. Narratives can make or damage the image of an individual or society. The global image of a nation is built on some key factors, such as the incumbent government, people, culture, and heritage. However, if any agency deliberately makes false, manipulated narratives, it could surely be a great blow to the status of a country on an international level. Many such non-governmental organisations are involved in negative and malicious campaigns in India. They were found to be involved in numerous antisocial



activities including proselytisation, money laundering, and terror financing. They also provoke anti-government and anti-development drives in India.

For instance, NGO Oxfam India led a malafide campaign against the Assam tea industry. The Union Home Ministry cancelled the FCRA licence and alleged Oxfam was purportedly



indulging in activities detrimental to the national economic interest.

Similarly, a Kashmiri-based NGO, Jammu Kashmir Coalition of Civil Society (JKCCS), managed funds from foreign charities to fuel terror and create turmoil. The National Investigation Agency (NIA) has raided and arrested several associates of such NGOs in

the Valley region.

Considering the aforementioned facts, FCRA 2.0 introduced various specific regulations to tackle such malafide wrongdoings with a zero-tolerance policy.

Under the FCRA Act 2026, NGOs must specify their exact objectives with a scheduled fee payment for each activity. This act has a very significant point, which prohibits proselytisation. It clarifies that foreign funds can only be used for worship, religious education, and community kitchens, but cannot be used for religious conversations.

FCRA 2.0 emphasises financial compliance. NGOs must utilise 75 per cent of the allotted fund before receiving the next installment.

The union government is very dynamic and explicit about transparency and accountability, and to enhance these two features, the FCRA 2.0 mandates the mandatory declaration of the ultimate donor, websites, and other social media accounts.

Thus, the ongoing FCRA is highly pertinent and necessary in view of national security and integrity. The government provides an adequate space for good doings and humanitarian activities with bonafide foreign contributions. However, it is very vigilant in safeguarding national sovereignty.

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Order Order

UP court awards 10-year term to man for wife's dowry death



A court in Bareilly sentenced a 31-year-old man to 10 years of rigorous imprisonment for the dowry death of his wife, a case lawyer said on Tuesday.

Additional Sessions Judge Ashok Kumar Yadav convicted Jogendra, a resident of Rampura village under Shergarh police station limits, and imposed a fine of `20,000.

Additional District Government Counsel Suresh Babu Sahu said the prosecution, represented by him and advocate Pankaj Mahant, examined eight witnesses during the trial.

According to the prosecution, the case dates back to 2023. Ram Autar, a resident of Labhera village, had married his sister Vidya to Jogendra in April 2023.

Soon after the marriage, Jogendra allegedly began harassing Vidya for dowry. A village panchayat was convened on August 1, 2023, to resolve the dispute, after which Jogendra took his wife back home after assuring her family. However, five days later, on the night of August 6, 2023, he allegedly killed Vidya.

Based on a complaint lodged by the victim's brother the following morning, an FIR was registered at Shergarh police station. Following investigation and trial, the court convicted Jogendra and sentenced him to 10 years' rigorous imprisonment, the counsel added. (PTI)

Delhi HC to hear Indian polo group's plea over eviction on July 12

The Delhi High Court on Tuesday listed for hearing on August 12 the Indian Polo Association's petition against a sessions court's decision refusing to stay the Centre's May 20 order evicting it from the 15.20-acre Jaipur Polo Ground here.

Hearing in the matter was deferred before Justice Harish Vaidyanathan Shankar as lawyers were abstaining from work in view of the Delhi High Court's full court favouring the enhancement of pecuniary jurisdiction or financial limit of district courts here from `2 crore to `10 crore. Counsel for the petitioner association as well as the central Government urged the court to give an early date.

Justice Shankar said he was willing to hear the petition on Tuesday but deferred the hearing on a request by the lawyers. "Lawyers are abstaining from work. At request, renotify on August 12," the bench said. The petitioner's senior counsel requested the bench to take up the matter in July itself, stating that the sessions court was scheduled to hear the case on July 23. Justice Shankar, however, responded, "You can always inform them. Matter was kept at a short date. We didn't know this is likely to happen."

"We arrange our affairs in a manner that we are able to take up a certain number of matters. When something like this happens, all the planning that goes behind it goes awry," the judge added.

In its petition, the Indian Polo Association has assailed a June 18 order of the sessions court, which acts as the appellate authority under the Public Premises (Eviction of Unauthorised Occupants) Act, rejecting its interim application seeking restoration of possession of the Jaipur Polo Ground, stay of enforcement and execution of the May 20 eviction order and a restraint against demolition, uprooting, digging, disturbing or altering the Jaipur Polo Ground. The petition has stated that the rejection of the petitioner's interim application of stay on eviction notice was ex facie erroneous. (PTI)



SC grants four weeks to Centre to file response on plea challenging NIA Act

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Tuesday asked the Centre to file within four weeks its response on a petition challenging the validity of the National Investigation Agency Act, 2008.

Additional Solicitor General Aishwarya Bhati, appearing for the Centre, told a bench of Justices Vikram Nath and Sandeep Mehta that the Government needed some time to file the counter affidavit.

Senior advocate Siddharth Dave, appearing for the petitioner, said that notice was issued on the plea on April 21.

The bench granted four weeks to the Centre to file the counter affidavit, and said the petitioner may a file



rejoinder, if any, within two weeks thereafter. It said the plea would be listed for hearing after six weeks. On April 21, the top court sought responses from the Centre, the National Investigation Agency (NIA) and others seeking their responses on the plea. The apex court had observed that questions



Bhojshala case: SC makes ad hoc arrangements for Friday prayers

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Tuesday directed that Muslims be provided separate open space adjacent to the disputed Bhojshala site for offering namaz on Fridays between 1 and 3 pm.

However, a bench comprising Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana clarified that the arrangement for Muslims shall be ad hoc subject to the final outcome of petitions.

The top court also directed that the Archaeological Survey of India (ASI) shall not carry out any structural changes on the site without its permission.

Asking both Hindu and Muslim sides to have patience as Bhojshala is a sensitive matter, the apex court said it was ready to hear the matter



on a day-to-day basis and resolve the issue.

The top court was hearing a batch of appeals challenging a Madhya Pradesh High Court order, which said the disputed Bhojshala complex in Dhar district was a temple dedicated to Goddess Saraswati.

The court said it has to be very careful about every expression used.

"These are very sensitive matters. What is being said in

matter can be listed before an appropriate bench within 10 to 15 days," the CJ observed orally.

Earlier on Monday the bench was urged by senior advocate Huzefa Ahmadi and advocate Nizam Pasha, appearing for Muslim appellants, that the pleas needed to be heard on an urgent basis.

The CJ had asked the counsel for the appellants to remove defects from the petitions and assured them that they will be listed for hearing before a bench soon.

On May 15, the Madhya Pradesh High Court ruled that the disputed Bhojshala-Kamal Maula Mosque complex in Dhar district is a temple dedicated to Goddess Saraswati. It simultaneously quashed a decades-old ASI order that had allowed the Muslim community to offer Friday prayers at the site.

Ahmedabad blasts: HC cites scale of terror, conspiracy to uphold death penalty

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Ahmedabad

The Gujarat High Court, while upholding the death sentence of 38 Indian Mujahideen operatives in the 2008 Ahmedabad serial blasts, has cited the "humongous" conspiracy, the intention to spread widespread terror and the large number of casualties as key reasons for affirming the punishment.

A division bench of justices AY Kogje and Samir Dave, in its July 7 judgment, also upheld life imprisonment given to 11 other convicts, holding that their roles in terror training camps in Gujarat and Kerala, and logistical support to the conspiracy had been proved.

A copy of the order was made available on Monday.

On July 26, 2008, a series of 21 bomb blasts ripped through

different areas of Ahmedabad in a span of 70 minutes, killing 56 persons and leaving more than 200 others injured. Explosions also occurred at hospitals where victims were being taken for treatment, marking the first such targeting of medical facilities in a terror attack in India.

The high court rejected all appeals filed by the convicts and confirmed the February 2022 judgment of the special court, which had sentenced 38 members of the Indian Mujahideen (IM) terror outfit to death and 11 others to life imprisonment.

The state Government had sought confirmation of the death sentences.

In its July 7 judgment, the high court said the criminal antecedents and roles of the 38 convicts established that they had carried out a terrorist act



warranting the death penalty.

It noted that the special court considered both mitigating and aggravating circumstances before pronouncing the sentence.

The number of deaths, the "humongous nature of conspiracy", the intention "to create an atmosphere of widespread terror in the society", the conduct of the convicts during trial, the scale of the conspiracy, and the loss of

Lalu bail: SC refuses to interfere with HC order

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Tuesday refused to interfere with the Jharkhand High Court order granting bail to RJD chief Lalu Prasad Yadav in a fodder scam case. A bench of justices MM Sundresh and PB Varale asked the high court to expedite the hearing on the pending appeals in the matter and decide them preferably within six months.

The top court was hearing CBI's plea challenging a July 2019 order of the high court. "We are not inclined to interfere with the impugned order...", the bench said.

The CBI had challenged the high court order, saying it had "erroneously" suspended the sentence awarded by the trial court and released the Rashtriya Janata Dal chief on bail in one of the fodder scam cases. Yadav, a former chief minister of Bihar, was



convicted in the case related to the Deoghar treasury, which involved alleged defalcation of ₹89 lakh. The special CBI court convicted Yadav and sentenced him to a three-and-a-half-year jail term.

The high court had suspended the sentence and granted bail to Yadav in the case of alleged fraudulent withdrawal of ₹89.27 lakh from the Deoghar treasury on the ground that he had already completed half of the sentence.

action had been taken against them during their incarceration, and there was nothing on record to justify taking a lenient view while sentencing them, the HC said.

While upholding the life sentences of the remaining 11 convicts, the bench said the prosecution had established their participation in terror training camps and their involvement in procuring scooters, plastic containers, and clocks used in the conspiracy, besides arranging shelter for the other accused.

"Having perused the entire evidence on record, the court is of the view that the reasonings given by and the findings arrived at by the special court while sentencing this set of accused to life imprisonment are just and appropriate," it said. The high court also upheld the fines imposed on

the convicts, observing that the magnitude of the offence, the damage to public property and the large-scale loss of life and injuries justified the penalties. The court directed the Gujarat Government to pay compensation of ₹10 lakh to the families of those killed and ₹5 lakh to the grievously injured persons before March 30, 2027. The convicts include Safdar Nagori, former leader of the banned outfit Student Islamic Movement of India (SIMI), and his associates from 11 states, including Gujarat, Madhya Pradesh, Kerala and Uttar Pradesh.

Seventy-eight persons were put on trial after 35 police cases — 20 FIRs relating to the Ahmedabad blast and 15 linked to unexploded bombs recovered in Surat — were merged. Forty-nine persons were convicted by the special court.

SC to hear Meghalaya Govt's plea against bail to Sonam Raghuvanshi on July 21

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Tuesday said it would hear on July 21 a plea filed by the Meghalaya Government challenging the bail granted to Sonam Raghuvanshi, accused of killing her husband during their honeymoon in 2025.

The accused, a resident of Indore in Madhya Pradesh, was arrested in June last year in connection with the killing of her businessman husband, Raja Raghuvanshi.

The couple had gone missing while vacationing in Meghalaya's Sohra area on May 23 last year. Subsequently, Raja Raghuvanshi's body was found in a deep gorge on June 2, 2025. The police has alleged that Sonam Raghuvanshi conspired with hired assassins to kill her husband for financial gains.

The Meghalaya Government's plea came up for hearing on Tuesday before a bench of Justices M M Sundresh and P B Varale. Solicitor General Tushar Mehta, appearing for Meghalaya, requested the bench to take up the matter for hearing at 2 PM.



However, the counsel appearing for the accused urged that the matter be taken up next week. The bench posted it for hearing on July 21.

While hearing the matter on July 9, the apex court said it might refer to a larger bench the legal question whether the mere mention of a wrong statutory section in an arrest memo, specifically a typographical error, was sufficient to invalidate an arrest and grant bail to the accused in the case.

The top court had also indicated that it would closely examine whether the high court was justified in granting bail to Raghuvanshi on the grounds that the arrest memo contained a typographical error. On July 3, another bench

of the top court had refused to stay the high court order granting bail. The solicitor general on July 9 raised the question whether the mere mention of a wrong statutory section in an arrest memo, specifically a typographical error, was sufficient to invalidate an arrest and grant bail in the "shocking" murder case. The high court had upheld Raghuvanshi's bail on the grounds that the police failed to supply proper written grounds of arrest, noting a "total non-application of judicial mind" because the memo cited Section 403 (which does not exist in the context) instead of Section 103(1) (punishment for murder) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS).

The solicitor general had argued that the error was purely clerical. On June 29, the Meghalaya High Court upheld a trial court order granting bail to the accused.

The high court had dismissed a petition filed by the state seeking cancellation of the bail granted by the trial court on April 27. It had held that the manner in which the grounds of arrest were prepared reflected a "total non-application of

SC to hear next week Union Govt, State pleas seeking modification of industry curbs in UP

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Tuesday agreed to hear next week a batch of applications filed by the Centre and the Uttar Pradesh Government seeking modification of its directions regulating industrial activity in the Taj Trapezium Zone.

The matter was mentioned before a bench comprising Chief Justice Surya Kant and justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana by Attorney General R Venkataramani.

During the proceedings, the state Government informed the bench that its application seeking modification of the top court's October 2024 directions, which prohibit the establishment of new industries and the expansion of existing industries within the Zone, had been pending for some time.

The state Government further submitted that it had prepared a comprehensive vision document



addressing industrial activity in the Taj Trapezium Zone (TTZ) and requested that the bench consider all pending applications and related reports together.

Appearing for the Centre, the top law officer said, "The State of UP has a serious concern. We have filed an application seeking some modification to the order. There is a vision document with respect to industries. All of those could be listed together." The CJ said he had recently been informed in another matter that even "green category" industries were

facing difficulties in operating because of the existing directions governing the TTZ.

Noting the broader implications of the issue, the bench said the applications filed by the Centre and the Uttar Pradesh Government, along with reports submitted by the Central Empowered Committee (CEC), should be examined holistically.

The bench agreed to list the entire batch of connected matters for hearing next week, observing that all pending issues concerning industrial activity in the TTZ would be taken up together.

Kerala HC declines to suspend sentence in actress assault case

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kochi

The Kerala High Court has declined to suspend the sentence of the prime accused in the 2017 actress assault case, in view of the seriousness of the crime committed by him, his criminal antecedents and violation of bail conditions.

A bench of justices Raja Vijayaraghavan V and K V Jayakumar also said that it took into account the societal impact of the offence and the need to preserve public confidence in the administration of criminal justice, to deny the relief to the accused — Sunil N S also known as Pulsar Suni.

Sunil had sought suspension of his sentence and his release on bail during pendency of his appeal challenging his conviction and 20-

year sentence in the actress assault case.

Rejecting his plea, the bench said it had considered the role attributed to the applicant, Sunil, the nature of the offence, the manner in which it was committed, the gravity and seriousness of the crime, the sentence imposed by the trial court, and his criminal antecedents in as many as 11 serious cases.

It also took into account his alleged involvement in another criminal case while he was on bail in the present case and his violation of the bail conditions imposed by the court.

The bench said no exceptional circumstances had been made out to warrant the suspension of his sentence. In his application, Sunil had contended that he has already undergone

of security of women. It would also undermine public confidence in the rule of law and the administration of criminal justice. In that view of the matter, the long incarceration cannot by itself constitute a ground for suspension of sentence under section 389 of the Criminal Procedure Code," the bench said.

Section 389 of the Code of Criminal Procedure (CrPC) allows an Appellate Court to suspend a convicted person's sentence and release them on bail pending their appeal.

The High Court also held that Sunil has not been able to point out "any patent infirmity, manifest illegality, or perversity" in the judgment of the Sessions Judge. "At this interlocutory stage, we are unable to conclude that the findings



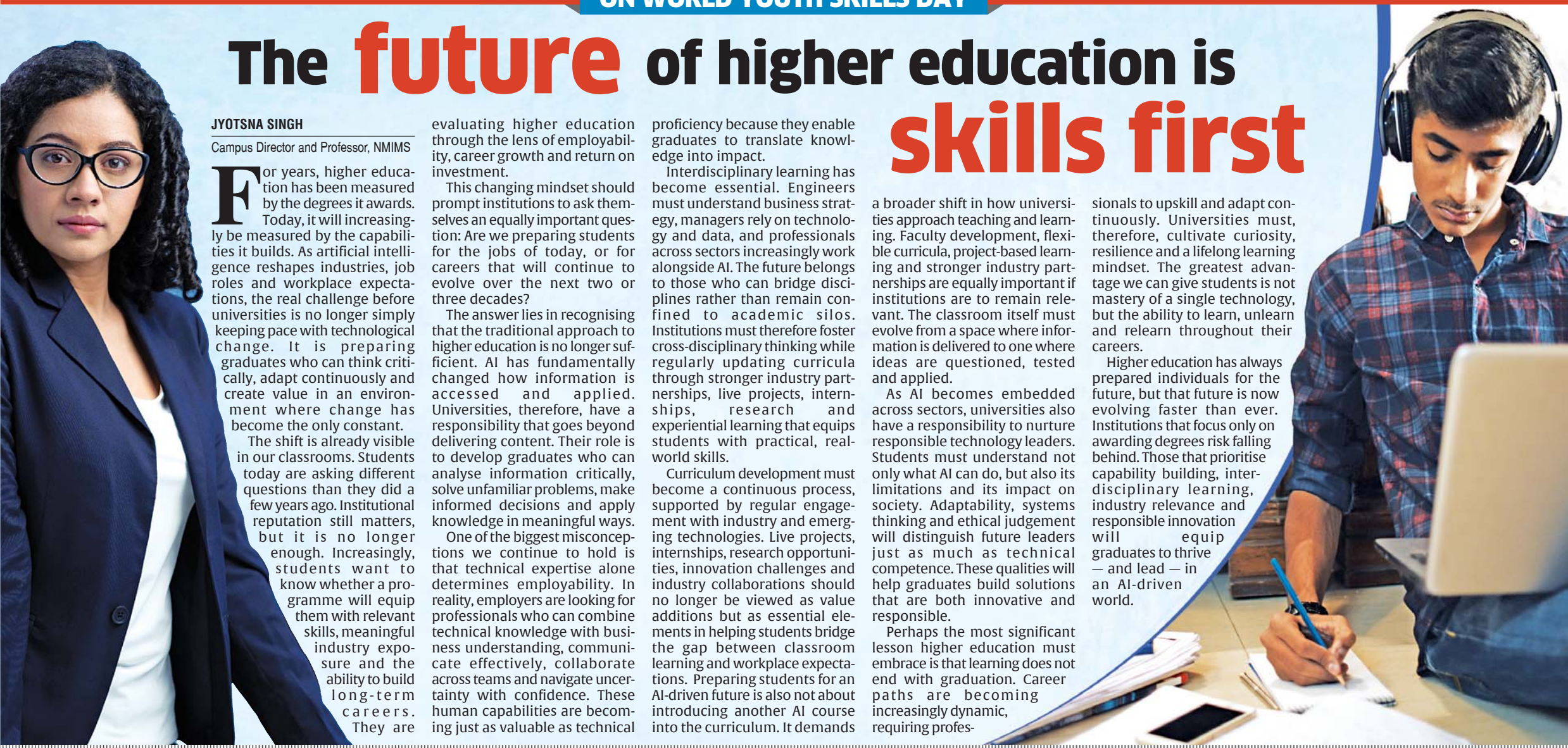
nearly eight years of imprisonment in the case.

The court, however, was of the view that the crime was a "calculated and premeditated act" which shows an "extraordinary degree of criminal depravity" and the manner in which it was committed was "unprecedented." "Its gravity extends beyond the individual victim, as it strikes at the dignity, bodily autonomy, and sense

recorded by the Sessions Judge are so unreasonable or perverse as to justify suspension of the execution of the sentence. In such circumstances, we are of the considered view that the applicant (Sunil) has failed to make out any exceptional or sufficient grounds warranting the suspension of the execution of the sentence imposed by the trial court," it said.

The sessions court had on December 12 last year, sentenced to 20 years imprisonment six persons, including Sunil, for the offence of gang rape. Actor Dileep and three other accused were acquitted in the case.

The case relates to the abduction and sexual assault of multi-lingual actress in a moving vehicle while she was travelling from Thrissur to Kochi on February 17, 2017.



The future of higher education is skills first

JYOTSNA SINGH
Campus Director and Professor, NMIMS

For years, higher education has been measured by the degrees it awards. Today, it will increasingly be measured by the capabilities it builds. As artificial intelligence reshapes industries, job roles and workplace expectations, the real challenge before universities is no longer simply keeping pace with technological change. It is preparing graduates who can think critically, adapt continuously and create value in an environment where change has become the only constant. The shift is already visible in our classrooms. Students today are asking different questions than they did a few years ago. Institutional reputation still matters, but it is no longer enough. Increasingly, students want to know whether a programme will equip them with relevant skills, meaningful industry exposure and the ability to build long-term careers. They are

evaluating higher education through the lens of employability, career growth and return on investment. This changing mindset should prompt institutions to ask themselves an equally important question: Are we preparing students for the jobs of today, or for careers that will continue to evolve over the next two or three decades? The answer lies in recognising that the traditional approach to higher education is no longer sufficient. AI has fundamentally changed how information is accessed and applied. Universities, therefore, have a responsibility that goes beyond delivering content. Their role is to develop graduates who can analyse information critically, solve unfamiliar problems, make informed decisions and apply knowledge in meaningful ways. One of the biggest misconceptions we continue to hold is that technical expertise alone determines employability. In reality, employers are looking for professionals who can combine technical knowledge with business understanding, communicate effectively, collaborate across teams and navigate uncertainty with confidence. These human capabilities are becoming just as valuable as technical

proficiency because they enable graduates to translate knowledge into impact. Interdisciplinary learning has become essential. Engineers must understand business strategy, managers rely on technology and data, and professionals across sectors increasingly work alongside AI. The future belongs to those who can bridge disciplines rather than remain confined to academic silos. Institutions must therefore foster cross-disciplinary thinking while regularly updating curricula through stronger industry partnerships, live projects, internships, research and experiential learning that equips students with practical, real-world skills. Curriculum development must become a continuous process, supported by regular engagement with industry and emerging technologies. Live projects, internships, research opportunities, innovation challenges and industry collaborations should no longer be viewed as value additions but as essential elements in helping students bridge the gap between classroom learning and workplace expectations. Preparing students for an AI-driven future is also not about introducing another AI course into the curriculum. It demands

a broader shift in how universities approach teaching and learning. Faculty development, flexible curricula, project-based learning and stronger industry partnerships are equally important if institutions are to remain relevant. The classroom itself must evolve from a space where information is delivered to one where ideas are questioned, tested and applied. As AI becomes embedded across sectors, universities also have a responsibility to nurture responsible technology leaders. Students must understand not only what AI can do, but also its limitations and its impact on society. Adaptability, systems thinking and ethical judgement will distinguish future leaders just as much as technical competence. These qualities will help graduates build solutions that are both innovative and responsible. Perhaps the most significant lesson higher education must embrace is that learning does not end with graduation. Career paths are becoming increasingly dynamic, requiring profes-

sionals to upskill and adapt continuously. Universities must, therefore, cultivate curiosity, resilience and a lifelong learning mindset. The greatest advantage we can give students is not mastery of a single technology, but the ability to learn, unlearn and relearn throughout their careers. Higher education has always prepared individuals for the future, but that future is now evolving faster than ever. Institutions that focus only on awarding degrees risk falling behind. Those that prioritise capability building, interdisciplinary learning, industry relevance and responsible innovation will equip graduates to thrive — and lead — in an AI-driven world.

How can school education back non-linear career paths?

DINESH GUPTA
Founder & CEO, Vikalp Online School

The path from school to work has, for years, been predictable. Students finished school, went on to further study in their chosen field, found employment in that field, and gradually established a steady career. This linear sequence formed the basis of school education. But that is rapidly changing. Today's students are likely to switch careers, jobs, and skill sets multiple times during their working lives. A computer programmer might become a technopreneur, a high school teacher could turn to instructional design, and a finance graduate could pursue a career in data analysis or even sustainability. In this context, success is no longer about following a linear career trajectory but about adapting, learning, and reinventing oneself. So, the question is no longer whether students will change jobs, but whether schools are preparing them to do so. A non-linear career path is a sequence of career transitions across different jobs, industries, or professions over the course of a person's working life. Artificial Intelligence (AI), automation, digitalisation, and evolving business models have accelerated this shift. Many of the occupations that



today's students will pursue in the future either do not yet exist or will look very different from those of today. Skills that are valuable now may no longer be relevant in a few years. As a result, the ability to continuously learn and acquire new skills has become a necessity rather than an advantage. In the real world, success depends not only on what people know but also on how quickly they can learn and adapt. Yet, school education often remains centred on completing the syllabus, examinations and grades. While academic knowledge is essential, employers increasingly value critical thinking, creativity, communication, collaboration, problem-solving and adaptability. These skills are developed

through exploration, questioning and real-world learning rather than rote memorisation. Schools must therefore evolve from information-delivery systems into institutions that build capability and resilience from an early age. Children learn to adapt when they are encouraged to try different approaches to unfamiliar problems, work collaboratively with others, and learn from their mistakes. Inquiry-based learning, projects, experimentation, and reflection help students become comfortable with uncertainty rather than fear it. Another important aspect is encouraging students to become independent learners. In today's fast-changing economy, a student's greatest competitive advantage in

the future may not be what or how much they know today, but how effectively they continue learning throughout their lives. Schools should therefore teach students not only subject knowledge but also how to learn, how to evaluate information critically, and how to acquire new skills whenever required. Career readiness is about much more than senior secondary career counselling. Many students still choose academic programmes because of limited awareness of career opportunities or social pressures. However, informed career decisions require not only an understanding of interests and strengths but also personal values and preferred ways of learning. Schools can play a transformative role by exposing students to diverse career options, encouraging self-reflection, and providing opportunities for interdisciplinary learning. Career self-awareness is becoming just as important as academic learning. Competency-based learning, flexibility, and multidisciplinary education have rightly been emphasised in the National Education Policy (NEP) 2020. The next challenge lies in implementing these principles consistently in classrooms. Students should be assessed not only on their subject knowledge but also on their analytical, communication, collaboration, and

problem-solving skills. The role of teachers should increasingly shift towards that of facilitators who nurture curiosity, encourage students to ask questions, and help them think independently. Technology can also be used to personalise learning. Digital platforms, when used effectively, can provide flexible learning pathways, self-paced learning, and access to diverse educational resources. However, technology should be used to enhance good pedagogy, not replace it. The future of work will reward individuals who can learn continuously, adapt quickly, and collaborate across disciplines. Schools therefore have a broader responsibility than simply preparing students for board examinations or university admissions. Their greater purpose is to nurture resilient, curious, and self-directed learners who can confidently navigate an uncertain future. Careers will continue to change throughout people's lives. The greatest education is not one that prepares students for a single profession, but one that equips them with the confidence and capability to thrive through change. In an era of non-linear careers and constant uncertainty, perhaps the greatest contribution schools can make is to nurture curiosity, resilience, and confidence in every learner.

Are we preparing children for exams or for life?



RIMA BHANDARI
Energy Coach, Healer, Author & TEDx Speaker

Every year, millions of children work hard to achieve good grades. While academic success is important, an important question remains: Are we preparing children only for examinations, or are we preparing them for life? Today's students face constant pressure from studies, social media and expectations. Many silently struggle with stress, anxiety and fear of failure. Unfortunately, their emotional well-being often receives less attention than their report cards. Rima Bhandari believes that education should develop not only knowledge but also confidence, resilience and emotional strength.

Before becoming an Energy Coach and Healer, she had a successful career as a physiotherapist. Her personal journey through depression taught her that true health is incomplete without mental and emotional well-being, inspiring her to dedicate her life to helping others build inner strength. Parents, teachers and schools must work together to create an environment where children feel safe expressing their emotions. Emotional well-being programmes, mindfulness practices and open conversations should become part of education. The future will belong not only to students with high marks, but also to those who are emotionally resilient, compassionate and prepared for life's challenges.

CAMPUS CANVAS

Karnataka to set up India's first government AI university

Minister D K Shivakumar on Tuesday announced the establishment of India's first government-driven Artificial Intelligence (AI) University, reaffirming the state's ambition to emerge as a global hub for responsible AI innovation. Speaking at the inauguration of Google I/O Connect India 2026 in Bengaluru, Shivakumar also announced the creation of an AI Hub to serve as an incubation centre for AI research and development by startups, companies and academic institutions. The proposed university will focus on developing world-class AI talent, promoting cutting-edge research and strengthening collaboration among academia, industry and government. Describing AI as the defining technological revolution of the present era, the Chief Minister said Karnataka aims to become an AI-native state, where artificial intelligence improves governance,



education, healthcare, agriculture and public services. He highlighted Karnataka's strong technology ecosystem, noting that the state contributes nearly 40 per cent of India's software exports and that Bengaluru is home to over 17,000 startups and numerous Global Capability Centres. Inviting Google to deepen its partnership with Karnataka, Shivakumar called for collaboration in developing AI solutions for education, healthcare, agriculture, climate resilience and governance. He reaffirmed the state's commitment to expanding digital infrastructure, including data centres, to support AI innovation and next-generation digital services. **PTI**

Rajasthan loses over 8 lakh students in two years

Rajasthan has recorded a decline of over eight lakh school students in the past two academic years, with government schools losing more than 9.3 lakh enrolments, according to the latest UDISE+ 2025-26 data. Total enrolment dropped from 1.67 crore in 2023-24 to 1.59 crore in 2025-26, despite the number of teachers increasing. Education experts attributed the trend to falling fertility rates, migration and changing parental aspirations. They said the sharper decline in government schools reflects growing demand for better learning outcomes, safety and accountability, and urged policymakers to prioritise quality education, employability and public confidence over enrolment figures alone. **PTI**



Role of MBA education in nurturing startup ecosystems

RAJESH VERMA
Head of School (HOS), Mittal School of Business, Lovely Professional University (LPU)

India's startup ecosystem has emerged as one of the world's most vibrant innovation hubs, driven by digital transformation, supportive policies, and an ambitious generation of young entrepreneurs. While access to capital and technology has accelerated this growth, the true strength of any startup ecosystem lies in its people. The entrepreneurs who will shape tomorrow's economy must first be equipped with the knowledge, mindset, and practical experience to transform ideas into sustainable businesses. This is where MBA education has a defining role to play. Business schools are no longer expected to produce only managers for corporate organisations; they must nurture entrepreneurial leaders who can innovate, embrace uncertainty, and create long-term value. As industries evolve rapidly under the influence of artificial intelligence, automation, and digital technologies, management education must move beyond theoretical instruction to prepare students for real-world decision-making and problem-solving. India's entrepreneurial journey reflects this changing landscape. According to the Department for Promotion of Industry and Internal Trade (DPIIT), the country has more than 1.8 lakh recognised startups, making it one of the largest startup ecosystems globally. Sustaining this momentum will require institutions to produce graduates who possess not only business acumen but also creativity, resilience, adaptability, and the confidence to build and scale new ventures. Preparing such entrepreneurs calls for a fundamental shift in the way management education is delivered. Entrepreneurship cannot be learnt through lectures alone. The most effective learning happens when classroom concepts are reinforced through indus-



THE FUTURE OF MBA EDUCATION WILL NOT BE MEASURED SOLELY BY PLACEMENTS OR DEGREES AWARDED

try immersion, live consulting projects, startup internships, business simulations, and interactions with founders and investors. Progressive institutions are increasingly adopting outcome-driven learning models that balance academic rigour with practical exposure, ensuring students graduate with both knowledge and experience rather than a degree alone. Equally important is creating opportunities where learning translates into measurable outcomes. Students should be encouraged to participate in consulting assignments, innovation challenges, startup ventures, and paid industry projects during their academic journey. Such experiences not only strengthen professional competencies but also instil confidence, financial responsibility, and an entrepreneurial mindset long before students enter the workforce.

Universities must also move beyond being centres of instruction to becoming catalysts for innovation. Strong startup ecosystems are built when incubation support, industry mentorship, intellectual property guidance, seed funding opportunities, and interdisciplinary collaboration become integral to campus life. Many of today's most successful ventures are born at the intersection of management, technology, healthcare, agriculture, and design, making cross-disciplinary collaboration essential for fostering breakthrough ideas. The rise of artificial intelligence further reinforces the need to reimagine MBA education. AI is no longer a specialised technology; it is transforming every business function, from operations and marketing to finance and customer engagement. Future entrepreneurs must therefore develop AI and digital competencies alongside ethical leadership, sustainability, and responsible decision-making. The businesses that succeed in the coming decade will be those that combine technological innovation with a clear sense of purpose and societal impact. This evolving philosophy is already visible across progressive higher educa-

tion institutions, where classroom learning is increasingly being complemented by industry exposure, entrepreneurship, and experiential projects. Such models encourage students to engage with real-world challenges throughout their academic journey, ensuring that education delivers practical outcomes alongside academic achievement. Ultimately, the greatest outcome of an MBA education is not that every graduate becomes a startup founder. It is that every graduate develops an entrepreneurial mindset characterised by curiosity, resilience, creativity, calculated risk-taking, and a commitment to lifelong learning. These qualities empower individuals to create value whether they launch a new venture, lead an established organisation, or drive innovation from within. As India continues its journey towards becoming a global innovation powerhouse, universities will play a pivotal role in shaping the next generation of entrepreneurs. Institutions that successfully integrate academic excellence with experiential learning, industry partnerships, innovation, and outcome-based education will not only prepare graduates for employment but also empower them to create enterprises, generate opportunities, and contribute meaningfully to the nation's economic and social progress. The future of MBA education will not be measured solely by placements or degrees awarded. Its real success will lie in nurturing innovators, changemakers, and entrepreneurial leaders who have the courage to challenge convention, the capability to solve complex problems, and the vision to build businesses that create a lasting impact on society.

India begins bid for UNSC non-permanent seat

YOSHITA SINGH ■ United Nations

India will ensure that issues such as free, open and rule-based maritime order, including safety of seafarers, and countering terror financing get the “attention they deserve” at the UN Security Council, External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar has said.

Jaishankar made these remarks as he launched India’s official campaign for a non-permanent seat on the UN Security Council (UNSC) for 2028-29 on Monday at an event at the world body’s headquarters, attended by UN ambassadors, diplomats and officials. India has been a non-permanent member of the UNSC eight times so far. The last time it held the seat was in 2021-22.

The minister’s comments come at a time when several Indian seafarers have been killed in strikes



Union External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar during a meeting with United Nations Secretary-General António Guterres in New York

rescued, as commercial vessels came under attack amid escalating tensions in West Asia.

Jaishankar said India is launching its UNSC candidature at a time when the world is facing a “profound paradox”. “Never before has the world possessed such immense capabilities to advance human welfare at this scale. At the same time, we are witnessing levels of conflict, violence and instability that threaten even those who may be very far away,” he said.

“To address this complexity, the United Nations must take the lead and the Security Council must show the way. Elections to its membership, consequently, assume great importance,” he further said. Jaishankar also said that India’s approach to the UN is rooted in ‘SHANTI: Securing Holistic Advancement through Norms, Trust

and Integrity’, as he outlined in detail New Delhi’s priorities for the UNSC term. The priorities he listed were “a voice of the Global South, advancing reformed multilateralism, a future-ready peacekeeping, addressing threats posed due to misuse of AI, securing maritime commons, and countering terror financing”. “In an era where supply chains connect our economies, the world is also increasingly focused on securing the maritime commons,” Jaishankar said.

He said the challenge begins with ensuring adherence to relevant international law, specifically the UN Convention on the Law of the Sea (UNCLOS). “Our collective interest is in maintaining safe and unimpeded flow of maritime commerce,” he said, adding that nations with requisite capabilities must also cooperate to combat piracy. (PTI)

Death toll from Bangkok music bar fire rises to 30

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Bangkok

The death toll from a huge fire in a Bangkok music bar has increased to 30, officials said Tuesday, as the investigation into the blaze proceeded while relatives of the victims took on the grim task of identifying their loved ones and retrieving their bodies.

More than 70 people were injured in the Sunday night tragedy, with 24 of them still in critical condition, according to a statement by the Bangkok Metropolitan Administration.

Initial details about the victims, which have not been updated since Monday, said



18 of the dead were women and nine were men, all Thai except one bar employee from Laos. The injured included 41 women and 34 men.

The blaze at the Rong Beer Na Ladprao bar, the city’s deadliest in 17 years, broke out shortly before midnight in a northern part of the Thai capital. Firefighters needed half an hour to bring it under control.

Trump welcomes new Iraqi PM to the White House

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Washington

President Donald Trump welcomed Iraq’s new prime minister to the White House on Tuesday after strongly backing the political neophyte in his bid for office.

Ali al-Zaidi, a businessman with no political background, emerged as a consensus candidate in Iraq after months of deadlock over the premiership following last year’s parliamentary elections. When al-Zaidi was formally installed as prime minister-designate in April, Trump said in a



social media post that it was the “beginning of a tremendous new chapter between our Nations - Prosperity, Stability, and Success like never seen before.”

But Trump’s interest and involvement in the next leadership in Iraq began long before that statement. Iraq’s dominant parliamentary bloc, the Coordination Framework, a coalition of Shiite parties allied with Iran, initially said it would back former Prime Minister Nouri al-Maliki, whom the Trump administration views as too close to Tehran.

Nasa astronaut embarks on 8-month sojourn to International Space Station

SAGAR KULKARNI
■ Washington

Nasa astronaut Anil Menon and two Russian cosmonauts on Tuesday lifted off onboard a Soyuz MS-29 spacecraft from Kazakhstan on an eight-month mission to the International Space Station. The Roscosmos spacecraft carrying Menon and Russian cosmonauts Pyotr Dubrov and Anna Kikina lifted off from the Baikonur cosmodrome at 8:17 pm IST.

After a two-orbit, three-hour trip to the station, the spacecraft will automatically dock at 11.56 pm IST to the Prichal module. This marks Menon’s first spaceflight and the second flight for the Russian cosmonauts, according to NASA.

Menon’s family members, including astronaut wife Anna Wilhelm, and NASA Administrator Jared Isaacman, were at the Baikonur cosmodrome for the spaceflight. Once aboard, the trio will join NASA astro-



Expedition 75 Roscosmos cosmonaut Anna Kikina, top, NASA astronaut Anil Menon, middle, and Roscosmos cosmonaut Pyotr Dubrov, bottom, wave farewell prior to boarding the Soyuz MS-29 spacecraft for launch, at the Baikonur Cosmodrome in Kazakhstan

nauts Jessica Meir, Jack Hathaway, and Chris Williams, European Space Agency astronaut Sophie Adenot, and Roscosmos cosmonauts Sergey Kud-Sverchkov, Sergei Mikae, and Andrey Fedyaev.

Menon, Dubrov and Kikina’s mission will last about eight months, and

they are scheduled to return to Earth in April 2027. Menon will “conduct scientific research and technology demonstrations aimed at advancing human space exploration and benefiting life on Earth,” according to NASA. Yelena Remizova, head of Russia’s agency for international humanitarian coop-

eration Rosstrudnichestvo, earlier told state-run TASS news agency that the rocket will carry with it drawings made by Indian schoolchildren. “These are the works of the winners of the ‘First Forever’ competition, dedicated to the 65th anniversary of the flight of the first Earth astronaut, Yuri Gagarin, and cooperation between Russia and India in the field of space exploration,” she said.

Born in Minneapolis to Ukrainian and Indian immigrants, Menon is an emergency medicine physician and a US Space Force colonel. During his stint with the US Air Force, he served on the frontlines in Afghanistan during Operation Enduring Freedom and also worked for the Himalayan Rescue Association, caring for climbers on Mount Everest.

Menon’s father, Shankaran, hails from Ottapalam in Kerala’s Palakkad district.

His mother, Elizabeth, is an immigrant from Ukraine to America. (PTI)

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DEMAND NOTICE			
Whereas the borrowers/co-borrowers/guarantors/mortgagors mentioned hereunder had availed the financial assistance from Axis Bank Ltd. We state that despite having availed the financial assistance, the borrowers/guarantors/mortgagors have committed various defaults in repayment of interest and principal amounts as per due dates. The account has been classified as Non Performing Asset on the respective dates mentioned hereunder in accordance with the directives/guidelines issued by Reserve Bank of India, consequent to the Authorized Officer of Axis Bank Ltd. under Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 & in exercise of powers conferred under Section 13(12) read with Rule 3 of Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002 issued Demand Notices on respective dates mentioned herein below under Section 13(2) of SARFAESI Act, 2002 calling upon the following borrowers/guarantors/mortgagors to repay the amount mentioned in the notices together with further interest at the contractual rate on the amount mentioned in the notices and incidental expenses, cost, charges etc until the date of payment within 60 days from the date of receipt of notices. The notices issued to them on their last known addresses have returned un-served and as such they are hereby informed by way of public notice about the same.			
Sr. No.	Name of Borrower / Co-borrower / Guarantor	1. NPA Date	2. Demand Notice Date
1.	1. Umesh (Borrower) H No.-32/11, Subhash Nagar, Ward No-07, Near Dholbi Ghat, Gurgaon-122001, 2. Srujita (Co-Borrower) H No.-32/11, Subhash Nagar, Ward No-07, Near Dholbi Ghat, Gurgaon-122001	1. 09-Jan-18	2. 25-05-2026
2.	1. Mr. Deepak Rawat (Borrower) F-561, Delta-1, Greater Noida, Uttar Pradesh-201301, 2. Mrs. Meena Rawat (Co-Borrower) F-561, Delta-1, Greater Noida, Uttar Pradesh-201301	1. 01-Jul-2022	2. 25-05-2026
3.	1. Mr. Jatin Appudhaya (Borrower) House No. 833/13, Pratap Nagar, Near Ram Mandir, Gurgaon, Haryana-122001, 2. Mrs. Mamta (Co-Borrower) House No. 833/13, Pratap Nagar, Near Ram Mandir, Gurgaon, Haryana-122001	1. 09-Dec-22	2. 27-May-2026
4.	1. Ashesh Kumar Pandey (Borrower) Flat No-201, Plot No. 149, Gyan Khand-01, Indira Puram, Ghaziabad-201012, Also At: 671, B/7, Govindpur, Kalkaji, New Delhi-110019, 2. Roop Rani (Co-Borrower) Flat No-201, Plot No. 149, Gyan Khand-01, Indira Puram, Ghaziabad-201012	1. 08-Jun-23	2. 21-May-26
5.	1. Mr. K. Ramesh Kumar (Borrower) Flat No. 149, Gyan Khand-01, Indira Puram, Ghaziabad-201012, Also At: 671, B/7, Govindpur, Kalkaji, New Delhi-110019, 2. Roop Rani (Co-Borrower) Flat No-201, Plot No. 149, Gyan Khand-01, Indira Puram, Ghaziabad-201012	1. 08-Jun-23	2. 21-May-26
6.	1. Shashank Chaurasia (Borrower) Flat No-287 D Floor, DDA Affordable Flat Sector-13, Dwarka, New Delhi-110075, 2. Shantini Rajpal (Borrower) 1820, First Floor, DDA, Faridabad, Haryana-121005	1. 10-Dec-16	2. 25-05-2026
7.	1. Brijesh Wallia (Borrower) D-199, G-2, Ramprastha Colony, Ghaziabad, Uttar Pradesh-201011, 2. Priyanka Wallia (Co-Borrower) D-199, G-2, Ramprastha Colony, Ghaziabad, Uttar Pradesh-201011	1. 01-Jan-2022	2. 21-May-26
8.	1. Mr. Santosh Kumar Jha (Borrower) R/o. House No. 178, Shih, Ward No. 30, Ballabgarh, Patwari, Mohalla, Faridabad, Haryana-121006, 2. Mrs. Mala Devi (Co-Borrower) R/o. House No. 178, Shih, Ward No. 30, Ballabgarh, Patwari, Mohalla, Faridabad, Haryana-121006	1. 09-Oct-2025	2. 26-Oct-2026
9.	1. Mahesh Kumar Chauhan (Borrower) 68 B, MIG, Sector-82, Madhuban Apartment, Noida, UP-201301, 2. Archana Chauhan (Co-Borrower) 68 B, MIG, Sector-82, Madhuban Apartment, Noida, UP-201301	1. 30-Oct-25	2. 06-Jun-26
10.	1. Sabir Rahman (Borrower) GF Gali No-17, Gopal Pur, Near Hill View, Sector-11, Sohna, Gurgaon, Haryana-122004, Also At: Rohit Singh S/o Uma Shankar Singh, TLG India Pvt Ltd, Plot No. 90D, Udyog Vihar Phase-4, Sector-18 Gurugram-122001	1. 05-May-24	2. 22-Oct-2026
11.	1. Harpal Singh Dangli (Borrower) 663/10, First Floor, Krishna Colony, Gurgaon, Haryana, India-122001, 2. Gurpreet Kaur (Co-Borrower) 663/10, First Floor, Krishna Colony, Gurgaon, Haryana-122001	1. 02-May-24	2. 22-Oct-2026
12.	1. Sunil Chauhan (Borrower) House No GF, Rajiv Colony, Naharpur Road, Near Global School, Gurgaon, Haryana-122001, 2. Poonam Devi (Co-Borrower) House No GF, Rajiv Colony, Naharpur Road, Near Global School, Gurgaon, Haryana-122001	1. 08-Jan-24	2. 22-Oct-2026
13.	1. Rajesh Kumar (Borrower) H No-128, Pandwala Kalan, South West, Delhi-110043, 2. Gelsi (Co-Borrower) H No-128, Pandwala Kalan, South West, Delhi-110043	1. 03-Oct-2022	2. 22-Oct-2026
14.	1. Rohit Singh S/o Uma Shankar Singh (Borrower) Flat No. 1004, Tower-5, Vipul Lavanya, Sector-81, Gurgaon-122004, Also At: Rohit Singh S/o Uma Shankar Singh, TLG India Pvt Ltd, Plot No. 90D, Udyog Vihar Phase-4, Sector-18 Gurugram-122001	1. 10-Mar-23	2. 06-Jun-26
15.	1. Karandeep Singh Mudder S/o Kuldeep Singh Mudder (Borrower) 394, Ground Floor, Chittaranjan Park, New Delhi, India-110019, Also At: Karandeep Singh Mudder S/o Kuldeep Singh Mudder, Axis Bank Ltd, B-146 Saket, New Delhi-110017, Also At: Karandeep Singh Mudder S/o Kuldeep Singh Mudder, Property No. WLN033/PON 13, Woodlands Heights Rajapura, Bangalore-560001	1. 11-Mar-19	2. 08-Oct-2026
16.	1. Under Dev S/o Surat Singh (Borrower) House No. 201, Block-20, Triok Puri, Chilla, Saroda, Khadar, East Delhi, India-110091, Also At: Under Dev S/o Surat Singh, Indus Studio, 27/12/13 Triok Puri, Near Mayur Vihar Phase-1, Delhi-110091, Also At: Under Dev S/o Surat Singh, Unit No. 1211A, 13th Floor, Block-H, TS-1 Sector-17A, Yamuna Expressway Industrial Development Authority, Noida-201303, 2. Sharda Dev (Co-Borrower) House No. 201, Block-20, Triok Puri, Chilla, Saroda, Khadar, East Delhi, India-110091, Also At: Sharda W/o Under Dev, Unit No. 1211A, 13th Floor, Block-H, TS-1 Sector-17A, Yamuna Expressway Industrial Development Authority, Noida-201303	1. 08-Jan-26	2. 08-Oct-2026
17.	1. Karandeep Singh Mudder S/o Kuldeep Singh Mudder (Borrower) 394, Ground Floor, Chittaranjan Park, New Delhi, India-110019, Also At: Karandeep Singh Mudder S/o Kuldeep Singh Mudder, Axis Bank Ltd, B-146 Saket, New Delhi-110017, Also At: Karandeep Singh Mudder S/o Kuldeep Singh Mudder, Property No. WLN033/PON 13, Woodlands Heights Rajapura, Bangalore-560001	1. 11-Mar-19	2. 08-Oct-2026
18.	1. Abhishek Kumar Gautam (Borrower) Ward 31, Near Airtel Tower, Agrawa Sri Krishna Nagar, Motihari, East Champaran, Bihar-845406, 2. Shalendra Prasad Singh (Co-Borrower) Ward 31, Near Airtel Tower, Agrawa Sri Krishna Nagar, Motihari, East Champaran, Bihar-845406	1. 06-Nov-20	2. 21-May-26
19.	1. Mr. Arun Sarna S/o. Mr. Kanwal Sarna (Borrower) Plot No-721, Second Floor, Sector-5, Vaishali, Ghaziabad, Uttar Pradesh-201012, Also At: Mr. Arun Sarna, M/s. Sarna Enterprises, Shop No-111, Ring Road Market, Opp Noveraj Nagar, South Delhi, India-110029, Also At: Mr. Arun Sarna, First Floor, Property No. B-3, Krishna Nagar, Ghondli Illaga, Shahdara, Delhi-110051	1. 13-May-2026	2. 15-Jun-2026
20.	1. Ms. Devyani (Borrower) W/o. Mr. Rahul Kumar Rath, 11/222, 2nd Floor, Sector-33, Rajendra Nagar, Sahibabad, Ghaziabad, Uttar Pradesh-201005 (Applicant), Also At: Ms. Devyani, Flat No-516, Tower-SAT9, 5th Floor, Blossom Zest, Plot No GH-02, Sec-143, Noida, UP-201305, 2. Rahul Kumar Sarna (Co-Borrower) 11/222, 2nd Floor, Sector-33, Rajendra Nagar, Sahibabad, Ghaziabad, Uttar Pradesh-201005 (Co-Applicant)	1. 08-Jun-26	2. 20-Jun-2026
21.	1. Ranjit Kumar Sharma (Borrower) C-312, Sector-19, Noida-201301, 2. Meena Sharma (Co-Borrower) C-312, Sector-19, Noida-201301	1. 09-Nov-2020	2. 21-May-26
22.	1. Bighneshwar (Borrower) B-109, Gali No-3, Budh Vihar, Saraswati Public School, Mnanooli, Delhi-110093, 2. Sunanda Sharma (Co-Borrower) B-109, Gali No-3, Budh Vihar, Saraswati Public School, Mnanooli, Delhi-110093	1. 08-Jun-24	2. 22-Oct-2026
23.	1. Mr. Naveen Kumar (Borrower) R/o. Flat No. 8105, Plot No. GH-07, Crossing Republic, Near ABS Engineering College, Ghaziabad, U.P. 201012, 2. Mrs. Anamika (Co-Borrower) R/o. Flat No. 8105, Plot No. GH-07, Crossing Republic, Near ABS Engineering College, Ghaziabad, U.P. 201012	1. 08-Jun-24	2. 22-Oct-2026
24.	1. Mr. Sanjay Sharma (Borrower) R/o. Flat No. A-244, First Floor, New Panchari, Near Panchari School, Ghaziabad, U.P. 201010, Also At: Mr. Sanjay Sharma A/130, Sector-3, Chiranjeev Vihar, Kavi Nagar, Ghaziabad-201002, 2. Mrs. Urvasi Sharma (Co-Borrower) R/o. Flat No. A-244, First Floor, New Panchari, Near Panchari School, Ghaziabad, U.P. 201010	1. 30-Oct-2026	2. 14-Oct-2026
25.	1. Mr. Sanjay Negi (Borrower) HNo. 544, Surya Nagar, Ph-2, Sector-91, Giasi Koti-1, Faridabad, Haryana-121013, Also At: Mr. Sanjay Negi (Borrower) B-68, Old Power, H-Colony, Faridabad, Haryana-121002, 2. Mr. Rajesh Negi (Co-Borrower) HNo. 544, Surya Nagar, Ph-2, Sector-91, Giasi Koti-1, Faridabad, Haryana-121013, Also At: Mr. Rajesh Negi (Co-Borrower) B-68, Old Power, H-Colony, Faridabad, Haryana-121002	1. 08-Nov-24	2. 18-Jun-26
26.	1. Mrs. Rhythm (Borrower) W/o. Mr. Anshuman Singh, B-119, 6th Pilkhani Street, Sector Gamma-1, Kasana, G B Nagar, Noida, Uttar Pradesh-201310, 2. Mr. Anshuman Singh (Co-Borrower) S/o. Mr. Arjun Singh, B-119, 6th Pilkhani Street, Sector Gamma-1, Kasana, G B Nagar, Noida, Uttar Pradesh-201310	1. 08-Jun-26	2. 20-Jun-2026
27.	1. Mr. Sanjay Sharma (Borrower) R/o. Flat No. A-244, First Floor, New Panchari, Near Panchari School, Ghaziabad, U.P. 201010, Also At: Mr. Sanjay Sharma A/130, Sector-3, Chiranjeev Vihar, Kavi Nagar, Ghaziabad-201002, 2. Mrs. Urvasi Sharma (Co-Borrower) R/o. Flat No. A-244, First Floor, New Panchari, Near Panchari School, Ghaziabad, U.P. 201010	1. 30-Oct-2026	2. 14-Oct-2026
28.	1. Mr. Sanjay Sharma (Borrower) R/o. Flat No. A-244, First Floor, New Panchari, Near Panchari School, Ghaziabad, U.P. 201010, Also At: Mr. Sanjay Sharma A/130, Sector-3, Chiranjeev Vihar, Kavi Nagar, Ghaziabad-201002, 2. Mrs. Urvasi Sharma (Co-Borrower) R/o. Flat No. A-244, First Floor, New Panchari, Near Panchari School, Ghaziabad, U.P. 201010	1. 30-Oct-2026	2. 14-Oct-2026
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31.	1. Mr. Sanjay Sharma (Borrower) R/o. Flat No. A-244, First Floor, New Panchari, Near Panchari School, Ghaziabad, U.P. 201010, Also At: Mr. Sanjay Sharma A/130, Sector-3, Chiranjeev Vihar, Kavi Nagar, Ghaziabad-201002, 2. Mrs. Urvasi Sharma (Co-Borrower) R/o. Flat No. A-244, First Floor, New Panchari, Near Panchari School, Ghaziabad, U.P. 201010	1. 30-Oct-2026	2. 14-Oct-2026
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41.	1. Mr. Sanjay Sharma (Borrower) R/o. Flat No. A-244, First Floor, New Panchari, Near Panchari School, Ghaziabad, U.P. 201010, Also At: Mr. Sanjay Sharma A/130, Sector-3, Chiranjeev Vihar, Kavi Nagar, Ghaziabad-201002, 2. Mrs. Urvasi Sharma (Co-Borrower) R/o. Flat No. A-244, First Floor, New Panchari, Near Panchari School, Ghaziabad, U.P. 201010	1. 30-Oct-2026	2. 14-Oct-2026
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52.	1. Mr. Sanjay Sharma (Borrower) R/o. Flat No. A-244, First Floor, New Panchari, Near Panchari School, Ghaziabad, U.P. 201010, Also At: Mr. Sanjay Sharma A/130, Sector-3, Chiranjeev Vihar, Kavi Nagar, Ghaziabad-201002, 2. Mrs. Urvasi Sharma (Co-Borrower) R/o. Flat No. A-244, First Floor, New Panchari, Near Panchari School, Ghaziabad, U.P. 201010	1. 30-Oct-2026	2. 14-Oct-2026
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55.	1. Mr. Sanjay Sharma (Borrower) R/o. Flat No. A-244, First Floor, New Panchari, Near Panchari School, Ghaziabad, U.P. 201010, Also At: Mr. Sanjay Sharma A/130, Sector-3, Chiranjeev Vihar, Kavi Nagar, Ghaziabad-201002, 2. Mrs. Urvasi Sharma (Co-Borrower) R/o. Flat No. A-244, First Floor, New Panchari, Near Panchari School, Ghaziabad, U.P. 201010	1. 30-Oct-2026	2. 14-Oct-2026
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SBI

STATE BANK OF INDIA

E-AUCTION
SALE NOTICE

HOME LOAN CENTRE/RACPC -2, RAMA COMPLEX, SOHNA ROAD, BADSHAHPUR, GURUGRAM-122016

NOTICE FOR E-AUCTION SALE ON 10.08.2026 FOR MOVABLE PROPERTY

E-Auction Sale Notice for Sale of Movable Assets under the Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 read with proviso to Rule 8(6) of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002.

Notice is hereby given to the public in general and in particular to the Borrower(s) and Guarantor(s) that the below described movable property hypothecated /charged to the Secured Creditor, the physical possession of which has been taken by the Authorized Officer State Bank of India, the Secured Creditor, will be sold on "As is Where is", "As is What is" and "Whatever there is" on 10.08.2026, if recovery of bank due to the secured creditor as under:-

Interested bidder may deposit Pre-Bid EMD with BAANKNET before the close of e-Auction. Credit of Pre-Bid EMD shall be given to the bidder only after receipt of payment in BAANKNET's Bank Account and up-dation of such information in the e-auction website. This may take some time as per banking process and hence bidders, in their own interest, are advised to submit the pre-bid EMD amount well in advance to avoid any last minute problem.

Date / Time of E-Auction on10.08.2026 for 6 Hours from 10:00 AM to 04:00 PM with unlimited extn. of 10 minute each.

S. No.	Name of the Borrower(s) / Guarantor(s)	Outstanding Dues for Recovery of which Property /ies is/are being Sold	Vehicle Description	Reserve Price (Rs.) (below which property could not be sold)	Name of the Authorised (Signatory)
				Earnest Money (EMD) 10% of the Reserve Price	
				Bid Increment Amount	
1.	Mr. Robin Yadav S/o Mr. Satish Yadav Village-Fazilpur, Badli Fazilpur, Farukh Nagar, Gurugram-122506 Car Loan A/c.: 41159874224	Rs.7,32,245/- Plus Interest w.e.f. 14/07/2026 with further interest and incidental expenses, costs, charges etc. thereon	Make & Model: Mahindra XUV 300 W8 DS BS6 MT Regn. No.: HR76GT125 Engine No.: EUNZF20724 Chassis No.: MA1NM2EU1N2F79452 Date of Regn.: 08/02/2022	₹ 6,70,000.00	(Chief Manager) Home Loan Centre-2 Gurugram
				₹ 7,00,000.00	
				₹ 5,00,000.	Mr. Naveen Nagar Mobile: 9813314646
				*GST as applicable	

Last Date of EMD Deposit on or before 10.08.2026 upto 08:00 A.M.

Account Wallet in which EMD to be remitted : Bidder's own wallet Registered with BAANKNET on its e-auction site: <https://baanknet.com/auaction-psb/eproc-listing> by means of NEFT/RETS. EMD of Reserve Price to be transferred by bidders by means of challan generated on his/her/bidder account maintained with BAANKNET on its e-auction site: <https://baanknet.com/auaction-psb/eproc-listing> by means of NEFT from his/her/bank. For any assistance, please call please call BAANKNET HELPDESK: +91 8291202200, support.BAANKNET@psballiance.com and/or Authorized Officer.

TERMS AND CONDITIONS OF THE E-AUCTION ARE AS UNDER:

(1) E-Auction is being held on "As is where is", "as is what is basis" and "whatever there is basis" and will be conducted "On Line". The auction will be conducted through the Bank's approved service provider BAANKNET at their web portal: <https://baanknet.com/auaction-psb/eproc-listing>

(2) Bank shall reserve the right to cancel/postpone the auction.

(3) The Vehicle are available for inspection during banking hours on 08.08.2026 From 10:00 AM to 04:00 PM., Contact Person: Mr. Praveen Nagar, Mob: 9813314646, (Resolution Agent) & Mr. Narendar Singh Mob: 7055610161 (SBI, NPA Manager)

(4) * Successful bidder to pay GST as applicable on the successful bid amount. viz sale value.

(5) To the best of knowledge and information of the Authorized Officer there is no encumbrance on the property/ies. However the intending bidder should make their own independent inquiries regarding the encumbrances, title of the property/ies put on auction and claims/lights/dues/affecting the property prior to submitting their bid.
The e-Auction Advertisement does not constitute and will not be deemed to constitute any commitment or any representation of the Bank. The property is being sold with all the existing and future encumbrances whether known or unknown to the bank. The Authorized Officer shall not be responsible in any way for any third party claims/rights/dues.

(6) The Earnest Money Deposit (EMD) of the successful bidder shall be retained towards part sale consideration and the EMD of the unsuccessful bidders shall be refunded. The Earnest Money Deposit shall not bear any interest. The successful bidder shall have to deposit 25% of the sale price, immediately on acceptance of bid price by the Authorized Officer and the balance of the sale price on or before 15th day of the sale. Default in deposit of amount by the successful bidder would entail forfeiture of the whole money already deposited and property shall be put to the e-auction and the defaulting bidder shall have no claim/right in respect of property /amount.

(7) For detailed terms and conditions of the sale please refer to the link at the Bank's Service Provider's web portal: <https://baanknet.com/auaction-psb/eproc-listing> & e-auction website: <https://BAANKNET.com>

Date: 14.07.2026 Place: Gurugram

Authorized Officer, State Bank of India, Home Loan Centre /RACPC-2, Gurugram



Indian techie drives AI-powered banking transformation in UK



Ashish Chatterjee, an Indian technology leader with more than 18 years of international experience, is playing a key role in transforming the UK's banking sector by leading large-scale digital modernisation projects powered by cloud computing, Open Banking and artificial intelligence (AI). Chatterjee recently led the development of an Open Banking platform for a major UK bank serving one of Britain's largest retail brands.

Built on a cloud-native microservices architecture, the platform supports between six and eight million registered users and processes three to five million transactions every day.

The system was delivered with 99.99 percent uptime and zero production defects, achieved through automated quality assurance, CI/CD pipelines and blue-green deployment strategies. Alongside the platform upgrade, Chatterjee also directed a structured AI transformation programme.

India and Sudan advance strategic healthcare partnership through India-Sudan Medicine Corridor

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The India & Arab Countries Chamber of Commerce, Industry & Agriculture (IACCIA), in collaboration with the Embassy of the Republic of Sudan in New Delhi, successfully convened the India-Sudan Medicine Corridor, a high-level roundtable dedicated to exploring business and investment opportunities in Sudan's pharmaceutical and healthcare sectors. The event brought together senior diplomats, leading Indian pharmaceutical companies, healthcare providers, medical device manufacturers, investors, regulatory experts, and representatives from both India and Sudan to discuss practical avenues for strengthening bilateral cooperation in healthcare, pharmaceuticals, medical technology, and healthcare investment.

A special highlight of the roundtable was a recorded keynote address by the Honourable Federal Minister of Health of the Republic of Sudan, H.E. Dr Heitham Mohamed Ibrahim, who underscored Sudan's commitment to rebuilding and modernising its healthcare system. He highlighted the country's strategic geopolitical position as a gateway to Africa and the Middle East and invited Indian pharmaceutical and healthcare companies to take full advantage of the investment incentives, business-friendly policies, and



H.E. Dr Mohammed Abdalla Ali Eltom, Ambassador of the Republic of Sudan to India, and Dr. Wael Awwad Secretary General India and Arab Countries Chamber of Commerce, Industry and Agriculture (IACCIA) during the India-Sudan Medicine Corridor High-level roundtable on business opportunities in Sudan's pharmaceutical and healthcare sectors, in New Delhi.

PANKAJ KUMAR

opportunities offered by the Government of Sudan. The Minister also welcomed the proposal to send a high-level Indian pharmaceutical and healthcare delegation to Sudan to explore long-term partnerships and investments.

The roundtable was inaugurated by H.E. Dr Mohammed Eltom, Ambassador of the Republic of Sudan to India, who outlined Sudan's vision for rebuilding and modernising its healthcare sector through strategic international partnerships. He emphasised the significant opportunities available for Indian pharmaceutical manufacturers, healthcare institutions, medical technology companies, and investors to contribute to Sudan's healthcare development while establishing mutually beneficial commercial partnerships.

Opening the session, Dr Wael Awwad, Secretary General of the India & Arab Countries Chamber of Commerce, Industry & Agriculture (IACCIA), emphasised that the India-Sudan Medicine Corridor represents a strategic platform to deepen economic cooperation between the two countries by facilitating investment, technology transfer, pharmaceutical manufacturing, healthcare services, research collaboration, and capacity building.

The discussions focused on several priority areas, including: Establishment of pharmaceutical manufacturing facilities and joint ventures in Sudan. Export of affordable, high-quality Indian medicines, vaccines, and medical consumables. Technology transfer and local pharmaceutical production. Development of

hospitals and healthcare infrastructure. Medical equipment, diagnostics, and digital healthcare solutions. Regulatory cooperation and harmonization of pharmaceutical standards. Health care workforce development, education, and professional training. Strengthening pharmaceutical supply chains and logistics. Investment opportunities across Sudan's healthcare and life sciences sectors.

A major outcome of the roundtable was the strong interest expressed by leading Indian pharmaceutical companies in exploring investment and partnership opportunities in Sudan. Participants unanimously agreed that the next phase of cooperation should involve a high-level Indian pharmaceutical and healthcare business delegation to Sudan to assess invest-

ment opportunities, engage with Sudanese government agencies and private sector stakeholders, and identify projects for pharmaceutical manufacturing, distribution, hospital development, and healthcare services.

The participants also agreed to establish an India-Sudan Healthcare and Pharmaceutical Business Council under the framework of the India-Sudan Medicine Corridor. The proposed council will serve as a permanent platform for promoting business dialogue, facilitating B2B partnerships, encouraging joint ventures, supporting technology transfer, and advancing long-term cooperation in pharmaceuticals, healthcare services, medical technology, research, and investment. Representatives of India's leading pharmaceutical companies welcomed Sudan's commitment to creating a conducive environment for foreign investment and expressed readiness to participate in Sudan's healthcare reconstruction, pharmaceutical manufacturing, and capacity-building initiatives.

The roundtable concluded with a shared commitment to transform the discussions into concrete projects through regular business engagements, investment missions, technical cooperation, and institutional partnerships. IACCIA will work closely with the Embassy of the Republic of Sudan and relevant stakeholders in both countries to

implement the agreed roadmap and coordinate the proposed Indian business delegation to Sudan.

Speaking at the conclusion of the meeting, Dr Wael Awwad stated, "The India-Sudan Medicine Corridor is far more than a trade initiative; it is a strategic partnership that brings together India's globally recognized pharmaceutical and healthcare expertise with Sudan's ambitious vision for rebuilding its healthcare system. Today's roundtable has laid the foundation for a long-term partnership based on investment, innovation, local manufacturing, technology transfer, and improved access to quality healthcare. Together, India and Sudan can build a sustainable healthcare ecosystem that serves not only Sudan but also the wider African region."

IACCIA extends its sincere appreciation to the Embassy of the Republic of Sudan in New Delhi, under the leadership of H.E. Dr Mohammed Eltom, for hosting this landmark initiative.

The Chamber also expresses its gratitude to the Honourable Federal Minister of Health of Sudan, H.E. Dr Heitham Mohamed Ibrahim, for his inspiring keynote message, and to all participating pharmaceutical companies, healthcare institutions, business leaders, investors, and experts whose valuable contributions helped shape a practical roadmap for future India-Sudan healthcare cooperation.

Bansal family's ₹2 lakh crore real estate vision through M3M is reshaping India's luxury housing landscape

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Gurugram

The Bansal Family, through its real estate platforms M3M India and Smartworld Developers, has built one of India's largest privately held real estate development businesses, with a Gross Development Value (GDV) of over 71,28,731 crore and a fully paid land bank of more than 3,000 acres across the NCR.

Building on this scale and financial strength, the Bansal Family has outlined an investment roadmap of approximately 710,000 crore

for FY27 towards construction and strategic land acquisitions. The Group remains net debt-free, is 100 percent promoter-owned, and holds an investment-grade rating, providing the flexibility to pursue long-term growth while maintaining disciplined capital allocation, according to a Press release.

Today, the Bansal Family has delivered over 30.6 million sq. ft. across 34 projects, including more than 14,000 homes. It is currently developing another 57.2 million sq. ft. across 40 ongoing projects and plans



to deliver an additional 1,000 homes over the next three months.

The Bansal Family has also recorded the highest residential delivery volume in the NCR for the last three

consecutive years, reinforcing its reputation for timely execution, quality, and customer trust.

Beyond residential development, the Bansal Family has also established itself as

North India's largest retail developer with over 11.2 million sq. ft., backed by an extensive portfolio of destination retail assets and a robust leasing platform.

Expanding beyond

Gurugram, the Family has strengthened its presence in Noida through the first self-owned M3M The Cullinan Emporium, comprising nearly 1 million sq. ft. of premium retail space and

serving as a high-quality retail and rental asset mall. Its development pipeline comprises Branded Residences (8%), Bridge-to-Luxury Housing (29%), Premium Residential (26%), Luxury Residential (19%), Retail (13%), Office (4%), and Industrial (2%) of its total saleable area.

Bansal Family commands India's largest branded residences portfolio spanning nearly 6.9 million sq. ft., developed in partnership with global luxury brands including The Trump Organization, ELIE SAAB and Jacob & Co. Branded resi-

dences alone account for a revenue potential exceeding 720,000 crore, while the Bansal Family is in advanced discussions to introduce five to six additional global luxury brands over the next few years, further strengthening its leadership in India's branded residences market.

Its latest flagship initiative, The Billionaire's Block at Smart City Delhi Airport in Sector 111, Gurugram, seeks to create what the company describes as the world's first integrated ultra-luxury district exclusively designed for billionaires.

DAILY SUDOKU

1	7		2	5		9		
4		8					3	
			5		8			
	9	4	5		3			
	6						9	
			2		9	7	6	
		6		8				
	4				6		8	
3	5		7			1	4	

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★☆☆☆☆

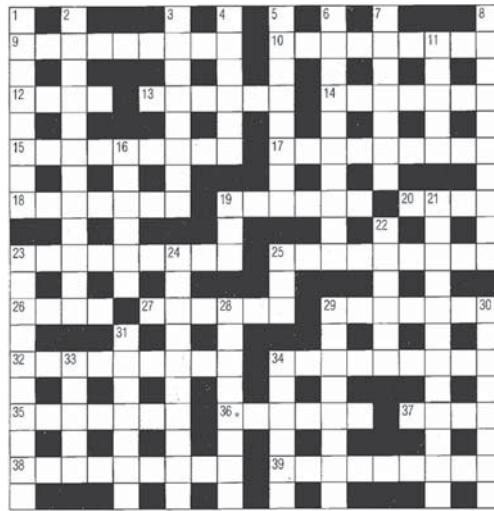
HOW TO SOLVE IT

Sudoku is a logic puzzle where you fill a 9x9 grid so that numbers 1 to 9 appear once in every row, column, and 3x3 box, using elimination and logical deduction—no maths involved.



SOLUTION (14.7.26)								
9	1	4	2	6	8	5	7	3
8	3	5	9	7	1	2	4	6
2	6	7	5	3	4	1	8	9
5	7	3	1	2	6	8	9	4
1	8	9	7	4	3	6	2	5
4	2	6	8	9	5	3	1	7
7	9	1	3	5	2	4	6	8
3	4	2	6	8	7	9	5	1
6	5	8	4	1	9	7	3	2

DOUBLE CROSSWORD WEDNESDAY | JULY 15, 2026



ACROSS

- 9 Begin to talk about one taking to drink (9)
- 10 Not knowing the thread had fallen into the ink (2,3,4)
- 12 A soft light, please (4)
- 13 The room needs a dust badly. I will get round to it (6)
- 14 Attacks the insects surrounding the animal (7)
- 15 Appalled at having broken? (9)
- 17 The one making the speech is the bowler (9)
- 18 They make for the woods (7)
- 19 Underline "anxiety" (6)

DOWN

- 1 Either created or was cool and calm (8)
- 2 Hale and hearty though bowed? (3,2,1,6)
- 3 In the past, impressionistic bird designs (4)
- 4 Was inclined to, if one cared for (6)
- 5 Complaint from the mess (8)
- 6 In the main, it's a great leveller (10)
- 7 Sould for getting the material overprocessed (7)
- 8 When it comes to tall stories, this beats all! (10)
- 11 A fellow having a half of bitter as a chaser (5)
- 16 Allow the nippers to put in an appearance (6)
- 19 Understand, when the note is sounded

- 20 Shut up after a firm "Get work" (4)
- 23 Was fast and furious: the sea being rough (4,5)
- 25 Save money by getting a local job (9)
- 26 "Squandered" has a sad sound to it (4)
- 27 Is depressed about, when you repudiate (9)
- 29 Very happy, now the train is moving out (9)
- 32 Help the ladies carry out and put away (4)
- 34 Stuff the man's with meat (9)
- 35 Bag and keep everybody in detention (9)
- 36 Cut back to the relations as they put the children to bed (4,2)
- 37 It's rotten being short of money (4)
- 38 A Mrs Green ordering a duck (9)
- 39 One's utmost to get even? (5,4)

- 21 An outdated drink? (3-9)
- 22 As chief, he doesn't succeed (6)
- 23 Is it not still providing you with accommodation? (6,4)
- 24 Not having a ghost of eagerness and energy? (10)
- 25 Don't allow to catch up (3)
- 28 It's clear anger does exhaust one (8)
- 29 Get back again at three, with a girl (8)
- 30 Yet, perhaps, deserve to be admitted, having boldness (8)
- 31 On the surface, would appear to be the first Scotsman ever (7)
- 33 Angry, I left in "backward and a shirker" (5)
- 34 Preserve from trouble (6)

India building world's second-largest data centre capacity, says man who has built 20% of it

ABHINAV KUMAR JHA
■ New Delhi

India is currently building the second-largest number of data centres in the world after the United States, and one Mumbai-based company claims it has already commissioned or built approximately 20 percent of that total capacity since 2019, according to Varun Maniar, Managing Director of Electromech InfraProjects, which constructs electrical, mechanical, cooling, and fire safety systems for data centres across the country.

Maniar, who returned to India from careers in financial services in the US and the UK in 2013, started Electromech, building small data centres for multinational corporations within large office buildings. The large-scale opportunity came in 2019, when Microsoft, Amazon, and other global cloud players began investing seriously in Indian cloud infrastructure. Since then, the company has grown to become what Maniar describes as a top-three contractor in the space, working with all five of the largest data centre developers in India, whose names he cannot disclose due to non-disclosure agreements.

The business of building data centres, he explains, is not the same as owning them. The land and power belong to the data centre operator, who then contracts out the technical construction of electrical systems, cooling systems, mechanical systems, and IT infrastructure to companies like Electromech.

The racks inside the data centre, where the actual data is stored, belong to the end customer, whether that is Amazon, Netflix, a bank, or a government institution.

On the question of data centres consuming enormous amounts of water, a concern that has been widely reported in the context of AI infrastructure growth, Maniar is pointed. "That is true in America. It is not true in India," he says. Indian data centres use air-cooled chiller technology rather than the water-cooled tower systems used in older American facilities.

New AI data centres additionally use liquid cooling with chemical coolants rather than water. He describes much of the public concern as fear-mongering unsupported by

actual consumption figures for Indian facilities.

"Nobody's saying that in one data centre in India, how much water is needed. People are just saying it needs a lot of water, a lot of water."

On the broader challenge of scaling up, Maniar is candid. The bottleneck is not land or power for his company.

It is people. Building two to three times the current capacity requires the right teams, project managers, supply chains, technicians, and partners, all at significantly greater scale.

RAJIV GANDHI NATIONAL UNIVERSITY OF LAW, PUNJAB

[Established under the Punjab Act No. 12 of 2006]
Advt. No. RGNUL/61/2026 dt. 13.07.2026
M.A. (ENGLISH) PROGRAMME
(Department of Literary and Cultural Studies)

Applications are invited from eligible graduates for admission to the Two Year M.A. (English) Programme at Rajiv Gandhi National University of Law, Punjab for the Academic Session 2026-2028. The programme offers 40 seats and is designed to provide students with a strong foundation in literary studies, cultural studies, critical theory, digital humanities, and interdisciplinary research, along with opportunities for academic specialization. The last date to submit the online application form is **16 August 2026 (11:59 PM)**. Details regarding the Programme Structure, Fee, Eligibility, Admission Form, and Reservation Policy are available on the University website: www.rgnul.ac.in

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Vice-Chancellor

0175-2391200 0175-2391600 Website: www.rgnul.ac.in, Email: mba@rgnul.ac.in

मध्य प्रदेश मध्य क्षेत्र विद्युत वितरण कम्पनी लिमिटेड
कार्यालय महाप्रबंधक (सं.सं.) वृत्त, रायसेन, वाटनदेव सागर रोड, रायसेन (म.प्र.)-464551
ई-मेल : raisencircle@gmail.com
क्र.महा.प्र./सं.सं./क्रय/2026-27/4196

रायसेन, दिनांक : 13.07.2026

NOTICE INVITING E-TENDERS

E-tender is invites from eligible bidders for following work.

Particulars	App. Value (In. Lakh)	Tender Fees (inclusive of GST @18% (In Rs.)	Bid Submission Start & End Date	Bid Opening Date & Time
Empanelment of Agencies for new 33/11kV substation, additional/ Augmentation of PTR at existing 33/11 KV S/s, HT Lines, LT Lines, DTR, Service Line, meter related works and any other associated works as per SOR schedules in Raisen Circle of MP MKVCL	1000/- Lakh	11800/-	15.07.2026 18:00 Hrs. up to 30.07.2026 15:00 Hrs.	31.07.2026 at 17:30 Hrs.

Other details, terms and conditions are available on company website : <https://portal.mpcz.in> & <https://mptenders.gov.in> or the under signed office.
M.P. Madhyam/126870/2026

GENERAL MANAGER (O&M)

BRIEFLY

Sports ministry directs Hockey India to probe allegations

The Sports Ministry directed Hockey India to investigate allegations of intimidation and harassment levelled by former India captain Asunta Lakra and to share the outcome of the findings with the ministry.

Lakra had urged the sports ministry through an email to intervene urgently against what she described as the institutional protection of sexual harassment, intimidation and victimisation of women athletes in hockey.

Accusing HI general secretary Bhola Nath Singh of intimidating her, Lakra alleged that individuals accused of misconduct were being protected while those raising concerns were subjected to intimidation and retaliation.

"I am directed to forward the email dated July 10, 2026 received from Ms Asunta Lakra, former captain of the Indian Women's Hockey Team and a member of the Executive Board of Hockey India. She has requested the constitution of an independent enquiry into allegations of sexual harassment, institutional intimidation, and related issues concerning women athletes," the letter from the ministry official said. "It is requested that the issues raised in Ms Asunta Lakra's email may be placed before the Internal Complaints Committee (CC) constituted by Hockey India under the provisions of the Sexual Harassment of Women at Workplace (Prevention, Prohibition and Redressal) Act, 2013, for its consideration and appropriate action, and the outcome of the same may be shared with this Ministry," it further added. However, no deadline has been set for the inquiry. Asunta had raised her voice against coach Sudhir Gola, who was accused of sexually harassing female players at the Eklavya Hockey Academy in Ranchi. Gola was subsequently dismissed.



‘Winning medal in CWG will be harder than Asian Games’



India's top 400m runners believe the upcoming Commonwealth Games in Glasgow will offer sterner competition than the Asian Games later this year, making it an ideal proving ground ahead of the continental showpiece. The scaled-down Commonwealth Games begins on July 23, nearly two months before the Asian Games, and India will field a 32-member athletics squad.

Vishal Thennarasu Kayalvizhi, who will be competing in the men's 400m and mixed 4x400m relay at the CWG, said the quality of competition in Glasgow, particularly with athletes from Australia and England in the fray, would push Indian runners to raise their standards. "Commonwealth Games is hard, it's tough if we don't work. I won't say it's impossible, I will say it is possible (to win a medal) if we work out well. Nothing is easy, whether it is Asian Games or Commonwealth Games since these are big competitions.

DSA members constitute panel to conduct polls, bypassing president

PHILEM DIPAK SINGH
■ New Delhi

Factional feud erupted in Delhi Soccer Association (DSA) as majority of its members constituted a three-member ad hoc committee to run the day-to-day affairs of the organisation and hold elections in August.

The two decisions were taken in an Extraordinary General Body Meeting (EGBM) bypassing president Anuj Gupta. The EGBM held here on Sunday fixed August 30 as the date for the DSA elections DSA. It authorised the ad-hoc panel to take charge of DSA with immediate effect till an elected executive committee assumes office. Gupta, on his part, termed the move



as "illegal", claiming that "people who are not even members are trying to take over DSA".

The EGBM appointed Young Boys FC President Bharat Singh Mehra as head of the ad hoc committee with Collegian FC President Susanta Deb and Ajmal FC President Liaquat Ali as the other members.

According to the minutes of the meeting in possession of PTI, 60 members of the DSA attended the EGBM — 47 permanent council members, six

Delhi CM Rekha unveils Mayur mascot

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Tuesday unveiled the official mascot 'Mayur' for the Commonwealth Table Tennis Championship 2026 to be held in Delhi later this month. The championship will be held at the Thyagaraj Stadium from July 27 to August 2, bringing together top players from 25 Commonwealth countries. Inspired by India's national bird, the mascot reflects the spirit, heritage and vibrant identity of a nation ready to welcome the Commonwealth.

The unveiling ceremony was also attended by Delhi's Education and Sports minister Ashish Sood, Commonwealth Table Tennis

Federation president Vivek Kohli and office-bearers of the Table Tennis Federation of India, players, coaches and other guests.

Highlighting the symbolic significance of the mascot, the Chief Minister said that 'Mayur' is inspired by India's national bird and embodies energy, enthusiasm, vibrancy and positivity. She noted that the peacock's feathers beautifully incorporate the national flags of all participating countries, reflecting the spirit of Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam and the universal message of sportsmanship. Expressing pride over Delhi being chosen to host the prestigious international championship, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta said the event is a testimony to the national



capital's modern sports infrastructure, exceptional organisational capability and unwavering commitment to global sports. She said Delhi has a proven track record of successfully hosting major sporting events, from the Asian Games to the Commonwealth Games.

The chief minister said the

Vani hungry for success as she faces a strong field in 10th Leg of Hero WPGT

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Kolar (Karnataka)

Vani Kapoor headlines another strong domestic field at the 10th Leg of the Hero Women's Pro Golf Tour that begins at the Zion Hills Golf County here on Wednesday.

Vani, who staged a fine final round rally to win the ninth leg last week for her first success in 2026, tees off with the hugely talented Mannat Brar and amateur Tanishka Prithvi in the opening round. Vani will once again face a stiff challenge from the likes of three-time winner in 2026 Ridhima Dilawari, Amandeep Drall, seasoned



playing on the Ladies Access Tour in Europe. Sneha Singh, a former Hero Order of Merit winner, has been struggling of late and will look at getting back to her old form and rhythm, while Vidhatri Urs, Anvitha Narendar, Seher

Atwal and the experienced Neha Tripathi will also seek a return to their winning ways.

Hitaashee Bakshi will hope to get her clubs working the way she wants after a struggle on the Ladies European Tour, for which she wants to be ready again soon, including having a crack at the Hero Women's Indian Open. Once again the field has two sets of sisters — the Kangs — Heena and amateur Ceerat — and the Jadon sisters — Lavanya and Riya. With 57 players in the field, the organisers have once again resorted to a two tee start and the field includes nine amateurs. The last few seasons have seen amateurs make a mark on the pro circuit even before turning to the paid ranks.

Doeschate wants to be relieved from India duties

KUSHAN SARKAR ■ New Delhi

India's assistant coach Ryan ten Doeschate has expressed his intentions to be relieved off his duties even though the BCCI is keen on keeping him instead of T Dilip, whose performance has been below par over the past one year.

While ten Doeschate hasn't been released yet, the former Netherlands skipper wants to return to the IPL and has even had fruitful discussions with one franchise. It is understood that when ten Doeschate came on board following strong recommendation from head coach Gautam Gambhir (he had worked with him at KKR), he was promised the job of a specialist fielding coach but two years down the line, the

issue hasn't been sorted.

"You have (Sitanshu) Kotak as the batting coach and there's Gauti (Gambhir) himself to look after the batters. Morne (Morkel) is in charge of pacers and Sairaj (Bahutule) looks after the spinners. When Tendo (his nickname) was brought on board, he was promised fielding coach's job," a senior BCCI source privy told PTI on conditions of anonymity.

"Dilip was supposed to be removed along with Abhishek Nayar (assistant coach), Soham Desai (S&C coach) and Arun Kanade (masseur) after the 2025 Champions Trophy.

"However for Dilip, a strong recommendation came from a senior player and Dilip got a one year extension and Tendo actual-



ly didn't have any specific domain role. He is a fantastic coach, who hasn't been used because Dilip is there," the senior source added.

It will now depend on whether head coach Gambhir can convince ten Doeschate to stay back as Dilip wasn't exactly his choice for a fielding coach.

The Indian team's fielding

Teenage Croatia defender Vuskovic joins Brighton in \$60M deal



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Brighton

Teenage defender Luka Vuskovic moved between Premier League clubs on Tuesday, joining Brighton from Tottenham after playing at the World Cup for Croatia.

Brighton said the 19-year-old Vuskovic signed a five-year deal without stating the transfer fee.

British media reported the fee was 46 million pounds (\$61.5 million). One month ago Tottenham paid Brighton a reported 52 million pounds (\$69.6 million) for the Netherlands defender Jan Paul van Hecke who Vuskovic should now replace.

Vuskovic played once at the World Cup, starting in the 4-2 loss to England in their opening group-stage game. Croatia was eliminated in

the round of 32 by Portugal after a controversial call to disallow an equalizing goal deep in stoppage time.

Vuskovic's game time at Tottenham seemed blocked by the offseason signings of central defenders Van Hecke and Marcos Senesi, who was a free agent after his contract expired at Bournemouth.

Vuskovic spent last season on loan from Tottenham at Hamburger SV, where his brother Mario remains under contract serving a four-year ban in a doping case that expires in November. He won the Bundesliga's official rookie of the month award four times.

Brighton placed eighth in the Premier League last season and qualified for the third-tier Conference League, starting on August 20 in the qualifying playoffs round.

Manav-Manush combine climbs to world No. 2 in ITTF rankings

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Indian table tennis reached a milestone on Tuesday as three doubles pairs across the men's, women's, and mixed doubles entered the top 10 of the latest ITTF World Rankings.

Leading the charge are Manav Thakkar and Manush Shah, who climbed to World Number 2 in the men's doubles rankings — the highest-ever ranking achieved by an Indian pair in any doubles discipline.

In women's doubles, Diya Chitale and Yashaswini Ghorpade broke into the top 10 by reaching World No.



10, while Diya Chitale and Shah rose to World No. 5 in the mixed doubles rankings. It is the first time that India have had three

doubles pairs - one each in men's, women's and mixed doubles - simultaneously ranked inside the top 10.

The achievement highlights India's growing stature as one of the strongest doubles-playing nations with the country's partnerships consistently challenging traditional powerhouses such as China, Japan, South Korea and Chinese Taipei. The milestone also comes at a significant juncture for the sport, with doubles set to return to the Olympic programme at the Los Angeles 2028 Games, increasing the importance of the event on the international circuit.

Manchester United lands Wales goalkeeper Darlow

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Manchester

Manchester United signed veteran goalkeeper Karl Darlow on Tuesday.

United said the 35-year-old Wales international signed a contract until June 2028, with the option for another year. Darlow was Leeds' starting goalkeeper last season. He became a free agent after his contract expired.

"I am extremely proud to sign for Manchester United. I'm joining an excellent group of goalkeepers and I'm really looking forward to all pushing each other to ensure that we maintain the



highest standards, which this club demands," Darlow said. "This is a really special opportunity; everyone can see what an exciting time it is for the club and I cannot wait to play my part in supporting my teammates and helping to drive the group

forwards." United's starting goalkeeper last season was Belgium international Senne Lammens, who made a costly mistake in his nation's World Cup elimination against Spain in the quarter-finals after substituting for injured starter Thibaut Courtois.

"Karl has proven his ability to perform at the highest level, his work ethic and determined personality make him a really strong addition to our squad," United director Jason Wilcox said. "We are delighted to add a player of his quality and experience to our excellent goalkeeping group."

New Napoli coach confident he can again match Conte's standard

DANIELLA MATAR ■ Napoli

New Napoli coach Massimiliano Allegri is confident of successfully following in Antonio Conte's footsteps.

After all, he's done it before. Allegri replaced Conte at Juventus in 2014, after Conte steered the Bianconeri to three Serie A titles. Allegri went on to win five straight at Juventus as well as guiding the team to four Italian Cup titles and two Champions League finals.

Conte left Napoli in May after two years in charge, during which his team finished first and second in the Italian league. Allegri, who was fired by AC Milan at the end of the season, was confirmed as his successor at the



beginning of July and was given a three-year contract.

"I am inheriting a squad that is certainly accustomed to hard work," Allegri said on Tuesday, in his first press conference as Napoli coach. "Conte has proven his worth throughout his career. I'm lucky, this is actually the second time I've inherited

Antonio's team — let's hope it's a good omen.

"It will be important to work with seriousness and professionalism, and above all to lay the groundwork for reaching March — as I always say that's when seasons are decided — still in contention for all our objectives: Serie A, the Champions League, the

Italian Cup." Allegri was fired by Milan after what the club's owners deemed "an unequivocal failure" of a season. Despite spending much of the campaign in the top two positions and fighting for the title, a run of only two wins in Milan's last eight matches dropped it to fifth on the last day of the season.

"It's not a question of redemption; sometimes seasons just end a certain way. I'm disappointed by how things turned out last season," Allegri said. "We were in the top three from Matchday 2 through Matchday 37; we only dropped out on the first and last matchdays, and the last one is the one that counts.

"I'm disappointed because,

in all my time coaching — at Juventus and Milan — this was the first time I've finished outside the top four. And I won't deny that it's weighed on me." Milan replaced Allegri with Ruben Amorim, and at the Portuguese coach's presentation team owner Gerry Cardinale referred to him as a coach who plays to win, rather than playing not to lose. "I absolutely do not comment on the ownership's words," Allegri said. "I can only thank those who supported me all season.

"Then, unfortunately, we are sorry for the missed objectives, but another year begins, beautiful to experience, we have three competitions and we start with great enthusiasm." (AP)

Gill, Axar guide India to 6-wicket win over England in first ODI

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Birmingham

Shubman Gill continued his love affair with the Edgbaston cricket ground as the Indian captain's graceful 80 lay the foundation for a walk-in-the park six-wicket victory over England in the first ODI here on Tuesday.

India, now, have taken a 1-0 lead in the three-match series. Axar Patel, much panned for his recent low returns in T20Is, played the perfect support cast with a superb all-round show of 4/62 and an unbeaten 57 off 52 balls in what could have otherwise been a tricky chase. Chasing a perfectly gettable target of 259, the

Indian skipper mixed poise and style in equal measure before suffering from cramps, but Washington Sundar (52 no off 63 balls) and Axar successfully completed the chase in 45.2 overs with a 102-run unbroken stand after being reduced to 160 for 4.

Gill was in fine nick despite being bothered by a dodgy hamstring and calf muscle cramps which forced him to retire when the 10th ODI century seemed to be there for the taking.

This was India's first win in the ongoing tour of the United Kingdom.

Gill, who hit 11 fours and a six in his 75-ball knock got a lot of support from his inform deputy Shreyas Iyer (35)



India's Shubman Gill and Rohit Sharma during the first ODI cricket match between England and India in Birmingham, England on Tuesday

PTI during their 101-run stand for the third wicket. Just like Adelaide Oval had been a

and Edgbaston. During the Test series last year, Gill scored 269 and 161 in Indian victory here.

And now in the 50-over format, he once again showed his real class even as he was done in first by calf muscle cramps and then hamstring became an issue.

After veterans Rohit Sharma (11) and Virat Kohli (5) were dismissed cheaply with team score reading 48, Gill took charge of the proceedings. The right-hander was never overly cautious nor did he take undue risks hitting those regal on-drives and picturesque cover drives. The pulled six off Josh Tongue was a treat for the eyes.

Once he retired hurt, sud-

denly the momentum shifted in England's favour.

The set Iyer was responsible for his cross-pitch running that made him traverse an increased distance only to be run-out. KL Rahul was then beaten for pace by Tongue as he chopped one on to his stumps.

But Axar and Washington shrugged off their poor show in T20Is to maintain calm during their century stand in which they soaked in the pressure of a hostile spell from Jofra Archer, and scored against the spinners which Harry Brook played one too many. Both the batters were below par with the willow during the T20Is but the longer format gave them

time to settle down and since Gill had nullified the score-board pressure, they could score runs with consummate ease. Earlier, the seasoned Joe Root and plucky Liam Dawson scored half-centuries in a gutsy seventh wicket stand for 121 runs as England posted a respectable 258 after opting to bat.

From a solid 61 for no loss till the start of 13th over, England slumped to 107 for 6 before the end of the 22nd over and there seemed no chance of a recovery from that position.

However, Root with a run-a-ball 76, fought well alongside Dawson, whose career-best 68 off 83 balls took them to a position where bowlers

had a decent total to defend.

Root played the field, waited patiently for Bumrah to complete his first two spells and attacked Axar (4/62) and Prasidh Krishna once the pitch showed signs of easing out.

The best shot was a ramp off a Jasprit Bumrah bouncer. He hit six fours and a six in all.

While the peerless Bumrah (1/31 in 9 overs) was the best Indian bowler in terms of skills and quality on display, young Gurnoor Brar (2/61 in 9 overs) and the usually profligate Prasidh (2/50 in 10 overs) also chipped in with wickets despite going for runs.

But Axar ran through the tail after the Dawson-Root century stand.

Haryana sweeps team titles at U-23 National Wrestling Championship



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Rohtak

Hosts Haryana stamped their authority by sweeping the overall team titles in men's freestyle, Greco-Roman and women's wrestling at the U-23 National Wrestling Championships here on Tuesday. The host state topped the men's freestyle division with 200 points, the Greco-Roman category with 195 points, and the women's wrestling field with 183 points at the three-day domestic event.

Services Sports Control Board (SSCB) finished runners-up in both men's freestyle (138 points) and Greco-Roman (165 points), while Maharashtra claimed the second spot in the women's wrestling team standings with 160 points.

In the men's freestyle category, Haryana and SSCB athletes shared the major honours alongside strong performances from Punjab.

In the 74kg weight category, Narender of SSCB bagged

the gold medal after defeating Himachal Pradesh's Naveen, while Rishabh Jakhar of Punjab and Yash of Haryana completed the podium with bronze medals.

The 79kg title went to Haryana's Paras, who overcame a tough challenge from SSCB's Yash, while Priyanshu of Delhi and Vishal Kumar of Punjab locked in the bronze medals.

Sahil Dalal asserted SSCB's strength in the 86kg class by winning the gold medal over Haryana's Himanshu Antil, with Sumit Thakur of Himachal Pradesh and Anuj Tomar of Uttar Pradesh securing the bronze medals. In the heavyweight 125kg division, Jaspooran Singh of Punjab wrestled his way to a gold medal finish against Uttar Pradesh's Lakshay Kumar, while Rohit of Haryana and Rishabh Singh of Rajasthan signed off with the bronze medals.

The Greco-Roman discipline mirrored a similar battle for dominance, with Haryana and SSCB leading the charge.

Aggression, patience key to India's epic Test win: Muzumdar

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ London

Tons of patience mixed with the right amount of aggression was the key to Indian women's cricket team's epic Test win over England, said chief coach Amol Muzumdar as he lauded centurion Yastika Bhatia for her "special knock" and pacer Kranti Gaud for her "controlled line and length."

Gaud's seven-wicket match haul and Bhatia's hundred played a big role in India's historic 270-run win over England in what was the first ever women's Test played on the hallowed turf of Lord's.

"Yeah, you can say that (it was a perfect game). We batted well, we bowled



extremely well and we fielded even better, it was a good game for us," Muzumdar said during the press-conference.

"I wouldn't be able to pinpoint one particular thing... I think we were disciplined in our approach towards our batting. And disciplined in our bowling as well, sticking to the basics

of cricket. "While bowling, as I said, good line and length, controlled line and length. Aggression mixed with patience. So I think that was a key factor for this win." Bhatia's 113 off 158 in the second innings helped India set England a mammoth 457-run target. The hosts could manage just 186 in 62.5 overs. "I

think it was a special knock. Needless to say that coming at Lord's has to be a brilliant one. One which she and all the team members would remember," Muzumdar said.

"Not just that, I was really impressed with the way she has come out of the injuries. Last couple of years, she has been tormented with some major injuries.

"And the way she has defied all those things and stayed true to the game. Also, her shot selection was superb, I felt. And she paced her innings really well. So I guess it was a lovely knock to watch from outside." Gaud emerged as the Player of the match after snapping 5/37 and 2/54 in the two innings.

Sindhu sails into Japan Open second round; Satwik-Chirag pair pulls out

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Tokyo

Satwiksairaj Rankireddy's recurring shoulder problem forced him and Chirag Shetty to retire from their Japan Open opener even as P V Sindhu eased into the women's singles second round with a straight-game win over Malaysia's Wong Ling Ching here on Tuesday.

The world No.4 Indian pair, who ended a two-year title drought by winning the Singapore Open but had to withdraw from Indonesia Open last month, retired after losing the opening game 19-21 to Denmark's Daniel Lundgaard and Mads Vestergaard. Chief doubles coach Tan Kim Her said the Indian duo will be skipping

the China Open next week and focus on rehabilitation to get back to shape for the home World Championships in August.

"It still needs some time to recover. We have at least four weeks to get back in shape ahead of World Championships," Tan told PTI. Two-time Olympic-medallist Sindhu, who is currently world no. 10, produced a compact performance to notch up a 21-14 21-11 win over 37th-ranked Wong Ling Ching of Malaysia in the opening round of the BWF Super 750 event.

India's Dhruv Kapila and Tanisha Crasto too advanced to the second round after defeating Scotland's Alexander Dunn and Julie Macpherson 21-16, 21-14 in



their mixed doubles opener.

However, Rohan Kapoor and Ruthvika Shivani Gadde bowed out in the opening round after losing 11-21, 10-21 to top seeds Feng Yan Zhe and Huang Dong Ping of China.

Sindhu vs Wong: Sindhu controlled the proceedings from the outset, dictating the pace of the rallies to open up a 7-4 lead. Although Wong attempted to stay in touch, her unforced errors

allowed the Indian to steadily pull away and take an 11-6 advantage at the mid-game interval.

The Indian ace looked comfortable in the rallies, mixing up her strokes effec-

tively to extend her lead to 14-9. Her backhand net dribbles, deft drops and well-disguised half-smashes came off with precision.

While there were stray errors, including a long toss and a wide cross-court net shot from the Indian, Wong failed to make the most of those opportunities.

A straight smash earned Sindhu seven game points, and she wrapped up the opening game in the second attempt. Sindhu resumed in similar fashion after the change of ends, racing to an 8-2 lead before taking an 11-3 cushion at the interval.

The gap only widened thereafter as Wong continued to struggle with her accuracy, allowing Sindhu to surge to a 16-5 lead.

Swiss veteran Yann Sommer joins Club Brugge on a 3-year deal

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Brugge (Belgium)

Swiss goalkeeper Yann Sommer signed up for Champions League soccer with Club Brugge on Tuesday after three seasons and two Serie A titles with Inter Milan.

Brugge said it gave the 37-year-old Sommer a three-year contract as a free agent. He will replace veteran Simon Mignolet, who retired in May aged 38 after helping Brugge win the Belgian league. Sommer will return to the Champions League after helping Inter reach the final in 2025, when it lost 5-0 to



Paris Saint-Germain. Inter was stunningly eliminated by Bodø/Glimt last season in the knockout playoffs round.

Sommer has won league titles with Inter, Bayern Munich and in Switzerland with Basel, where he started

his career. He played 94 times for Switzerland and went to each World Cup from 2014 to 2022. Sommer retired from the national team after a quarterfinals loss to England at the 2024 European Championship.

Devajit appointed Chairman of ICC Governance Committee

TONY DAS
■ Guwahati

The Board of Control for Cricket in India (BCCI) Honorary Secretary Devajit Saikia has been appointed Chairman of the International Cricket Council (ICC) Governance Committee reflecting a proud moment for Assam and the country.

Devajit Saikia was recently seen at the iconic Lord's Cricket Ground in London, alongside ICC Chairman Jay Shah and cricket legend Sachin Tendulkar.

Devajit Saikia credited ICC Chairman Jay Shah's visionary leadership for transforming women's cricket in India through landmark initiatives such as pay parity for central-



Jay Shah, Chairman ICC, Devajit Lon Saikia, Secretary BCCI, Sachin Tendulkar, eminent cricketer at Marylebone Cricket Club ground Lords

ly contracted women cricketers, enhanced domestic match fees and the launch of the Women's Premier

League. Saikia congratulated the Indian Women's Cricket Team on scripting history

with a memorable 270-run victory over England in the one-off Test at Lord's Cricket Ground.

New Zealand beats West Indies by 5 wickets in 2nd ODI

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Providence (Guyana)

Left-arm spinner Jayden Lennox took 5-19 as West Indies collapsed from 63-0 to be all out for 138 and New Zealand went on to win the second one-day cricket international by five wickets.

New Zealand faced a difficult chase on a sharply turning pitch and was 96-5 before Tom Latham made 37 in an unbroken partnership with Mark Bracewell to guide New Zealand to its target

with 104 balls remaining on Monday. New Zealand's 400th win in one-day internationals leveled the five-match series at 1-1 after West Indies won the first match by seven wickets. Lennox claimed his first five-wicket total in his seventh one-day international after a belated international debut at 31 and his figures from eight overs were the third-best by a New Zealand spinner in ODIs.

He set in motion a collapse which saw the West Indies lose all 10 wickets for 65 runs



after a solid opening stand between John Campbell (43) and Akeem August (18).

Lennox shared with Mitchell Santner the key

wickets of Keacy Carti who made 95 and captain Shai Hope who made an unbeaten 87 in a partnership of 131 runs in the first match on

Saturday. Santner bowled Carty for 18 with a ball which pitched on middle and turned sharply to beat the bat while Lennox bowled Hope for 7 with a ball that pitched on middle and leg and straightened past the inside edge. Amir Jangoo's 24 was the only other major contribution for West Indies which lost its last five wickets in 10 overs. Henry Nicholls (17) and Will Young (28) gave New Zealand a brisk start, putting on 35 for the first wicket at almost five runs per over.

'Lord's success strengthens case for more women's red-ball cricket'

HIMANK NEGI ■ New Delhi

India's emphatic 270-run victory over England in the first-ever women's Test at Lord's in London has strengthened the case for expanding red-ball cricket in the women's game, former India captain Shantha Rangaswamy said, urging the BCCI to revive longer-format domestic competitions across age groups.

The Indian women's team



produced one of the finest victories in its history as Yastika Bhatia struck a memorable century at the 'home of cricket', while Kranti Gaud claimed a five-wicket haul to enter the Lord's honours

board. Off-spinner Sneha Rana then sealed the win with four wickets in the second innings. "I think this is the best thing that could have happened for Indian women's cricket. Playing at Lord's for the first time ever, in their first Test there, and India wins," Rangaswamy told PTI in an interview. "India, in fact, demolishes England by a huge margin of 270 runs and two of them make it to the honours board. (PTI)